

Fire & Life Safety: A State of the Market

A Buy-Side Assessment for Acquirers · Published 10 August 2026



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SPONSOR-BACKED US FIRE CONTRACTING PLATFORMS AT PLATFORM LEVEL, AGAINST THE THIRTY-ODD A BLENDED TRACKER REPORTS

63%

OF FIRE PROTECTION SYSTEMS CURRENT ON THEIR ANNUAL INSPECTION IN ONE ACTIVELY ENFORCED JURISDICTION

\$3-\$4

OF REPAIR AND SERVICE WORK FOUND PER \$1 OF INSPECTION REVENUE, ON THE ACQUIRER'S OWN DISCLOSURE

Sprinkler and suppression · alarm , detection and monitoring · extinguisher , kitchen and special hazard .



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SMBX.AI · BUY-SIDE CORPORATE DEVELOPMENT

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

- **Inspection is bought for the work it finds , and that is the one growth lever here a buyer can test from a target's own records before signing .** A technician standing in a mechanical room with a tag gun and a code obligation generates a second , larger , higher-margin revenue stream nobody else is positioned to win . The largest filer in the industry puts it at "\$3 – \$4 of incremental service work generated annually for every \$1 of inspection work" (APi Group investor day , 2025-05-21) , restated on the record nine months later (Q4 2025 earnings call , 2026-02-25) . The slide's own footnote bounds it : a leadership estimate for US inspection revenues that excludes purely route-based service revenue , primarily portable extinguishers . It is the widest available definition , so read it as the ceiling rather than the base case .
- **The demand underneath it is written into law , and the law names the interval .** A private consensus standard becomes an enforceable bill through three links — a jurisdiction adopts a model code , the model code references the standard , and the code's referenced-standards chapter freezes the edition . What follows is a dated , repeating , licensed obligation that attaches to the owner and runs for as long as the system exists .
- **The mandate is real . Capture of it is not .** In an actively enforced city running mandatory electronic inspection reporting , 1 , 933 of 2 , 083 fire protection systems were found compliant — and only **1 , 313 , or 63% , were current on their annual inspection** (City of Rockville , 2024-01-31) . That is the bear case on the annuity and the bull case on the opportunity in one figure , and **no published source establishes the equivalent nationally .**
- **The competitive set is 17 , not thirty-odd .** US fire and life-safety service contractors under a live private-equity sponsor number **17** at platform level . A further **5** security-led integrators carry fire , **3** are manufacturers under sponsors , **8** are permanent-capital or family holders with no exit clock , and **5** have already been absorbed . Registers that blend those classes overstate both the buyers a bidder meets and the assets that will come to market .
- **There is no published size for this market , and this report does not manufacture one .** One sub-vertical separates cleanly from a primary government table : building sprinkler system installation contracting at **\$12 , 018 , 607 thousand** of value of business done (Census EC2223K0B , variable CONKB , code 8221 , 2022) , a distinct code from lawn sprinkler . Alarm and detection has a **ceiling and no size** , because both instruments fuse fire with burglar at the definition level . Extinguisher , kitchen and special hazard has **no revenue denominator at all** , and what replaces it is a count of legally obligated sites : **737 , 325** commercial and institutional kitchens , and a portable extinguisher base of **8 , 570 , 933 to 24 , 105 , 750** units against a codified maximum floor area per unit .
- **The recurring revenue may not travel with the deal .** Three executed inspection agreements obtained in full are structurally incompatible : a contractor's own form runs 60 months with automatic renewal and an explicit right to assign ; an owner's form is terminable on 45 days by either party and may not be assigned without consent ; a municipal vehicle is a rate-card purchase order cancellable in 30 days "for any reason whatsoever . " **The best-named logos are the ones least likely to convey .** No fire contractor discloses a renewal , retention or attrition rate on an inspection book , and there is no fire or life-safety-services S-1 in EDGAR , so the document that would normally settle it does not exist .
- **The spread the roll-up thesis rests on cannot be tracked , and the multiple the industry quotes was never paid .** The only small-end benchmark is industry-agnostic : **6 . 4x** enterprise value to operating earnings for \$10–25M enterprise values , year-to-date 2025 , on **2 , 084** observations (GF Data , Q3 2025) . Against it , the one disclosed figure at the small end of US fire and life safety is a single acquirer's ceiling on its own

add-on programme . That licenses 0 . 4 to 0 . 7 turns of entry advantage and no more ; measured inside one methodology the premium for size is **≈1 . 24x to 1 . 61x** . Meanwhile the valuation range the whole sector repeats traces to one 2024 trade report of prospective bids on a business that did not sell .

- **The insurance-pressure thesis currently cuts the other way , and the licence is the moat nobody prices .** Global commercial property rates fell **12%** in Q2 2026 after 9% declines in each of the two preceding quarters , with US commercial property down **13%** (Marsh , 2026-07-22) , and **no carrier or broker publication establishes a quantified premium differential for sprinklered versus unsprinklered commercial risk** . Separately , most states license the firm through a **named individual** who , in a lower-middle-market deal , is often the seller — a regime that protects an incumbent's margin and can strand the book at close . Build the licence register before the synergy model .
- **The best diligence question in this market is about a building somebody else owns .** Whether a target owns its listed central station , and if not whose paper its recurring revenue sits on , is worth roughly ten turns of recurring monthly revenue at the market level and carries the change-of-control exposure that decides whether the book conveys at all .

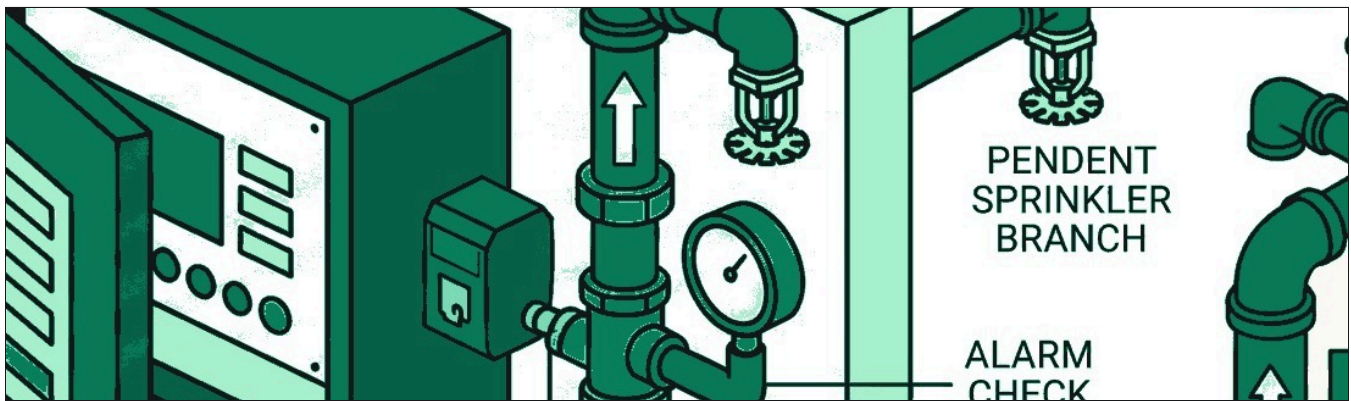
PART I — THE MANDATE

Every commercial building in the United States carrying a fire protection system also carries a continuing legal duty to inspect, test and maintain it. The duty does not arise from insurance, tenant demand or trade-association membership. It arises from the fire code the local Authority Having Jurisdiction has adopted, it attaches to the owner, and it runs for as long as the system exists. That obligation — not construction volume, not fire loss, not insurance pressure — is what makes this revenue recur.

The obligation can be traced, jurisdiction by jurisdiction, to a numbered section of enforceable law. What is not established anywhere in the public record is the share of it actually being met under contract with a third party. **Those two facts — a hard mandate and an unmeasured capture rate — are the whole investment case and the whole risk in one sentence.**

Three sub-verticals are referred to throughout, because they are underwritten differently: **sprinkler and suppression contracting**; **alarm, detection, monitoring and low-voltage life safety**; and **extinguisher, kitchen, clean agent and industrial special hazard**. Inspection, testing and maintenance is abbreviated to ITM where the phrase would otherwise repeat.

1.1 The chain of obligation



A building owner is never bound by "NFPA 25." The owner is bound by the edition of NFPA 25 the Authority Having Jurisdiction has adopted, and that arrives through three links: a state — or, in home-rule states, a municipality — adopts the ICC International Fire Code or the NFPA 1 and NFPA 101 family by statute or administrative rule; that model code mandates inspection, testing and maintenance **by reference** rather than by restating it, at **IFC Section 901.6** and **Table 901.6.1** or at **NFPA 1 Chapter 13**; and the referenced standard's edition is then fixed by the model code's **Chapter 80** list rather than by whatever the standards body has most recently published.

The load-bearing wording, in the version an acquirer is most likely to meet in a dense urban route: the NYC Fire Code (2022) at **FC 901.6** requires that "Fire protection systems shall be maintained in good working order at all times," with systems not in working order to be "repaired or replaced as necessary." **FC 901.6.1** routes to the standards listed in **FC Table 901.6.1**, which maps extinguishers to NFPA 10, sprinklers to NFPA 25, alarm to NFPA 72 and carbon dioxide to NFPA 12 (NYC FC Chapter 9, FDNY).

Two features carry the commercial weight. It is an affirmative and continuing duty to *maintain*, not a duty to inspect — inspection is how the owner demonstrates the duty is met. And the duty is discharged only by performing what the referenced standard requires at the interval it sets, **so scope is fixed by a private consensus document the owner never adopted and cannot negotiate.**

The edition freeze makes the third link commercially real . Jurisdictions adopting the 2024 editions of the IBC , IFC , NFPA 1 or NFPA 101 "will also begin enforcing the latest versions of several critical fire protection standards , including but not limited to" NFPA 13-2022 , NFPA 20-2022 , NFPA 14-2024 , NFPA 72-2022 and NFPA 25-2023 (NFSA , 2025-07-02) . The annuity is therefore a function of the *adopted* edition . Route density and revenue per site in Maryland , on NFPA 1-2024 and therefore NFPA 25-2023 , is not the same obligation set as in a jurisdiction whose fire marshal guidance still cites NFPA 25 at its 2011 edition . **A diligence model that prices scope off the current edition prices a market that does not exist yet in most of the country .**

One further hook connects two sub-verticals structurally . **IFC Section 903 . 4** requires valves controlling the water supply for automatic sprinkler systems to be supervised by a listed fire alarm control unit , and where IFC 903 . 4 and NFPA 13 conflict , the IFC controls (NFSA , 2023-02-03) . That single section forces a monitored alarm panel onto sprinklered commercial stock , converting a one-time sprinkler installation into a recurring monitoring line .

1.2 What the code requires, by system and interval

The table below carries the intervals that generate a contractor visit and marks the work an owner may lawfully perform in-house . Section numbers move between editions — the NFPA 25 valve chapters sit at 13 . x in the 2011 edition against component chapters at 5 . x , 6 . x , 8 . x and 14 . x in 2020 and 2023 — so each interval should be re-checked against the edition actually adopted in a target's footprint .

SYSTEM	INTERVAL	SCOPE OF THE VISIT	PERFORMED BY
Water-based (NFPA 25)	Weekly · monthly	Gauges on dry pipe , preaction and deluge ; control valves secured with seals only ; fire pump casing and relief valves ; monthly gauges on wet pipe and control valves locked or supervised	Owner-performable
	Weekly / monthly	Fire pump no-flow (churn) test — conflict , carried below	—
	Quarterly	Waterflow alarm devices ; fire department connections ; sprinkler pressure-reducing valves ; hydraulic nameplates ; main drain test where a backflow preventer or reducing valve sits on the riser	Contractor
	Semiannual	Waterflow and valve tamper switches ; tank level alarms . The 2026 edition adds a three-option semiannual dry and preaction waterflow test , including automated testing	Contractor
	Annual	Floor-level sprinkler , pipe , hanger , bracing , signage and spare-cabinet inspection ; main drain test at each riser ; antifreeze concentration ; dry pipe valve partial trip test ; preaction and deluge trip test at full flow with interior cleaning ; control valve full-range operation ; hose valves ; backflow preventer forward-flow test ; fire pump full-flow test at churn , 100% and 150% of rated capacity	Contractor
	Every 3 years	Dry pipe and preaction valve full-flow trip test ; occupant-use hose service test after the first 5 years	Contractor
	Every 5 years	Internal pipe assessment for corrosion , scale and obstruction ; check valve internal inspection ; gauges replaced or calibrated ; standpipe flow test at the hydraulically most remote outlet ; manual standpipe hydrostatic test ; pressure-reducing valve full-flow test ; private fire service main flow test	Contractor
	Long cycle	Sprinkler sample testing — 50 years standard response , 25 or 20 years fast response , 20 years ESFR , CMSA and dry , 5 years harsh environment . A replacement-driving event , not an inspection	Contractor

SYSTEM	INTERVAL	SCOPE OF THE VISIT	PERFORMED BY
Alarm and detection (NFPA 72)	Semiannual inspect · annual test	Control unit and trouble signals; annunciators; initiating devices; notification appliances; interface devices for elevator recall, HVAC shutdown and door release; duct detectors with airflow verification; supervising-station transmitter ; emergency voice with intelligibility verification	Contractor for annual testing; semiannual visual owner-performable with documented training
	Quarterly	Waterflow switch testing	Contractor
	Long cycle	Smoke detector sensitivity within 1 year of installation then alternate years, extendable to 5 after two consecutive passes; non-restorable fixed-temperature heat detectors replaced or laboratory-tested every 15 years ; restorable heat detectors, 2 or 20% per circuit annually and all within 5 years ; sealed lead-acid batteries replaced every 4 years	Contractor
Extinguishers (NFPA 10)	Monthly , at 30-day intervals	Visual inspection, initials and date on the tag	Owner-performed ; the 2026 edition permits electronic monitoring in lieu
	Annual · 6 years · 5 or 12 years	Maintenance by a trained technician with new tamper seals; six-year internal examination with a durable metallic label applied by a heatless process; hydrostatic test at 5 years for pressurized water, water mist, CO ₂ and wet chemical, 12 years for standard dry chemical and halogenated agent, with non-rechargeable units removed from service at 12 years	Contractor
Kitchen (NFPA 96, NFPA 17A)	Monthly solid fuel · quarterly high volume · semiannual moderate volume · annual low volume	Exhaust inspected for grease buildup by a trained, qualified and certified person; cleaning triggered where grease exceeds the depth thresholds	Contractor
	Semiannual	Wet-chemical suppression maintenance by a certified person; fusible link replacement	Contractor
Special hazard (NFPA 2001, 17, 12, 12A)	Monthly · semiannual · annual · 5 and 12 years	Clean agent monthly visual, semiannual container weigh, annual functional test of detection, releasing panel and supervisory circuits, 5-year cylinder hydrostatic per 49 CFR §180.205, and enclosure integrity to ASTM E2174 verifying the 10-minute hold time ; dry and wet chemical semiannual maintenance with 12-year container and hose hydrostatic test; carbon dioxide and halon semiannual weighing and container retest	Monthly usually owner-performed; the rest contractor

Water-based intervals are cited to NFPA 25 (2011) except where the 2023 and 2026 editions are named; alarm to NFPA 72-2010 as reproduced by the Minnesota Department of Health (June 2016), corroborated for 2019 and later by UpToCode; extinguisher to NFPA 10 (2010); kitchen to NFPA 96 (2024 and 2011), NFPA 17A (2009) and IFC §609.3.3.1 (2015); special hazard to NFPA 2001 (2022 and 2008), NFPA 17 (2009), NFPA 12 (2011) and NFPA 12A (2009). Supervising-station path supervision sets the monitoring layer's own cadence: a **single** communications path must be timer-tested at intervals not exceeding **60 minutes**, and **multiple** paths at intervals not exceeding **6 hours** (NFSA, 2023-02-03).

Two live conflicts, carried rather than resolved. On the fire pump no-flow test, one trade source working from the 2023 edition reports electric pumps monthly and diesel weekly (Ironsmith Fire, 2026-06-12), while the hospital schedule published by the health-engineering society, citing NFPA 25-1998 and 2011, reports weekly generally with monthly permitted under a CMS waiver (ASHE, 2014). Both stand; **the weekly obligation generates the larger route-labour requirement and binds in any jurisdiction still enforcing a pre-2017 edition.** On sprinkler sample testing, the trade association reading the 2023 edition gives **25 years** for fast response other than ESFR and CMSA (NFSA, 2023-08-17) while a contractor matrix on the 2011 edition gives **20 years** (Getz Fire, 2020-09). Both stand; the 20-year trigger binds in pre-2020 jurisdictions. Commercially the reading is the same either way — **the trigger is arriving now for buildings sprinklered in the 2000-2006 construction wave, and it produces replacement work rather than inspection work.**

A third conflict decides how a hood interval is billed. Three sources place the cooking-volume schedule in three locations across the 2011, 2021 and 2024 editions of NFPA 96, and all three are carried. The material disagreement is whether Table 12.4 is an inspection schedule with cleaning as a separate event on a separate trigger, or a flat six-month cleaning frequency extendable to twelve with documented minimal grease production and approval by the Authority Having Jurisdiction. The inspection-and-cleaning split is the correct reading of the standard's structure; the IFC counterpart and most enforcement practice treat the interval as a service-visit cadence, and hood-cleaning contractors bill it that way. **Revenue models should follow enforcement practice and diligence should follow the standard.**

The split between owner-performed and contractor-performed work determines how much of the mandate is contractable. No jurisdiction examined bars in-house work outright. The pattern is a split by task: owner and facility staff may perform the monthly and semiannual *visual* work, while annual functional testing, dry-pipe trip tests, sensitivity testing, fire pump flow tests and all suppression-system maintenance require a licensed or certified contractor. **The contracted annuity concentrates in the annual and semiannual visits, and revenue-per-site models built off total code intervals will overstate the contractable share.**

1.3 Who is permitted to perform the work

Licensing is set state by state and the mechanics differ materially. New York City requires supervision by a **Certificate of Fitness holder** for sprinkler, standpipe, foam, alarm and hydrant systems (FC 901.6.3), with detailed **monthly** standpipe and sprinkler reports completed by that holder and **posted near the main water supply control valve** (FC 901.6.2.1). Iowa requires a **contractor licence plus technician and technician-trainee licences** with endorsements by system type, and the contractor must name a **responsible managing employee** holding a current qualifying certification. Washington runs a four-level State Fire Marshal certificate in which **Level U requires NICET ASSL Level III**, with a separate contractor registration. California makes **C-16 Fire Protection Contractor** a standalone licensing-board classification and requires a **Fire Sprinkler Fitter Certification** for C-16 qualifiers and journey-level personnel on water-based systems in commercial or multi-family dwellings (CSLB Industry Bulletin 24-02, 2024-05-10). Utah requires a **certificate of registration** for annual sprinkler, standpipe and fire pump inspection. Maryland licenses sprinkler contractors in **eight classes** expiring two years after issue; Texas runs **separate regimes for extinguisher, alarm and sprinkler firms**; South Carolina licenses through its Contractor's Licensing Board. Minnesota permits facility staff to perform visual valve and gauge inspection and, with training, waterflow alarms, while requiring a licensed contractor for sprinkler heads, dry-pipe trip testing and most maintenance. At the standards layer, NFPA 96 (2024) requires work "by a properly trained, qualified, and **certified** person(s)" and NFPA 25 (2026) requires personnel "qualified...for the specific tasks performed," letting the Authority Having Jurisdiction set standards **by task type** rather than uniformly.

Two buy-side consequences follow . First , the licence is frequently attached to a **named individual** rather than to the entity — Iowa's responsible managing employee , Washington's Level U holder , California's C-16 qualifier — and in a lower-middle-market acquisition that person is often the seller . Whether the qualifying licence survives a change of control , and on what timetable a replacement must be seated , is a question for **regulatory counsel licensed in each state of operation** : ask whether the licence transfers , what notice the state fire marshal or licensing board requires on a change of control or of qualifier , and what the cure period is before work must stop . **Answer it before signing** .

Second , the task-based split means a target's headcount mix , not its site count , determines how much of the obligated work it can bill . Certification counts by discipline are the practical constraint on route expansion , and **no national count of certification holders by discipline is published** .

1.4 Enforcement mechanics — the ITM-to-repair pull-through

A failed inspection compels a repair through three separate mechanisms , and knowing which is operating in a target's territory is what turns a pull-through claim into something testable .

The base code obligation . The IFC and the NYC Fire Code at 901 . 6 require systems to be maintained in good working order at all times and , where they are not , "repaired or replaced as necessary . " The duty is affirmative and continuing , so a documented deficiency is a documented violation until corrected .

The reporting loop . Third-party electronic reporting removes the owner's ability to hold a deficiency privately . The dominant platform is The Compliance Engine , operated by BRYCER LLC , which states it is trusted by over **1 , 420 Authorities Having Jurisdiction** (BRYCER , the platform's operator) . Named mandates :

JURISDICTION	MANDATE	EFFECTIVE	MECHANICS
San Diego , CA	All providers who inspect , install , test and repair fire protection systems in the city must register and submit all reports through the platform ; 14 system types covered	2020-04-15	The provider pays a filing fee per report , none on repair reports . Deficiency reports must be resubmitted with corrective-action documentation within 14 days of rejection
Raleigh , NC	All compliant and non-compliant systems reported electronically	2015-11-01 , Ordinance 2015-492	—
Vancouver , WA	Results submitted through the fire department online system within 30 days of the service date ; repairs completed within 30 days may be combined with the inspection report , otherwise uploaded within 30 days of completion	Ordinance M-4485 § 27 , 2024	VMC 16 . 04 . 166 , an explicit local addition to IFC 901 . 6
Seattle , WA	Testing reports submitted online ; the central station must be notified to place the alarm system in test mode	—	A \$35 filing fee per system type per year , hood systems per six-month service ; reports due within seven calendar days ; \$12 late fee per report

Federal payment leverage in healthcare . CMS ties Life Safety Code deficiencies to an escalating ladder : initial citation usually at scope and severity D , E or F minimum , **denial of payment for new admissions required at 3 months** where substantial compliance is not achieved , and **termination from Medicare required at 6 months** , with civil monetary penalties where noncompliance is serious . CMS stated it "does not have authority to allow extensions of the August 13 , 2013 deadline" (CMS S&C-13-55-LSC , 2013-08-16) .

Records are the enforcement substrate . IFC §901 . 6 . 3 and §110 . 3 require records available to the fire code official ; NFPA 25 §§4 . 3-4 . 3 . 5 (2020) set a minimum three-year retention on site , with the practical rule of keeping each record one year past the next occurrence of that type — which makes five-year-cycle records an

effective six years . Where the fire code and NFPA 25 differ on retention , **the fire code controls** (NFSA , 2025-11-06) .

The diligence question all of this produces is precise and testable : repair revenue divided by inspection revenue , split between jurisdictions with mandatory electronic reporting and those without . A target operating in electronic-reporting jurisdictions should show materially higher repair attach than one on paper reports . If it does not , the gap is either an operational failure or an indication that the inspection base is smaller than represented .

1.5 The mandate is real; capture of it is not

The evidence that the obligation is being met is thin , single-jurisdiction and in part published by the reporting platform's own operator — and the two instrumented jurisdictions report figures that look contradictory until the metrics are separated .

Burlington , Vermont reports **686 systems actively tracked , with 89% in full compliance** , published by the platform's operator (BRYCER) ; the complement is **11% , or about 75 systems** . Rockville , Maryland reports **2 , 083 fire protection systems** , of which **1 , 933 (90%) were found compliant** and **1 , 313 (63%) are current on annual inspections** (City of Rockville , 2024-01-31) . The two cities agree closely on systems found compliant , at 89% and 90% . They part company on the measure that generates contractor revenue : **currency on the annual inspection , where Rockville is at 63%** . Those are different metrics , not conflicting estimates , and the gap between them inside a single city is the finding . Alongside both , the reporting operator attributes **32% of false alarms** to systems not compliant with ITM requirements .

The bear reading . In the jurisdictions that have gone to the trouble of mandating electronic reporting — the most instrumented , most enforced condition available — roughly nine systems in ten are already accounted for on the compliance measure . If that is representative , the incremental opportunity is not a vast pool of untouched buildings ; it is share taken from incumbents who already hold the work , in a market whose largest disclosed participant describes its markets as "local in nature and highly fragmented" (Cintas FY2025 10-K) . Growth then comes from route density , price and repair attach rather than from converting the unserved .

The bull reading . In that same actively enforced city , more than a third of legally inspectable systems were not current on an annual inspection . That is the largest measured pool of latent , legally owed , uncaptured demand anywhere in the record , and it sits in a jurisdiction chosen for enforcement rather than neglect . Nothing establishes the rate in the 2012-IFC states , in jurisdictions with no reporting mandate , or in the owner-performed tiers where the only evidence of compliance is initials on a tag . Two structural leaks a compliance percentage does not capture : owners may lawfully perform the monthly and semiannual visual work themselves , and the largest disclosed operator names in-housing as a live competitive alternative — "[b]usinesses may decide to perform certain services **in-house** instead of outsourcing these services" (Cintas FY2025 10-K) .

No published source establishes the national share of legally inspectable fire protection systems that are current on their required inspection , testing and maintenance . That absence is itself the most important finding this market has to offer about itself . It means the top-down compliance-gap pitch cannot be sourced , and the only defensible route to a capture estimate runs bottom-up through a target's own book : obligated systems per site , visits per system per year , and the proportion of those visits invoiced . **That is a data-room exercise , and it is the exercise that should decide the price** .

One further trap sits in the vocabulary . Inspection currency , outstanding deficiency and code violation are three different states , and the industry uses the words interchangeably . **A deficiency rate presented in a confidential information memorandum means nothing until the seller specifies which of the three is being**

counted. For reference , Buncombe County , NC reported 12–15% of systems out of compliance or carrying an outstanding deficiency before adopting a reporting programme in July 2024 and 2% or less afterwards , and third-party reporting itself "is utilized in at least 37 states" (NFSA , 2018-12-05).

1.6 Adopted editions, and the adoption lag

Two published counts of the code-family split exist and they disagree . One tracker gives 33 states IFC , 11 states NFPA , 3 state-specific and 4 local-only (PlainFireData) . The ICC's own Master I-Code Adoption Chart of January 2024 lists 43 jurisdictions with a statewide IFC edition and 15 flagged as local-only , with overlap where a state has both a statewide code and local adoption authority . The two classify Indiana , Iowa , Louisiana , Massachusetts and Michigan inconsistently . The ICC chart is the sounder instrument for the IFC column because it is the ICC's own tracking and carries edition years ; several states genuinely run both families at once .

IFC EDITION ADOPTED STATEWIDE	STATES
2021	AL , AK , AR , CA , CT , DE , FL , LA , MD , MT , NV , NJ , NC , ND , OR , SC , SD , UT , VA , WY
2018	AZ , GA , HI , ID , MN , MS , NE , NH , NY , OK , PA , RI , WA , WV
2015	DC , ME , MA , MI , NM , OH , WI
2012	TN , TX
Local adoption only	CO , IL , IN , IA , KS , KY , MO , NV , NJ , NM , OK , TX , VT , WA , WY

States appear in both a statewide row and the local-only column where the statewide code is a floor and home-rule municipalities adopt independently . **Texas and Tennessee , on the 2012 IFC , are the extreme lag cases in the chart** , and Texas is a large market .

The named adoption instruments show how varied the machinery is . Florida sits on NFPA 1 and NFPA 101 in their Florida 2021 Editions under F . A . C . 69A-60 . 003 and 69A-60 . 004 , effective 2023-12-31 , with a rule hearing on the 9th Edition scheduled for **2026-07-14** . Maryland moved to **NFPA 1 , 2024 edition** on **2025-06-23** . Massachusetts runs NFPA 1 , 2021 edition with state amendments under 527 CMR 1 . 00 . Illinois adopted NFPA 101 , 2015 edition , effective 2020-01-01 , replacing the 2000 edition . California published the **2025 California Fire Code** , based on the 2024 IFC , on 2025-07-01 with effect from **2026-01-01** . Ohio's fire code rule text took effect **2025-11-20** . Two entries matter more than the rest : **Utah amends the NFPA 25 frequency table directly in state administrative code (R710-5-7)** , so the standard as published is not the standard as enforced ; and a Montana fire district moved from the 2012 IFC to the 2021 IFC by board resolution on its own clock with a hard cutover date of 2023-04-12 . **Adoption is not a state-level variable everywhere .**

The Chapter 80 reference list is the hinge of the whole chain and it is not freely published . Two pieces of direct evidence exist . Central Valley Fire District , on the 2021 IFC , lists its adopted referenced standards as NFPA 10 (2021) , NFPA 13 (2019) , NFPA 25 (2020) and NFPA 72 (2019) ; the 2021 IFC was published in 2020 , so an NFPA 10-2021 reference inside it is chronologically implausible and the district has more likely listed the editions it enforces rather than Chapter 80's list verbatim . For the 2024 family the trade association gives NFPA 13-2022 , NFPA 14-2024 , NFPA 20-2022 , NFPA 25-2023 and NFPA 72-2022 (NFSA , 2025-07-02) . **Adoption must therefore be confirmed jurisdiction by jurisdiction against the administrative code and the adopted Chapter 80 list . This is a legal determination rather than a research task :** engage regulatory counsel or a code consultant licensed in each state in the target's footprint and ask for two things in writing — the citation and effective date of the currently adopted fire code , and the specific editions of NFPA 25 , 72 , 10 and 96 its referenced-standards list freezes .

STANDARD	CURRENT EDITION	EXAMPLE ADOPTED EDITION	LAG
NFPA 25	2026	2011 (Minnesota State Fire Marshal guidance) · 2020 (any 2021-IFC jurisdiction) · 2023 (Maryland)	15 years · 6 · 3
NFPA 72	2025	2019 (2021-IFC jurisdiction) · 2016 (Seattle FD guidance) · 1999 (CMS and hospital baseline)	6 · 9 · 26 years
NFPA 96 · NFPA 10	2024 · 2026	2017, or 2021 where most AHJs sit, · 2010 (MN DOH), 2021 (Central Valley FD)	3–7 years · up to 16
IFC	2024	2012 (Texas, Tennessee per the ICC chart)	12 years, 4 cycles

Minnesota illustrates why the chain must be traced to the end rather than to the model code: the ICC chart shows the 2018 IFC, while the state fire marshal's own page states "the 2011 edition of NFPA 25." Both are published; they describe different links in the same chain, **and the enforced obligation is the one the fire marshal names**. A model that prices scope off the current edition will overstate it in Texas, Tennessee, Ohio, Michigan, Maine, New Mexico, Wisconsin and the District of Columbia, and understate the rate of future scope expansion in the fast-cadence states.

1.7 Dated forcing functions

Retroactive mandates, and their ITM residue. New York City's **Local Law 26 of 2004** required office buildings 100 ft or more in height to be fully sprinklered and certified by **2019-07-01**, on a ladder running through an owner's affidavit in 2005 and seven- and fourteen-year reports. Chicago's Municipal Code 13-196-205 required every existing building above **80 feet** to be sprinklered throughout on a phase-in of one-third of gross square footage by 2009-01-01, two-thirds by 2013-01-01 and **100% by 2017-01-01**, with landmark and open-air exceptions routed instead to a life safety evaluation. Nationwide, all Medicare and Medicaid-participating nursing homes were required to be **fully sprinklered as of 2013-08-13** under what is now 42 CFR 483.90, cited at tag K056.

Both municipal programmes are expired as installation demand. **Their commercial residue is the resulting ITM base** — a 2005–2019 retrofit wave now entering the 20-to-25-year fast-response sample-test window and the five-year gauge and valve replacement cycle. That is replacement and repair revenue on an installed base whose sprinkler dates are a matter of public record in two of the densest route markets in the country.

Standard-driven events already dated, all in NFPA 25 (2026): residential sprinklers in place **50 years** must be replaced with fast-response models or tested to confirm a thermal response index no greater than $65 (m \cdot s)^{1/2}$; escutcheons and cover plates on recessed and concealed sprinklers must be replaced for damage, corrosion, loading, non-manufacturer paint or adhered covers, **converting a visual finding into a parts-and-labour ticket on every annual visit**; abandoned systems must be physically removed or disabled and distinctly marked, with ice in piping defined as an impairment and the spare cabinet list extended to K-factor, temperature rating, wrench model and quantity by type; corrosion-mitigation systems such as nitrogen generators must be maintained to manufacturer specification or the system requires recalculation, **pulling nitrogen inerting into the ITM contract**; and the new semiannual dry and preaction waterflow test adds a visit or opens an automated-monitoring substitute.

Adoption dates already on the calendar. Florida's 9th Edition rule hearing was scheduled for 2026-07-14; the 2025 California Fire Code takes effect 2026-01-01; Maryland moved to NFPA 1-2024 on 2025-06-23; the Ohio Fire Code rule text took effect 2025-11-20. **Each is a dated scope change for every route operating in the state concerned, and each is knowable in advance**.

1.8 What is shrinking or reversing

A retroactive mandate was re-timed, and the re-timing is more instructive than a deletion would have been. Maryland's adoption of the NFPA 1 and NFPA 101 2024 editions, effective 2025-06-23, retains the high-rise retrofit obligation and changes the clock that runs it. The amendment replaces a fixed statutory deadline with "within 12 years of the date of the original violation notice issued by the fire authority having jurisdiction", and the replacement text for NFPA 1 §13.3.2.24.2 requires existing high-rise buildings to be "protected throughout by an approved automatic sprinkler system" on that rolling clock, with a 180-day intent-to-comply filing and mandatory signage reading "WARNING: THIS HIGH-RISE BUILDING IS NOT PROTECTED THROUGHOUT WITH AN AUTOMATIC FIRE SPRINKLER SYSTEM" (COMAR 29.06.01.07 and 29.06.01.08, effective 2025-06-23). The state's Fire Prevention Commission states it "will continue to pursue options to have fire sprinkler systems installed" (FY2025 report).

The consequence for underwriting is specific, and it is not that mandates get repealed. **No compliance clock starts until an authority having jurisdiction issues a violation notice.** An obligation whose deadline is triggered by enforcement rather than by statute defers indefinitely wherever enforcement capacity is thin — which converts a dated forcing function into a bet on staffing at the fire marshal's office. **A thesis that underwrites future retrofit volume from pending state mandates should discount for that explicitly in the model rather than in a growth rate.**

Five further forces run against the annuity. The two largest retrofit programmes are finished and generate no installation demand. Adoption lag compresses scope rather than merely delaying it — a jurisdiction on the 2012 IFC or NFPA 25-2011 enforces a smaller scope today, and the 2026-edition revenue items are not billable in Texas, Tennessee or the seven 2015-IFC jurisdictions and will not be for years. The 2026 edition removes work as well as adding it: pipe of 10 ft or less between a fire department connection and the check valve may skip the five-year hydrostatic test where visually inspected inside and out (QRFS, 2026-06-23). NFPA 10 (2026) makes a code interval satisfiable by a device rather than a visit, permitting electronic monitoring in lieu of the manual monthly extinguisher inspection — an interval that was owner-performed anyway, so the immediate revenue effect is small, but the same logic appears as an automated option in NFPA 25. And **the labour qualification gate is loosening at the standard level**: NFPA 25 (2026) requires personnel "qualified...for the specific tasks performed," and since the licensed-contractor requirement is a large part of why the contracted annuity exists, a task-based regime is at the margin a narrower moat.

Healthcare is not simply "state scope plus." CMS references NFPA 101 and NFPA 99 at their **2012 editions** with tentative interim amendments, and the hospital schedule published by the health-engineering society works from the NFPA 25-1998 and 2011, NFPA 72-1999, NFPA 10-1998 and NFPA 96-1998 editions. Hospitals sit on 1998 and 1999-vintage frequency tables by federal reference, **older than most state adoptions.** The healthcare premium is the enforcement ladder above, and the adjacent scopes — fire and smoke damper testing one year after installation then every six years, and annual sliding and rolling fire door inspection — not a broader base frequency table.

PART II — WHAT CAN BE SIZED, AND WHAT CANNOT

2.1 The instrument problem



The difficulty here is not that data is scarce. It is that **every published container fuses fire with an adjacent trade, and the fusion happens inside the classification rather than at the reporting stage**, so it cannot be netted out afterwards. Receipts are carried as the Census publishes them, in thousands of dollars.

CONTAINER	ESTABLISHMENTS AND RECEIPTS	WHY IT IS NOT A FIRE FIGURE
NAICS 238220 Plumbing, Heating, and Air-Conditioning Contractors	114,427 · 297,608,835 (EC2223BASIC, 2022)	Fire sprinkler installation sits inside this label alongside all plumbing and HVAC contracting; sprinkler work is on the order of 4% of the container's receipts
NAICS 238210 Electrical Contractors and Other Wiring Installation	81,249 · 249,247,389 (EC2223BASIC, 2022)	Fire alarm sold without monitoring sits inside all of electrical contracting
NAICS 561621 Security Systems Services (except Locksmiths)	7,462 · 31,313,513 (EC2256BASIC, 2022)	Fire alarm is not separated from burglar and security by definition
NAICS 811310 Commercial and Industrial Machinery Repair	23,925 · 54,640,745 (EC2281BASIC, 2022)	Extinguisher service without installation sits inside all industrial machinery repair
NAICS 561990 All Other Support Services	12,269 · 29,678,192 (EC2256BASIC, 2022)	No fire content is identifiable in the container at all

None of those five is a fire code. Any count taken from them is a container count, and the scale of the distortion is easy to state: reporting the 114,427 establishments in the plumbing and HVAC container as a fire-protection establishment count would overstate the sub-vertical by more than an order of magnitude.

One instrument does separate cleanly. The 2022 Economic Census publishes a **kind-of-business classification for construction, CONKB**, independent of NAICS, which contains fire-specific lines and separates fire sprinkler from lawn sprinkler. It carries the sprinkler sizing below and bounds the alarm layer, and **it does not reach the third sub-vertical at all: the code list contains no extinguisher, clean-agent or kitchen-suppression line**. Two limits travel with every figure from it — the table publishes only value of business done, with no establishment count, employment or payroll, and it is published at industry levels 2 and 3 only, so the sprinkler line cannot be cut within its containing code.

For the extinguisher, kitchen and special-hazard layer, the product-line table that would resolve it does not reach the services sectors on the openly accessible endpoint, and **no national product-line code for fire-extinguisher servicing, fire-suppression servicing or kitchen suppression is established in the public**

record . Nor does the largest disclosed participant fill the gap : **Cintas states no total addressable market , no market size and no market share** , for fire protection or for any segment , in its FY2025 10-K . What it states instead is a structure claim — its markets are "local in nature and highly fragmented ."

A reader who has absorbed this section will not ask for a single fire and life safety market size , because there is not one to give . What follows is one clean figure , one ceiling , one floor and a set of obligated-base counts . **They are not additive and they are not comparable on a like basis .**

2.2 Sprinkler and suppression contracting — the one clean figure

Instrument : table EC2223K0B , variable CONKB , measure "Value of business done (\$1 , 000)" , 2022 , United States .

CONKB	LABEL , VERBATIM	NAICS 23 (\$1,000)	NAICS 238 (\$1,000)
8221	"Building sprinkler system installation contractor"	12,018,607	12,014,511
8212	"Fire and security systems installation and service contractor"	18,514,295	18,508,938
8222	"Lawn sprinkler installation contractor"	1,776,660	1,728,134
8220 · 8224 · 8210	HVAC · plumbing · electric power installation and service , including lighting	123,488,876 · 76,125,406 · 178,844,538	123,465,608 · 76,100,456 · 178,362,969
8000 · 001	"Special trade contractors , total" · "Total"	1,198,309,008 · 2,920,771,250	1,165,801,524 · 1,281,526,572

Code 8221 is the only fire-specific revenue figure in the published record from a primary government table without derivation : **\$12,018,607 thousand** of value of business done in 2022 . It is **0.4115%** of all construction and **0.9375%** of the specialty-trade subsector . **It is a distinct code from lawn sprinkler** , which sits separately at 1,776,660 in the same thousands — which is what makes it usable , because the fusion problem that defeats every other container does not apply here .

Three caveats travel with it , and the first is a measurement basis rather than a caveat . **This is not an establishment classification** . The construction questionnaire asks each respondent to "report the percent of the total represented by the following construction and non-construction business activities" , so the line is the **value of building-sprinkler-installation work allocated across all of the construction sector** — not the revenue of establishments classified as sprinkler contractors . That is why the table carries no establishment count , and **no implied contractor count can be derived from it** . The label also says *installation* , so standalone ITM performed by firms outside construction is not in it ; it excludes non-employer firms ; and "building sprinkler system" is not split between wet , dry , standpipe or special hazard .

Commercial-vendor sizings of the US fire sprinkler market run several times larger , and the tension is definitional rather than arithmetical : the Census code counts value of business done by construction establishments primarily doing sprinkler installation , whereas vendor figures typically bundle device manufacture , distribution , monitoring and standalone ITM firms outside that boundary . **The Census figure is the right construction-contracting denominator for underwriting , and any vendor figure should be treated as a differently-scoped total rather than a competing estimate of the same thing .**

The one fire-specific labour denominator available is also unusually clean : **Road Sprinkler Fitters Local 669 , 16,631 members** on a 2025 Department of Labor filing (via UnionFacts , page updated 2026-04-23) . Local 669 is the single national local with jurisdiction over sprinkler fitting , so this is a floor on the organised

segment and says nothing about open-shop headcount . On the association side , AFSA states "more than 1 , 000 member companies" (About page , no publication date shown) .

2.3 Alarm, detection and monitoring — a ceiling, not a size

Two instruments bound this sub-vertical from above : CONKB **8212** "Fire and security systems installation and service contractor" at **18 , 514 , 295** , covering contractors classified in construction , and NAICS **561621** Security Systems Services at **31 , 313 , 513** , covering establishments selling alarm systems **with monitoring** — both in \$1 , 000s , as Census reports them . They are differently scoped , they are not alternatives , and averaging them would produce a number that describes nothing . Together they place a ceiling on the construction-side and services-side alarm layer at **\$49 , 827 , 808 thousand** , of which an unknown — and from published Census unknowable — share is fire . **That is a bound , not a size** . Both fuse fire with burglar at the definitional level .

The occupational denominator carries the same fusion : **SOC 49-2098 , Security and Fire Alarm Systems Installers , national employment 85 , 900 (2024)** , with 2024-2034 growth described as much faster than average at 7% or higher and **9 , 400** projected annual openings (O*NET OnLine , attributing to BLS 2025 wage data and 2024-2034 projections) . **The occupation title fuses security with fire and is not a fire-only headcount** .

What can be said about structure rather than size : **the monitoring container is the most branch-intensive in the set** , at 7 , 462 establishments against 6 , 161 firms , a ratio of **1 . 211** , against 1 . 021 for the plumbing and HVAC container and 1 . 029 for electrical . That is the footprint pattern of national monitoring platforms , and it is the one place in the published data where a multi-location operating model is visible . The code hook that makes the sub-vertical recur is the sprinkler supervision requirement at IFC 903 . 4 : **a buyer acquiring sprinkler ITM in an IFC jurisdiction is acquiring a structural referral into monitoring , whether or not the target monetises it** .

2.4 Extinguisher, kitchen and special hazard — a floor, not an estimate

There is no revenue denominator for this sub-vertical in the public record . No Census product line names it , no association publishes a market figure , and the largest disclosed operator makes no market-size statement . What exists instead is a defensible **count of code-obligated sites** , because every one carries a recurring statutory duty whether or not anyone is billing it : **≥ 737 , 325** commercial and institutional kitchens carrying a Type I hood cleaning and semiannual suppression duty , and a portable extinguisher base of **8 . 57 million at the code floor to 24 . 11 million** , central case $\approx$ 16 . 07 million , across **5 , 918 thousand** commercial buildings and **96 , 423 million sq ft** of floorspace (CBECS 2018) .

The bottom-up dollar figure that falls out of those counts , at route pricing :

LAYER	LOW	HIGH
Extinguisher ITM — 16 , 070 , 500 units , annual maintenance plus the six-year internal and twelve-year hydrostatic cycles	\$415 . 2M	\$830 . 3M
Hood and duct cleaning — 737 , 325 sites , semiannual , at standard single-hood pricing	\$663 . 6M	\$1 , 769 . 6M
Partial recurring service revenue	\$1 , 078 . 8M	\$2 , 599 . 9M

Route pricing is **\$15 - \$30** per extinguisher for annual inspection and maintenance , **\$40 - \$80** for six-year maintenance and **\$50 - \$100+** for the twelve-year hydrostatic test (IronClad Fire Protection , 2025-11-07) . A consumer aggregator gives **\$40 - \$100** for a professional inspection (HomeGuide , no date shown) , 2 . 7 to

3.3 times the route price; the gap is a population difference rather than an error, because the consumer figure prices a single-unit call-out including the trip while the route figure prices a stop with dozens of units under one trip charge. **This is by definition a route business, so the route price is the correct basis.** Hood cleaning carries a live price conflict, carried rather than resolved: a standard single-hood semiannual schedule implies **\$900 - \$2,400 a year** (Facilitec Southwest, 2026-06-16, updated 2026-07-01, on that source's own statement that these are industry-typical 2026 Southwest ranges rather than its own pricing), while a second operator publishes **\$1,800 - \$4,800 a year** weighted to multi-hood systems (Total Fire Protection, 2026-06-08). On the second basis the hood layer alone is **\$1,327.2M - \$3,539.2M**.

That total is a floor, and the reason is arithmetic rather than caution. Cintas alone books **\$817.463M** of Fire Protection Services revenue (FY2025 10-K). If the whole service pool were the size of the bottom-up figure, then even assuming only half of that fire line falls in this sub-vertical, one company would hold **15.7% to 37.9%** of a market its own 10-K describes as highly fragmented. That is not a credible share, and the correct response is to read the figure as a floor rather than adjust it into agreement. Three explanations are available and none can be sized: real extinguisher density materially exceeds code-minimum spacing once corridors, stairwells, kitchens and mechanical rooms are counted against the 75-ft travel distance; the national building survey excludes manufacturing and industrial floorspace, the extra-hazard highest-density tier, along with multifamily common areas and vehicle fleets; and the excluded revenue lines may simply be the majority of the money.

One revenue line is missing from the arithmetic entirely, and for a stated reason. The **wet-chemical suppression service line** — "At least semiannually, maintenance shall be conducted" (NFPA 17A §7.3.3, 2009), reinforced by NFPA 96 §12.2.1 — is real revenue, twice a year, at every one of 737,325 sites. The only semiannual suppression-inspection price in the record is **\$500-800** for engineered systems priced by detector count (Kinetix Fire, 2021-02-25, modified 2021-12-07). That is an engineered detector-count price, not a restaurant hood-system price, and applying it to 737,325 restaurant and institutional kitchens would be a category error. **No restaurant or commercial wet-chemical hood-suppression semiannual service price exists in the public record**, so the line is left out rather than estimated in. Also absent: the clean-agent and industrial special-hazard layer, for which neither a national systems count nor a service price is published; plus all equipment sales, all installation, recharge after discharge, cabinets, signage and mounting.

These two sub-verticals must never be set against one another as competing market sizes. The sprinkler figure is value of business done by construction establishments; this one is a bottom-up service-revenue floor that omits equipment, installation and two whole service lines. **No combined total for this market appears anywhere in this report, and one should not be constructed from its parts.**

What can be said about relative firm population comes from the one registry publishing both classes: in Nevada, **portable-extinguisher service licences are 56.4% of automatic-fire-sprinkler company licences** — 84 against 149 (Nevada State Fire Marshal, 2022-03-07). Those are licences rather than firms, one firm may hold several, and it is one state on a list four years old — but it indicates a firm population of the same order as sprinkler even though the measured revenue is not.

2.5 The obligated base — sites, systems and units

POPULATION	COUNT	SOURCE
Full-Service Restaurants (722511) · Limited-Service (722513) · Cafeterias and Buffets (722514)	254,201 · 271,243 · 4,590	Census EC2272BASIC, 2022

POPULATION	COUNT	SOURCE
Hotels and Motels (721110) · Casino Hotels (721120)	56,260 · 400	Census EC2272BASIC, 2022
Operating public schools (SY 2023-24) · private schools (SY 2019-20)	99,297 · 30,492	NCES
Registered hospitals (2024 survey) · CMS-certified nursing facilities (July 2025)	6,100 · 14,742	AHA Fast Facts 2026 · KFF from CMS data
Core obligated commercial-kitchen base	737,325 sites	Sum of the components above
Portable extinguisher installed base	8,570,933 – 24,105,750, central ≈ 16,070,500	Derived from CBECs floorspace and Cal. Code Regs. tit. 19 §568 Table 2

The extinguisher band rests on a legally binding maximum spacing rather than a survey. **Cal. Code Regs. tit. 19, § 568, Table 2** codifies the NFPA 10 Class A distribution table into enforceable state law: a maximum floor area per extinguisher of **11,250 sq ft** in all three hazard classes, with maximum floor area per unit of A of 3,000 sq ft light, 1,500 ordinary and 1,000 extra hazard, and a maximum travel distance of 75 ft. **A count derived from it is a code floor, not a guess**, because every compliant building must carry at least that density.

The kitchen count is likewise a floor. It excludes correctional facilities, degree-granting postsecondary institutions, corporate and campus dining, military dining, stadiums and arenas, non-hotel casinos, convenience stores with fryers and grocery hot-bar and deli operations — **every one of which carries an NFPA 96 obligation** — and deliberately excludes snack and beverage bars (78,110), drinking places (40,911), food service contractors (30,086), caterers (12,579) and mobile food services (10,155).

Conflict — restaurant unit count. Three sources, three numbers, not averaged. Census counts **701,875** employer establishments in food services and drinking places for 2022. The National Restaurant Association states "more than 1 million restaurant and foodservice outlets" alongside \$1.55 trillion projected 2026 sales (NRA, 2026-02-12). A franchise marketing page states "nearly 750,000 restaurants in the United States alone" (HOODZ, no date). These measure different things: Census counts employer establishments inside a fixed industry boundary in 2022, while the association counts outlets in 2026 on a definition that plausibly includes non-employer operations, in-store foodservice inside retail and grocery, and institutional outlets classified elsewhere. The Census figure is the sound establishment denominator; the association figure is the outlet-level ceiling. **The roughly 300,000-outlet gap between them is itself the size of the institutional and in-store kitchen layer the Census boundary does not see**, which is consistent with the 207,291 institutional and lodging sites counted separately above.

Visits per site per year. The obligated base converts to visits without a growth assumption, but it requires an assumption about site configuration. For a single-tenant commercial building with one wet-pipe sprinkler system on a riser with a backflow preventer, one monitored alarm, portable extinguishers, and one moderate-volume kitchen with wet-chemical hood suppression, the code intervals produce **11 contractor-performed scheduled site events a year**: four sprinkler visits, two alarm visits, one extinguisher annual maintenance visit, two kitchen suppression services and two hood and duct inspections. That is before any three-year dry-pipe trip test, five-year internal pipe, gauge or standpipe event, six-year extinguisher internal examination, or deficiency-driven repair visit. **The building configuration is an assumption and should be replaced with the target's actual site mix; the frequencies are not assumptions.**

2.6 Structural fragmentation

Instrument: table EC2223LOCCONS, variable EMPSZFE, measure ESTAB, 2022. The Census band label is "less than 5," not "1-4"; the universe is employer establishments, so establishments with no employees in the reference period sit inside that band.

EMPLOYMENT SIZE BAND	238220 ESTAB	SHARE OF ENTIRE-YEAR	238210 ESTAB	SHARE OF ENTIRE-YEAR
All establishments	114,427	—	81,249	—
Operated for the entire year	93,416	100.00%	67,642	100.00%
...with less than 5 employees	49,926	53.44%	35,717	52.80%
...with 5 to 9 · 10 to 19	19,350 · 12,587	20.71% · 13.47%	13,783 · 8,945	20.38% · 13.22%
...with 20 to 49 · 50 to 99	7,730 · 2,346	8.27% · 2.51%	5,976 · 1,892	8.83% · 2.80%
...with 100 to 249 · 250 to 499 · 500 or more	1,134 · 248 · 95	1.21% · 0.27% · 0.10%	988 · 211 · 130	1.46% · 0.31% · 0.19%

74.16% of entire-year plumbing and HVAC establishments have fewer than 10 employees and only **1.58%** have 100 or more; the electrical container runs **73.18%** and **1.96%**. Multi-location intensity is near-unitary in both — **1.021** and **1.029** establishments per firm — against 1.211 for security systems services.

These are container counts, not fire counts, and the distinction is not a technicality. The table describes the plumbing, HVAC and fire-sprinkler trade together in one column and all of electrical contracting in the other. A fire-protection contractor running a 20-employee ITM crew is structurally closer to the 20-to-49 band than to the sub-five mode of the container, and **the sub-five share must not be read as the fire-protection size distribution.**

What the distribution does license: the trade population is atomised and overwhelmingly single-location, consistent with a roll-up thesis built on adding locations rather than buying networks; and the large end is thin in absolute terms, with 1,477 establishments at 100 or more employees across the entire plumbing, HVAC and sprinkler container, of which the fire-specific subset is smaller still. Unit economics frame the labour model: the plumbing and HVAC container runs 10.2 employees per establishment, \$68,695 of payroll per employee and \$254,434 of receipts per employee; electrical 11.9, \$71,341 and \$257,292; security systems services 18.9, \$61,819 and \$222,277 of receipts per employee.

What it does **not** license: any fire-specific establishment count, because the fire-specific instrument publishes revenue only and no Census product pairs it with an establishment count; and any national count of licensed extinguisher, sprinkler or alarm firms, because only two state registries produce counts — Utah at 246 fire extinguisher, 92 fire suppression and 51 kitchen exhaust companies, and Nevada as above — and scaling those nationally produces figures that disagree by 2.68 times, since both include out-of-state licence holders and per-capita scaling double-counts national platforms once per state. **A national licensed-firm count is buildable by deduplicating firm names across all fifty registries. It does not exist today, and building it is the single piece of work that would most improve every screen run against this market.**

PART III — THE ANNUITY, UNDERWRITTEN

3.1 Pull-through: why inspection is bought for the work it finds

Inspection is not bought for the inspection revenue. It is bought because a technician standing in a mechanical room with a tag gun and a code obligation generates a second, larger, higher-margin revenue stream nobody else is positioned to win. **That is the load-bearing claim of the whole sector thesis, and the one leg of it carrying a first-party, on-the-record number.**

The ratio, stated by the largest filer in the industry, twice. An investor day put it on a slide: "\$3 – \$4 of incremental service work generated annually for every \$1 of inspection work" (APi Group, slide 19, 2025-05-21). The slide's own footnote bounds it: "Based on leadership estimate for U.S. inspection revenues, excludes purely route based service revenues (primarily portable fire extinguishers)." So it is a leadership estimate, US-only, with the extinguisher route book carved out — which means **it does not transfer to the economics of the third sub-vertical.** Nine months later the chief executive restated it unprompted: "If you recall, we generate someplace between \$3 and \$4 worth of service work for every dollar of inspection revenue that we generate. And that continues to grow at that high-single-digit clip" (Q4 2025 earnings call, Russell A. Becker, 2026-02-25).

The clause after the ratio carries as much weight as the ratio: management is asserting the multiple is not decaying. The earlier form shows how much the disclosure has firmed — "Our go to market strategy is to sell inspection work first, because we estimate that every dollar sold can lead to subsequent service work" (Form 424B5, 2021-09-13). "Can lead to" in 2021 became a stated \$3 to \$4 by 2025. It is one issuer's own management estimate, with no published methodology and no independent replication. **It is the market's best-supported claim rather than an audited statistic, and it should be carried that way.**

The mix shift the ratio produced is disclosed and it is large. "We increased our percentage of revenue coming from inspections, service, and monitoring from 40% in 2021 to 54% in 2025" (Q4 2025 earnings call, 2026-02-25), against a stated objective of "60%+ long-term net revenues from inspection, service and monitoring revenues" (investor day, slide 55, 2025-05-21). Alongside it: "19 Consecutive Quarters of Double-Digit Organic Inspection Revenues Growth", updated to "over 20 quarters of this trend" on the same call. A separate and older series covering service as a proportion of a predecessor life-safety business — approximately 20% in 2008 to approximately 41% in 2020 — measures different businesses on a different denominator and must not be blended with it.

Three software-platform datasets corroborate the mechanism on different measures. None is a fire-only whole-population statistic, and each is published by a software vendor selling to these contractors, so they are carried as corroboration of direction rather than as the figure: pull-through at **19.5%** and **19.6%** of work orders for top performers, two technician-count cohorts from the same report with no average taken (ServiceTrade Fire and Life Safety benchmark, 2024); pull-through repair revenue at **10.3%** of invoiced dollars, being \$822 million tied to recurring inspections against \$8 billion of invoices across over 1,300 fire and mechanical contractors (ServiceTrade, 2026-02-05); and **75%** of respondents reporting over 20% of revenue from pull-through, in a survey of over 1,000 commercial owners and executives fielded in May 2025 (ServiceTitan, 2025-07-14).

These are not in conflict; they measure different quantities. But the tension is worth carrying into an investment committee memo. The issuer's ratio implies service is 75% to 80% of the inspection-plus-service block, while the platform aggregate implies pull-through repair is about a tenth of all invoiced dollars. The first counts all subsequent service work off an inspection relationship; the second counts only repair work

explicitly tied to a recurring job . **The \$3-to-\$4 ratio is the wider definition and should be read as the ceiling , not the base case .**

The most useful operating insight in the sector decomposes the ratio into two behaviours . Top performers identified potential repairs on about 25% of work orders against about 10% for bottom-half performers , and "Top performers consistently converted between 50% and 60% of identified equipment issues into quotes for their customers . Bottom-half performers only quoted identified issues about 10% of the time . " Quote approval rates were similar between cohorts — "the difference in revenue came from volume rather than conversion quality . " In fire protection specifically , "Top-half performers earned 38% more per work order than bottom-half performers" and 99% more per customer (ServiceTrade , "5 Steps to Growing Pull-Through Repair Revenue") .

The pull-through gap is therefore not a closing-skill gap . It is a detect-and-quote gap . A contractor who does not systematically record deficiencies at the inspection and does not systematically quote them leaves roughly half the annuity's economics on the floor — a defect a buyer can test from the target's own work-order and quote history and fix after close with process and software rather than with people . **It is one of the few genuinely underwritable operational improvements in the sector .**

The revenue is composed of many small compelled repairs rather than a few large ones . Platform quote data shows "1 . 4 million quotes , achieving a 63% acceptance rate with 40% of the quoted value approved" — acceptance by count runs well ahead of acceptance by value , so the mean accepted quote is materially smaller than the mean issued quote . That is consistent with the disclosed "≈\$7K Average Ticket Size in Safety Services : North America" (APi Group investor day , 2025-05-21) .

3.2 What "recurring" actually means in an executed contract

No filer discloses the composition of its inspection book by contract form , so the question is answered from the contracts themselves . Three executed or published standard-form agreements are available in full , and they are structurally incompatible with one another . **That incompatibility is the finding .**

	CONTRACTOR'S OWN FORM	NATIONAL-ACCOUNT, OWNER'S PAPER	PUBLIC-SECTOR AWARD
Parties	Fire Protection , Inc . (Seattle) , published master service agreement	Johnson Controls Fire Protection , LP — Physicians Realty L . P . , contract 919272	Pye-Barker Fire & Safety — Lee County , FL , solicitation B210350NAT
Term and renewal	"60 months commencing on the date of service activation" ; renews "automatically for successive 60 month terms thereafter under the same terms and conditions"	2022-07-01 to 2025-06-30 ; "the term shall automatically renew for successive one (1) year periods if not terminated"	"one (1) three-year (3) period" ; renews "not to exceed the initial Agreement term" , "Upon mutual written agreement"
Termination	Written notice "at least 60 days prior to the expiration of any term , extension , or renewal"	"may be terminated at any time by either party upon forty-five (45) days' prior written notice"	County may terminate "upon thirty (30) days' written notice" for "any reason whatsoever"
Escalation	"the greater of six percent (6%) each year or the percent equal to the most recent 12-month percentage change in CPI-U"	In the price schedule : +9 . 95% year 1 to 2 , +9 . 03% year 2 to 3	None specified
Assignment	"FPI shall have the right to assign this Agreement to a company licensed to perform the services and shall be relieved of any obligations" ; customer may not assign without consent	"Contractor shall not assign this Agreement without the prior written consent of Owner"	Assignee must agree "in writing with the non-assigning party"

	CONTRACTOR'S OWN FORM	NATIONAL-ACCOUNT, OWNER'S PAPER	PUBLIC-SECTOR AWARD
Volume commitment	Scheduled service at contracted rates	Fixed annual price, "monthly in advance, net 30"	Work "on an as needed basis" contingent on County purchase orders; rate card \$80-\$180/hour by technician grade, 25% materials markup
Deficiency handling	"If system devices or panels are deficient, FPI will provide Customer with a written proposal for service and/or repairs"	Annual inspections with semi-annual visuals and quarterly testing across multiple properties	Not specified

The contractor's own form is the asset a consolidator wants: five-year evergreen term, an escalator at the greater of 6% or consumer price inflation, a unilateral assignment right in the contractor's favour, and a written deficiency-to-proposal step. **On that paper the pull-through mechanism is a contractual obligation rather than a sales habit** — the difference between a detect-and-quote discipline that survives a change of ownership and one that leaves with the founder.

The national-account form is the mirror image. Its executed price schedule is real evidence of inspection pricing power: total contract value **\$288,845** across three years, at **\$87,576**, **\$96,290** and **\$104,979** — escalation well above general inflation in a competitively awarded multi-site institutional account. But two clauses dismantle the annuity story. Termination for convenience on 45 days' notice by either party means that **on a three-year face term the economic term is 45 days**. And no assignment without owner consent means the contract does not travel unless the owner agrees. The public-sector award is not a revenue contract at all: it is a rate-card master agreement with zero volume commitment, cancellable in thirty days for any reason whatsoever. It confers a right to be called, not a right to revenue. **Diligence that counts a public-sector "three-year contract" as contracted backlog is mis-stating the asset.**

On assignability the answer is structural rather than statistical, and it turns entirely on whose paper the agreement is written on. An equity or stock purchase preserves the book while an asset purchase puts the best-named accounts at risk of consent — and the perverse result follows directly: **the accounts a buyer most wants, the multi-site national logos, are precisely the ones least likely to travel in an asset deal, because they are the ones written on the customer's paper.**

No source discloses what share of any contractor's book sits on each form — not a filer, not a rating agency, not a franchise disclosure document. It is the single most commercially decisive unquantified variable in the industry, and it is a diligence question rather than a research question. **Engage transaction counsel with contract-assignment and change-of-control experience before structure is fixed**, and ask three things: what proportion of the inspection book by revenue sits on the target's own form; which named accounts contain anti-assignment or consent clauses; and whether the structure contemplated triggers them.

The filers' own language is internally contradictory, and the contradiction is live. Against "Maintenance and service revenues are less cyclical, and are reasonably recurring due to consistent renewal rates and deep customer relationships" (Form 424B5, 2021-09-13) sits the risk-factor formulation "the fact that our revenues are derived primarily from contracts with durations of less than six months and the risk that customers will not renew or enter into new contracts" (Form DRS, 2019-12-23) — a phrase that still appears in that issuer's filings through the Form 10-Q filed 2025-10-30. The FY2025 risk factors go further: "our customers are not contractually committed to procure specific volumes of services under a contract." Accounting treatment in the adjacent route-service industry corroborates the short-duration reading: approximately 95% of Cintas revenue comes from route servicing recognised "over time as services are performed", and "The Company's performance period generally corresponds with the monthly invoice period" (Form 10-Q, period ended 2025-

08-31). **A route-service business whose performance period is one month has no long-dated contract asset at all.**

"Recurring" in fire and life safety is a behavioural fact about customer habit and legal duty , not a balance-sheet fact about contracted term . The one route-based recurring service business that does disclose a term sets the benchmark from outside the sector : "We primarily serve our customers pursuant to written service contracts that range in duration from three to five years" (UniFirst Form 10-K , fiscal 2017) , across 300 , 000-plus customer locations . Fire inspection's own contractor-side standard form , at 60 months , sits at or above that . Its national-account forms , at a 45-day out , sit far below .

3.3 Retention and attrition

One usable commercial proxy exists . ADT's commercial segment disclosed customer retention of ≈91% and a customer life of ≈10 years , alongside recurring revenue at ≈30% of segment total revenue (ADT Inc . , *Business Overview and Financial Modeling* , April 2022 , pages 9 and 10) .

Label the population precisely . It measures ADT Commercial — the commercial fire , life safety and security business divested to GTCR in October 2023 and rebranded Everon , and the direct organisational ancestor of one of the platforms in the consolidation map . It is **not** a pure inspection book ; it is a blended commercial security-plus-fire book . It carries no published definition , so whether the 91% is logo retention , revenue retention or recurring-monthly-revenue retention is unstated , and those are three different numbers . It is an April 2022 marketing-deck figure published before divestiture , with no successor figure under the new ownership . Discounted for all three caveats , ≈91% retention with a ≈10-year customer life remains a materially different animal from residential monitoring attrition , and it is the right anchor for a commercial inspection book **provided it is labelled a proxy every time it is used .**

The residential number , with its definition attached , so the two are never confused . ADT reported gross customer revenue attrition of **13 . 1%** in FY2025 against 12 . 7% in FY2024 , revenue payback of **2 . 3 years** against 2 . 2 , and end-of-period recurring monthly revenue of **\$359M** at 2025-12-31 , flat year on year , on total revenue of **\$5 , 129M** (Q4 and full-year 2025 results , 2026-03-02) . The company's own definition : "Gross attrition is calculated on a trailing twelve-month basis , the numerator of which is the RMR lost during the period due to attrition , net of dealer chargebacks and reinstated customers , excluding contracts monitored but not owned and DIY customers , and the denominator of which is total annualized RMR based on an average of RMR under contract at the beginning of each month during the period . "

The population is residential and small-business monitoring subscribers and the denominator is recurring monthly revenue . **A 13 . 1% attrition rate on that denominator and a 91% commercial customer-retention rate are computed on different numerators , different denominators and different populations , and must never be placed on the same axis .** Read together , the residential figures describe a book being replaced rather than grown at a slightly worsening cost : recurring monthly revenue flat while attrition widened 40 basis points and payback lengthened by a tenth of a year . On a constant-hazard reciprocal the 13 . 1% implies a customer life of 7 . 63 years against 7 . 87 at the prior year's rate — an approximation that overstates life for any real book , since early-life attrition runs higher than late .

No fire protection contractor discloses an inspection-book renewal rate , retention rate or attrition rate . Not one , public filer or private platform . The structural reason closes off the research route a buyer would otherwise fund : **there is no fire or life-safety-services S-1 in EDGAR .** The registration statement is the document that normally compels a services business to publish retention , churn and cohort economics , and no fire or life safety business has filed one . The one listed pure-play came to market via a UK-listed special purpose vehicle and a Form S-4 , and its 2019 draft registration statement has its financial and operational

metric tables redacted with placeholder marks . A full-text search on Form S-1 for the phrase "inspection , testing and maintenance" returns eight registrants , none of them a fire or life safety business . The second route is closed for a different reason : credit opinions on the large private platforms exist but are entitlement-gated , because the issuers are private placements rather than public registrants . **Obtaining platform-level operating metrics is a paid-database exercise and should be scoped and budgeted as one rather than pursued as open-web research .**

Underwriting instruction . Any inspection renewal rate presented by a seller is an unaudited management figure with no public benchmark to check it against . Test it against the target's own site-level invoice history across three consecutive inspection cycles , not against an industry average , because there is no industry average . The obligation itself recurs regardless of who performs it , so **retention in this sector is a competitive outcome , not a contractual one .**

3.4 Gross margin by work type, and the recurring-revenue ladder

The only fire-specific margin-by-work-type bands in the public record come from a sector M&A update , and they are the economic reason the inspection book is defended rather than harvested : **testing and inspection 50%+ , repair and maintenance 40%-50% , retrofit 35%-45%+ , and new construction 25%-35%** (Meridian Capital , *Fire & Life Safety Services M&A Market Update* , Winter 2025) . The same report characterises service revenue as "generally characterized as recurring/reoccurring with strong margins ."

The spread does the work . Against the new-construction band , testing and inspection at its floor carries 15 percentage points more gross margin at the top of that band and 25 points more at the bottom . The report's own reading of the disclosed 40%-to-54% migration is that it is worth roughly 15 to 20 points of gross margin on the migrated revenue . **On either construction , the value being paid for in a mix shift is the margin on the migrated dollar , not the recurrence of it .** Recurrence without the margin band is a route business with a low ceiling ; the margin band without recurrence is project work .

Directional corroboration from inside a single filer , on a different measure : that issuer's Safety Services segment carried adjusted gross margin of **37 . 3%** in FY2025 against 36 . 4% in FY2024 , while its Specialty Services segment carried **18 . 9%** against 19 . 7% . **That is a difference between two different businesses rather than a work-type differential inside one , and it must not be used as the latter .** What it establishes is that the service-weighted segment carries roughly twice the gross margin of the project-weighted segment under the same management , procurement and overhead . The bands also explain the defensive behaviour a buyer will observe in the field : a contractor holding an inspection book at a 50%-plus gross margin , which also generates the repair work at 40% to 50% , has more to lose from a lost site than a project contractor has from a lost bid .

Recurring-revenue comparators , on one basis . All figures below use **total revenue as the denominator** , because that single choice matters more than any individual value — the sector's most-cited recurring statistic is quoted on a narrower denominator and flatters the top of the ladder by about fifteen percentage points .

BUSINESS	RECURRING MEASURE	FIGURE	POPULATION
ADT Inc .	annualised recurring monthly revenue ÷ total revenue	84 . 0% (FY2025)	residential and small-business monitoring
ADT Commercial (later Everon)	recurring ÷ segment revenue	≈30% (April 2022)	commercial fire , life safety , security
API Group	inspection + service + monitoring ÷ net revenue	54% (FY2025) , objective 60%+	fire and life safety services , global

BUSINESS	RECURRING MEASURE	FIGURE	POPULATION
APi predecessor life-safety segment	service ÷ net revenue	41% (2020)	predecessor business only
Chubb Fire & Security	"recurring in nature"	"over 60%" (pre-2021)	fire and security, 17 countries
Rollins · Cintas	recurring services ÷ revenue · route-serviced ÷ revenue	≈75% (FY2025) · ≈95% (Q1 FY2026)	pest control · uniform, first aid, fire protection

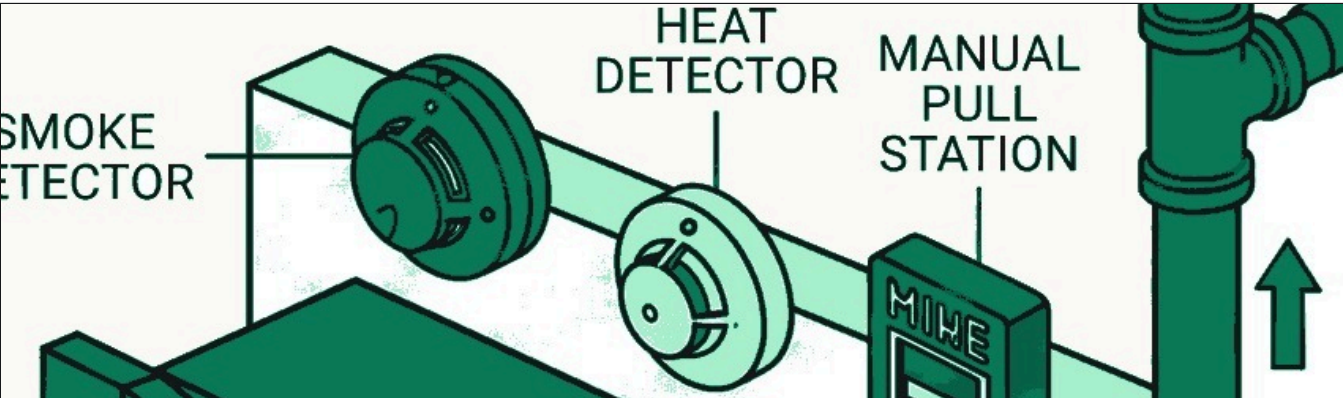
The denominator point, stated once: annualised recurring monthly revenue of **\$4,308M** measures **98.9%** of ADT's monitoring and related services revenue and **84.0%** of its total revenue. Both are true and they answer different questions, and only the second is comparable to any other platform in this sector.

Two conclusions follow. **First, 54% and "over 60%" bracket the practical ceiling for a services-led fire platform**, and the largest operator's own objective says management believes the ceiling sits near there. A target represented as materially above 60% recurring is either defining recurring more loosely than the sector's largest filer does, or is not comparable — and the first explanation is more common. **Second, pest control at ≈75% and route-serviced uniform rental at ≈95% run far higher recurring shares, and the gap is structural rather than managerial**, because fire platforms carry construction and retrofit revenue that those businesses do not. When a fire platform is compared to a pest-control or uniform-rental benchmark, that structural gap is the thing being papered over.

At the other end of the ladder, a business showing recurring monthly revenue at roughly 6% to 9% of total revenue is not selling monitoring contracts at all — it is selling inspection agreements. **That distinction, rather than the percentage, is what changes the diligence programme:** above roughly 10%, the asset is a set of assignable term-dated contracts with measurable decay; below it, the asset is a site list, an inspection history and a habit.

PART IV — THE CONSOLIDATION MAP

4.1 How to read this map



Sub-vertical codes : **SV1** sprinkler and suppression , install plus ITM · **SV2** alarm , detection , monitoring and low-voltage life safety · **SV3** extinguisher , kitchen , clean agent and industrial special hazard .

The owner classes below are not interchangeable , and a register that blends them misleads . A sponsor with a fund clock will produce a secondary asset ; a permanent-capital holder will not . A manufacturer under a sponsor competes for supplier assets , not route density . An entity already absorbed into another platform is not a target at all , however live its nameplate looks . **Separating them is this part's main contribution , because a single headline platform count overstates the competitive set a buyer actually faces .**

CLASS	DEFINITION	COUNT
1a	US fire and life-safety service contractors under a live private-equity sponsor	17
1b	Security-led integrators under a live sponsor carrying fire and life safety in their own service description	5
2	Fire manufacturers and product platforms under sponsors	3
3	Permanent-capital, family and strategic holders with no exit clock	8
4	Platform-level entities already exited to a strategic or absorbed into another platform	5

Two further groups sit outside the counts and are named because they distort registers that include them . First , **fire platforms of scale whose owner does not appear in the public record** : ORR Protection and CPI Security Systems . Second , **monitoring infrastructure under a sponsor** : Becklar , whose brands include AvantGuard , Freeus , Armstrongs and Eyeforce , passed to Graham Partners on 2024-12-10 with BV Investment Partners rolling its stake (Security Info Watch , 2024-12-10) . It is not a fire contractor , but it owns paper that fire-alarm recurring revenue sits on .

Read together : **the sponsor-backed US fire contracting set at platform level is 17 , not the thirty-odd entities a blended tracker reports .** Two of the 17 carry a sponsor identified only by trade press or a directory listing — RapidFire Safety & Security (Concentric Equity Partners) and Telgian (The Miller Group) — and both should be graded a step below the rest . Ownership states are as of 2026-07-29 , and privately held platforms change hands without announcement .

4.2 Public strategies

APi Group Corporation (NYSE: APG) is the only issuer in the sector that discloses a fire and life-safety segment at all, which makes it the benchmark set by default. FY2025 net revenues were **\$7,911 million** against \$7,018 million in FY2024, with Safety Services at **\$5,456 million** on 13.7% reported and 6.7% organic growth, Specialty Services at **\$2,460 million**, and a Safety Services segment earnings margin of **16.8%**, up 90 basis points (APi Group IR, 2026-02-26). The two segments sum to \$7,916 million against a stated total of \$7,911 million; both are carried as filed and the \$5 million difference is not netted. FY2026 guidance was raised to **\$8,475-\$8,675 million** (Businesswire, 2026-04-30). Its stated strategy is inspection-first: the CertaSite acquisition "shifts mix towards 60% of revenues from inspection, service, and monitoring" (2025-12-10). FY2025 acquisitions consumed **\$186 million** of net cash; Chubb Fire & Security was bought from Carrier for **\$3.1 billion**, completed 2022-01-03. In the two quarters after CertaSite it completed **Onyx-Fire Protection Services** in Canada (~\$190 million of annual revenue, 2026-06-08) and **WTech Fire Group** in Europe (~\$175 million, 2026-07-01). Of the "more than \$1 billion across these three acquisitions" the chief executive described, **only CertaSite is a US business, and the other two remove nothing from a US target board.**

Johnson Controls International plc (NYSE: JCI) did not exit fire. FY2025 sales were **\$23.6 billion**, with Products and Systems at **\$16.124 billion** and Services at **\$7.472 billion**, up 7%, and Systems and Services backlog at **\$14.9 billion**, up 13% organically. What it sold was HVAC: Residential and Light Commercial went to Bosch Group in July 2025 for **\$8.3 billion** of total consideration, its own portion approximately **\$6.9 billion**. Fire and security remain inside Building Solutions Americas.

Carrier Global Corporation (NYSE: CARR) sold both of its fire businesses and retains none: Industrial Fire to Sentinel Capital Partners at **\$1.425 billion** enterprise value and Commercial and Residential Fire to an affiliate of Lone Star Funds at **\$3 billion**, closing 2024-12-02. Access Solutions, including LenelS2, went to **Honeywell International (NASDAQ: HON)**, which publishes no fire or life-safety-specific revenue line for its building automation segment.

Securitas AB (OM: SECU B) holds Securitas Technology, reporting FY2025 revenue of **\$3,459,840,000** and recurring monthly revenue of **\$102,000,000** at 2025-12-31, both survey estimates, second on the SDM 100. It completed the STANLEY Security acquisition on 2022-07-22 at **\$3,200 million** debt- and cash-free.

Cintas Corporation (NASDAQ: CTAS) runs a Fire Protection Services operating segment covering extinguishers, sprinkler and alarm testing and special hazard suppression, reported inside the "All Other" reportable segment at **\$1,146,018 thousand** in FY2025 against **\$1,064,082 thousand** in FY2024, on total company revenue of **\$10,340,181 thousand**. **Fire Protection Services is not separately disclosed and is strictly smaller than the segment.**

ADT Inc. (NYSE: ADT) has left commercial fire: it sold its commercial business to GTCR and then sold its business-to-business multifamily segments to that same business, now Everon. **It is a seller of commercial fire assets, not a bidder for them.**

The negative findings matter as much as the positive ones. A reader will assume the large listed mechanical and electrical contractors carry a fire line. They do not disclose one. **Comfort Systems USA (NYSE: FIX)** describes its mechanical segment as one that "principally includes HVAC, plumbing, piping and controls, as well as off-site construction, monitoring and fire protection" (Form 10-Q, period ended 2025-06-30) — that is the whole of it, on FY2025 revenue of **\$9,101.6 million**, with no breakout by trade, so **no fire-protection denominator for that issuer exists in the public record.** **EMCOR Group (NYSE: EME)** reported FY2025 revenues of **\$16.99 billion**, with US Mechanical Construction and Facilities at **\$7,050.5 million**, 42% of the

total, and its results release contains no mention of fire protection or life safety as a distinct service line. Both are credible acquirers of mechanical contractors that happen to carry sprinkler capability, and **neither can be benchmarked on fire economics**.

4.3 Sponsor-backed platforms

Revenue is not in the public record for almost any fire-led platform in this class. The exceptions are narrow: platforms that file into the SDM 100 survey report revenue and recurring monthly revenue there, and CertaSite's revenue entered the record only because a public acquirer had to state it. Empty cells are figures absent from the public record, not omissions, and **no revenue has been derived from headcount or location count**.

Fire-led service contractors under a live sponsor

PLATFORM	CURRENT SPONSOR	PRIOR SPONSOR	SV	FOOTPRINT AND SCALE EVIDENCE
Pye-Barker Fire & Safety	Altas Partners (majority) · Leonard Green & Partners · ADIA · GIC		1+2+3	47 states; 253 locations stated against 256 location URLs enumerated; 9,000 team members; FY2025 revenue \$2,000,000,000 and recurring monthly revenue \$50,391,844 (SDM 100, 2026); 2021-2024 growth 587%
Summit Companies / SFP Holding	BDT & MSD Partners , majority, announced 2025-08-04	BlackRock Long Term Private Capital (2021-09-20); CI Capital Partners before that	1+2	37 states; Summit Fire & Security at 27 states and 130+ branches; 82 acquisitions since the 1999 founding, 55 strategic, as at 2021
AI Fire (Impact Fire, Academy Fire)	Blackstone, Feb 2025	TruArc Partners (2021, retained a stake); Caltius on the original Impact Fire deal	1+2+3	20 states named by the company, 18 states and over 40 district offices per the seller — both carried; Impact Fire at 50+ locations
Marmic Fire & Safety	KKR, 2024-07-24	HGGC (2021); Thompson Street before that	1+3, ITM-led	53 branches across 20 states; over 56,000 customers; over 30 companies joined
Sciens Building Solutions	Carlyle (NASDAQ: CG), completed 2021-12-15	Huron Capital, platform formed 2016, minority retained	1+2	31 divisions across twelve states; greater than 35-fold increase in revenue and earnings over the prior hold
Encore Fire Protection	Permira, completed Mar 2025	Levine Leichtman Capital Partners	1+2+3	33 branches across 13 states on its published locations list, against a wider footprint claimed on the sponsor page; 2,400+ employees; 1,200 certified technicians; 70+ acquisitions; 75 affiliated brand partners named
Altus Fire and Life Safety	Apax Partners , 2024	AE Industrial Partners (2021)	1+2	12 Northeast states plus Georgia and Pennsylvania; eight add-ons integrated under the prior sponsor
ASPYRE Fire & Life Safety	Percheron Capital, 2025-11-12		1+2+3	Southern US foundational, stated intent to expand nationally; sponsor assets under management over \$4 billion
Guardian Fire Protection Services (Rockville MD)	Knox Lane, majority, 2024-01		1+2+3	9 locations across 4 states; more than 24,000 commercial customers

PLATFORM	CURRENT SPONSOR	PRIOR SPONSOR	SV	FOOTPRINT AND SCALE EVIDENCE
Guardian Fire Services (Nashville TN)	Investcorp , 2025-12-03	Northern Lakes Capital	1+2+3	17 branches across the Southeast , Northeast and Western US ; 12 acquisitions since 2022
Fire Safety and Protection	Sunny River Management , LLC		1+2	5 US and 8 Canadian offices ; eight named constituent acquisitions founded 1964 to 2010
National Fire & Safety	Highview Capital , LLC		1+2+3 , own central station	AZ , CO , TX , UT , WY currently ; seven western states per the 2022 release ; six dated add-ons
Relay Fire and Safety	The Riverside Company		3 , extinguisher route	New York metropolitan area named as its largest target market
RapidFire Safety & Security	Concentric Equity Partners (<i>trade press only</i>)		1+2+3	FY2025 revenue \$71 , 925 , 249 , recurring monthly revenue \$1 , 188 , 586 , SDM 100 #35 ; six named add-ons
FSS Technologies	Lightview Capital , 2025-10-28	Glass Lake Holdings as independent sponsor	1+2	Headquartered Ann Arbor MI
Security Fire Systems	Blackford Capital (<i>trade press only</i>)		1+2	Named add-on Lakeview Security , Fire & Communications
Telgian	The Miller Group (<i>directory listing only</i>)		consulting , engineering , ITM	Headquartered Phoenix AZ ; not a route business

Security-led integrators under a live sponsor carrying fire

PLATFORM	SPONSOR(S)	FIRE EVIDENCE	SCALE EVIDENCE
Convergint	Ares Management (shared control) · Leonard Green & Partners · Harvest Partners , the latter two from 2021-12-15	"fire and life safety" named in its own service description	Over 220 technology centers across three regions ; 11 , 000+ colleagues ; over 40 acquisitions ; adjusted operating earnings approximately quadrupled since 2018
Everon	GTCR , completed 2023-10-02	Acquired as ADT's "commercial security , fire and life safety business unit"	Over 100 offices ; 5 , 000+ employees ; 300 , 000+ customer locations ; FY2025 revenue \$1 , 618 , 725 , 121 , recurring monthly revenue \$43 , 340 , 856 , SDM 100 #4
Pavion Corp .	Wind Point Partners , June 2020	Fire alarm , security and integrated communications from one profit-and-loss statement	70+ US locations and 23 countries ; FY2025 revenue \$904 , 972 , 750 , recurring monthly revenue \$17 , 832 , 431
Zeus Fire and Security	Access Holdings , platform formed 2022-02-22	Fire in the corporate name ; two UL-listed monitoring centres	Seven states ; 750+ employees ; FY2025 revenue \$205 , 859 , 618 , recurring monthly revenue \$6 , 467 , 326 ; 14 member brands
Minuteman Security and Life Safety	Tenex Capital Management	"Life Safety" in the corporate name	Maine to Florida ; FY2025 revenue \$202 , 454 , 000 , recurring monthly revenue \$1 , 986 , 667

Security 101 passed from Gemspring Capital to **Morgan Stanley Capital Partners** on 2026-02-24 . Neither the announcement nor the company's own site names fire or life safety anywhere . It is excluded from this register , and the exclusion is the finding: a sponsor-backed integrator of that size with no fire line will not appear as a bidder for fire assets .

Owner not established . ORR Protection operates 15 branches serving 50 states , reported FY2025 revenue of **\$169,428,932** and recurring monthly revenue of **\$1,254,129** , and has acquired Compass Fire Protection (Aug 2025 , union sprinkler capability and Pacific Northwest presence) and Detection & Suppression International (Oct 2024 , Texas) . CPI Security Systems reported FY2025 revenue of **\$185,000,000** and recurring monthly revenue of **\$13,100,000** . **For a buyer , an active acquirer with no identified owner is the most dangerous entry in a register : it cannot be graded on hold period , and it may or may not be a competing bidder .**

4.4 Permanent capital, family and strategic holders — and manufacturers

Different underwriting logic applies to permanent holders , with two consequences to price in . **They do not create the supply of secondary assets a sponsor does , so none returns to market on a fund clock . And they compete differently , because they can win a founder-led process on continuity and values rather than on price .**

HOLDER	ASSET	BASIS OF HOLDING	SCALE EVIDENCE
Markel Group (NYSE: MKL) , Markel Ventures	VSC Fire & Security, Inc .	Agreement announced 2019-11-08 ; additional terms not disclosed	1,200+ people ; 21 offices across 9 states and DC ; founded 1958
Minimax Viking	Cosco Fire Protection , Cosco DAS , Firetrol Protection Systems	Gryphon Investors held the predecessor from 2005 and exited in 2007 to "MX Mercury Beteiligungen GMBH ('Minimax') , a global fire and life safety company owned by Industrial Kapital and management" (Gryphon portfolio page , retrieved 2026-07-29)	Branches across CA , WA , OR , CO and NV
Mark Ein (entrepreneur-investor , Chairman)	Kastle Systems International	Individual owner , not a fund	FY2025 revenue \$282,000,000 , recurring monthly revenue \$12,800,000
Armstrong Group	Guardian Protection	Widely reported , not primary-verified	FY2025 revenue \$214,411,000 , recurring monthly revenue \$12,762,000 ; bought a commercial alarm accounts division on 2025-03-27 — 8,300 commercial and 4,300 residential accounts in PA , WV and OH
The Philadelphia Contributionship	Vector Security	Partnered since 1982 ; no ownership percentage on the holder's own page and none assumed here	FY2025 revenue \$454,590,000 , recurring monthly revenue \$20,075,000
Westphal family · Family-owned · Independent	Bay Alarm Company · Per Mar Security Services · Guardian Alarm Company	Family and independent ownership	FY2025 revenue \$263,766,868 and \$158,462,703 respectively , with recurring monthly revenue of \$17,240,000 and \$5,197,677

Markel is the clearest case and the one most often left out of sponsor trackers . **An insurance balance sheet buying a sprinkler contractor is a structurally different competitor from a fund with a five-year hold** , and the acquirer's own release quotes the seller on values and continuity rather than price . Minimax Viking matters for a different reason : the western-US sprinkler franchise trackers still attribute to a private-equity sponsor has been strategically held for nearly two decades , and neither operating brand's own site states an owner .

Manufacturers under sponsors are underwritten separately again . They carry engineering and channel economics rather than inspection density , they matter to a services buyer chiefly as supplier-side counterparties , and **their brand names are the single most dangerous class of token in a target register** . Three exist : **Kidde Global Solutions** under Lone Star Funds , being Carrier's Commercial and Residential Fire

business closed 2024-12-02 at **\$3 billion** enterprise value , carrying Kidde , Badger , Edwards Signaling , FIREX , Kidde Commercial , GST and Aritech ; **Spectrum Safety Solutions** under Sentinel Capital Partners , being Carrier's Industrial Fire business closed 2024-07-02 at **\$1 . 425 billion** , with ≈1 , 400 employees in more than 20 countries and no US branch network published ; and **Marioff** , the HI-FOG water-mist business agreed to Inflexion on 2026-03-31 with terms not disclosed .

Both sponsor-owned manufacturer platforms exist only because Carrier left , and the sequence inside the industrial carve-out is the more instructive half of the story : the sponsor bought a four-brand bundle in July 2024 and agreed to sell one of the four twenty months later . **The register consequence inverts the usual failure mode : a US business whose name contains Kidde , Badger , Edwards , FIREX , GST or Aritech is overwhelmingly a dealer , distributor or independent service company using the product , not an owned entity .** Name-matching those tokens into an "already owned" bucket suppresses genuinely independent targets .

4.5 Why a target list must match on domain, not name

Three brand policies operate in this market and each has a different consequence for anyone trying to tell an independent business from an owned one . **Absorb everything :** the acquired name disappears at or shortly after close — Protegis and Performance Systems Integration into Summit Fire & Security , ADT Commercial into Everon , Corbett Technology Solutions into Pavion . At the extreme the acquired name never becomes public at all : one acquirer's bolt-ons are disclosed only as counts and aggregate consideration , with four Q1-2026 targets described as "individually immaterial acquisitions" at \$25M aggregate . **Under this policy a target list built on trading names will show the business as independent indefinitely . Prefix the legacy name :** the acquired brand survives as a division of the parent , which keeps the operating name searchable and the ownership discoverable in the same string — the only policy that makes ownership legible from the brand . **House of brands :** regional identities are retained deliberately , so **a single owner presents to a screen as four or five separate independents in four or five separate metros .**

The collision traps below are not edge cases . They are the ordinary condition of this market , and each produces a specific , silent error — a name match either buries an independent target inside an owned bucket , or surfaces an already-owned business as available .

TOKEN	OWNERS AND NAMEPLATES	RESOLUTION
Guardian	Five unrelated entities : Guardian Fire Services (Investcorp , Nashville TN) · Guardian Fire Protection Services (Knox Lane , Rockville MD) · Guardian Protection (Armstrong Group) · Guardian Alarm Company (independent) · "Guardian" as a named Encore affiliated brand partner	Domain only , maximum severity
Absolute	4 nameplates under three owners plus one variant , across the Midwest , Paragould AR , Glendale AZ and Piscataway NJ	Domain plus state
Total Fire · Elite Fire · Allstate · Reliable Fire · Approved · Advanced Fire · Premier · Alpine · AAA Fire · Coastal · Superior Fire Protection · Mid-Atlantic Fire Protection · Empire · Star Fire	Each is reused across two or three of Pye-Barker , Encore , Sciens , CertaSite , National Fire & Safety , Altus and API units , and several collide with unrelated national brands	Domain , or name plus state
National Fire & Safety	The Highview platform · National Fire Suppression under Western States Fire Protection (APi) · "National Fire & Safety Solutions" listed by Encore	Domain only ; the exact phrase is still unsafe
Western ... Fire Protection · Summit · United Alarm Service(s) · ASG	Reused across unrelated corporate families and , in one case , across a non-fire subsidiary of the same parent	Full string or domain

TOKEN	OWNERS AND NAMEPLATES	RESOLUTION
Kidde · Badger · Edwards · FIREX · GST · Aritech	Manufacturer brands ; matches will be dealers and distributors , not owned entities	Domain only
Sonitrol	A franchise network ; one platform owns some franchises and not all franchisees nationwide	Domain only
Short acronyms — NEFS, FSI, OSI, ESS, WSA, FS&S, LPS, ASG, HEIM, SEi, PASS, SGTS, VSC, ORR, ACT, IFP, NFS, TFA, RCI, GW, 3S, DU	Four characters or fewer ; these collide across industries	Never match bare initialisms
Surname-only tokens — Gorham, Franklin, Patterson, Kimble, Craynon, Teasley, Hamrick, Eastman, Spears, Flannery, Rich, Ellis	Match unrelated firms in every trade	Name plus state , or domain

Two sponsor-name coincidences that are not what they look like . *Blackstone Fire Control* was acquired by Impact Fire and has nothing to do with Blackstone the sponsor — which happens to own Impact Fire's parent , making the coincidence actively misleading . *Sentinel Fire Safety* is a named Encore affiliated brand partner and has nothing to do with Sentinel Capital Partners .

Stale rebrands compound it . All 31 Sciens legacy nameplates now trade as "Sciens <Legacy> Division", so a list carrying them as independents is wrong 31 times from one platform . Marmic rebrands everything with no sub-brand pages , so it must be caught by domain and by legacy names . Pye-Barker uses two formulas that mean different things — "formerly X" means the legacy sign is down , "X, A Pye-Barker Fire & Safety Company" means it is still up and a name match still works . The Davis-Ulmer family renamed from sprinkler to fire across seven nameplates .

The subsidiary exhibit under-counts live trading names . The listed pure-play's FY2025 exhibit runs 203 rows , and legacy US operating entities are being deleted from it as they merge into consolidation vehicles — Western States Fire Protection Company , Grunau Company , Security Fire Protection Company , Metropolitan Mechanical Contractors , Tessier's , Sunland Fire Protection , Delta Fire Systems , Landmark Sprinkler and Olsen Fire Protection all appear in the 2020 and FY2021 exhibits and are absent from FY2025 . **Every one is still a live trading nameplate with a branch , a licence and a truck livery .** The current exhibit alone under-counts by roughly thirty names .

Two absences carry weight in the other direction . Pye-Barker publishes 144 brand names and **zero brand-level domains** , the largest single unmatched estate in the industry by count ; Encore's 75 named brand partners likewise carry no domains and no geography . Both are name-only rosters attached to the two most acquisitive platforms in the sector .

The instruction that follows . Ownership must be established per legal entity from a primary source , never inferred from a trading name , and **the absence of a brand from this record is not evidence that the business is unowned** . A register built from published rosters can only see what platforms choose to publish , and the two largest estates publish the least .

4.6 Add-on cadence

The bifurcation is the finding . One platform is closing deals at roughly an order of magnitude above everyone else , so **a sponsor entering this market is not competing against one cadence but against two very different ones at once** .

PLATFORM	ADD-ONS	PERIOD	IMPLIED CADENCE
Pye-Barker Fire & Safety	57 for calendar 2025 on the company's own count , against 41 for the same company and period on a sector tracker's count	calendar 2025	≈4 . 75 closings a month on the company count
CertaSite (under Riverside)	21st add-on at 2023-09-13 ; 26th at 2024-03-13	Sep 2023 – Mar 2024	5 in 6 months
Guardian Fire Services (Nashville) · Altus · Sciens · National Fire & Safety	12 to 2025-12-03 · 8 across 2021-2024 · 13 since 2016 · 6 dated add-ons 2019-2022	various	≈3 . 0 · ≈2 . 7 · ≈2 . 6 · ≈2 . 4 a year
AI Fire · Performance Systems Integration · Encore · Summit · Marmic · Convergent	20 under a prior sponsor · 16 to 2025-08-12 · 70+ with 75 brand partners named · 82 since 1999 , 55 strategic · "over 30 companies" · over 40 since 2018	various	not annualisable
API Group	Not counted by number	FY2025 ; Q1 2026	\$186 million of cash acquisitions in FY2025 ; more than \$1 billion signed or closed across three deals in Q1 2026

The two counts for the fastest consolidator's 2025 programme — 57 on the company's own release (PRNewswire , 2026-03-17) and 41 on a sector tracker (Capstone , 2026-02-02) — both stand . **Neither publication states a cut-off date or a counting rule** , so the sixteen-deal difference has no established cause and neither figure should be presented without the other .

On either count , that platform consumed dozens of sellers in one year , most of them small enough that no other platform on this list was structured to absorb them at that rate . Below it sits a long tail running two to three deliberate deals a year , and one dense pocket in the middle : CertaSite added five businesses in six months while its sponsor was preparing it for a strategic exit . Both patterns matter and they are priced differently . **Against an absorber closing several deals a month , a sub-\$5 million seller in a covered metro will already have been called . Against a 2 . 5-a-year platform , the same seller may never have been .**

Two supporting figures on the direction of travel . Pye-Barker grew 587% across 2021 to 2024 , and its recurring monthly revenue went from **\$15 . 3 million** in 2023 to **\$50 , 391 , 844** at 2025-12-31 — **overwhelmingly acquisition-driven and not to be read as organic** . Performance Systems Integration , over one sponsor's hold , went from 4 locations to 14 , from 108 employees to over 450 , and from 64 technicians to 279 , ending with 21 , 000+ customers before it was bought .

4.7 Control changes, last 24 months

Most large transaction figures in this market reach print through trade press citing unnamed sources , with the parties declining to disclose terms . Values marked **Disclosed** were published by a party or a filer ; values attributed to an outlet were not confirmed by any party , and in several cases the parties' own releases state terms were not disclosed . **Both states are shown rather than blended .**

DATE	ENTITY	TO	VALUE
2024-07-02	Carrier Industrial Fire → Spectrum Safety Solutions	Sentinel Capital Partners	\$1 . 425 billion enterprise value , Disclosed
2024-07-24	Marmic Fire & Safety , from HGGC	KKR	not disclosed
2024-12-02	Carrier Commercial and Residential Fire → Kidde Global Solutions	Lone Star Funds	\$3 billion enterprise value , Disclosed
2024-12-10	Becklar , from BV Investment Partners , which rolled its stake	Graham Partners	not disclosed

DATE	ENTITY	TO	VALUE
2025-02-06	AI Fire , from TruArc Partners, which retained a stake	Blackstone	Seller's release names neither buyer nor price; reported at ≈\$1.1 billion including debt (Bloomberg, 2025-02-07)
announced 2025-02-06	Encore Fire Protection , from Levine Leichtman	Permira	Not disclosed by any party; reported at \$1.8 billion (Bloomberg, 2025-02-06; Alternatives Watch, 2025-03-13)
2025-08-04	Summit Companies / SFP Holding , majority, from BlackRock Long Term Private Capital	BDT & MSD Partners	not disclosed
2025-08-12	Performance Systems Integration , from The Riverside Company	Summit Fire & Security	not disclosed
2025-10-01	ADT's business-to-business multifamily segments	Everon (GTCR)	Everon's release states no price; reported at \$55 million (Dallas Innovates)
2025-10-28 · 2025-12-03	FSS Technologies , new platform · Guardian Fire Services , from Northern Lakes Capital	Lightview Capital · Investcorp	not disclosed
closed 2026-02-02	CertaSite , from The Riverside Company	APi Group — strategic, funded from cash on hand	Consideration disclosed in the acquirer's filings; FY2025 revenue "approximately \$90 million", Disclosed
2026-02-24 · 2026-03-31	Security 101 , from Gemspring · Marioff , a division of Spectrum Safety Solutions	Morgan Stanley Capital Partners · Inflexion	not disclosed
2026-06-08 · 2026-07-01	Onyx-Fire Protection Services (Canada) · WTech Fire Group (Europe)	APi Group	Annual revenue "approximately \$190 million" and "approximately \$175 million", Disclosed

Fifteen control changes in twenty-four months across fire services, fire products and the monitoring infrastructure beneath them.

Minority rounds are not control changes. Pye-Barker took minority investments from an ADIA subsidiary and from GIC closing January 2025, while Altas Partners retained its majority and Leonard Green invested significant new capital; terms were not disclosed. **That is capital in, not a seller out, and it produces no secondary asset. Continuation vehicles are not exits.** Convergent's sponsors closed an **\$850 million** single-asset continuation vehicle on 2026-03-02 — a figure that is **total commitments to the vehicle and not the enterprise value of the company**. The signal runs opposite to a sale: the largest security systems integrator in the country, one that names fire and life safety in its own service description, has been recapitalised rather than sold, stays in the market as a bidder, and is under no pressure to exit. **Asset and book purchases are a third category**, moving accounts rather than platforms, and should not be counted as platform transactions.

PART V — REGIONALITY & COVERAGE

5.1 What can be mapped, and what cannot

City-level branch rosters exist and are genuinely useful , but only for a named subset of platform units . They are **named cities , not metropolitan statistical areas** , and **no platform publishes a branch count per metro** .

Units with a published city-level roster : Western States Fire Protection (APi) at 36 branded office entries across 35 distinct cities plus 5 sub-brand nameplates — 41 named offices against a stated "More Than 45 Locations Across the Western U.S." ; Marmic at 53 branch cities across 20 states ; Summit Fire Protection at 34 named cities across nine states ; Encore at 33 branches across 13 states ; Sciens at 31 divisions each with a named city ; Viking Fire Protection Group (APi) at 21 ; CertaSite (APi) stating 17 locations and enumerating 16 cities ; American Fire Protection Group (APi) at 13 ; Cosco Fire Protection at 12 ; National Fire & Safety at 8 across 5 states . The Davis-Ulmer family , International Fire Protection and Everon publish partial rosters only .

Platforms that publish no city-level footprint at all : AI Fire , Altus , Converging , Pavion , Zeus , both Guardian platforms , ORR Protection , ASPYRE , Spectrum Safety Solutions and Relay Fire and Safety .

How much of the largest roster is captured . Pye-Barker states 253 locations across 47 states with 256 location URLs enumerated . Its canonical brands page names 144 businesses with no domains and no cities ; a further ≈60 trading names carry a named city . **City-level detail therefore exists for roughly a quarter of the largest estate in the industry , and the platform closing the most deals a year is the one whose geography is least completely on the record .**

The instruction that follows . No saturation index , share-of-metro figure or ranking of under-consolidated territories should be published off this base . Three defects make it unfit : named cities cannot be aggregated to metropolitan areas without a crosswalk , no unit publishes branches per metro , and the two largest rosters are the least complete . **Any metro-level density claim requires a licence registry or an equivalent independent second source .** What follows is a screening base for finding overlap that demonstrably exists , and nothing more .

5.2 Metro overlap, for the named subset

Built on **exact named-city matches within the subset of units publishing city-level rosters** . It understates overlap in two directions : adjacent-city presence in the same metro is not counted , and the platforms above that publish no cities contribute nothing .

DISTINCT OWNERS	NAMED CITIES
4 owners	Phoenix AZ (two APi units , Summit , Marmic , National Fire & Safety ; Telgian is headquartered here) · Colorado Springs CO (Western States , Summit , Marmic , National Fire & Safety)
3 owners	Fort Collins CO · Denver CO · Las Vegas NV · Salt Lake City UT · Houston TX · Dallas TX · San Antonio TX · Lubbock TX · Oklahoma City OK · Omaha NE · Lexington KY · Baltimore MD
2 owners	Round Rock TX · Tucson AZ · Reno NV · Tulsa OK · Springfield MO · Jefferson City MO · Des Moines IA · St. Paul MN · Duluth MN · Rochester MN · Green Bay WI · Detroit MI · Dayton OH · Louisville KY · Charlotte NC · Miami FL · Tampa FL · Los Angeles CA · San Diego CA · San Francisco CA · Seattle WA · Spokane WA · Atlanta GA · Washington DC

Two patterns are worth naming . **The Colorado Front Range and the Phoenix and Texas metros are the densest verified overlap in the country** , with four owners in two cities and three in twelve more . And

Albuquerque NM and Columbus OH each carry two APi units and no other owner — a different condition entirely: an owner consolidating a metro against itself, not competing for it.

5.3 Whitespace signals

These are screening priors, not conclusions. The mapping above is incomplete by construction, and **in this market absence of evidence is emphatically not evidence of absence**.

States appearing in no verified operating footprint: Alaska alone. Every other state appears in at least one named platform's published roster. The only Alaska presence anywhere in the record is an Alaska-incorporated entity in a 2020 subsidiary exhibit, absent from the current one. One state out of fifty is the honest measure of unclaimed territory at state level, and it is small and structurally difficult.

The interior West and Plains are not empty, and a register that treats them as empty will be wrong. Idaho carries two Western States units across three cities plus three Pye-Barker nameplates; Wyoming a Western States office at Casper; North Dakota Summit at Fargo and Williston and ICS at Grand Forks; South Dakota Summit at two cities, a Western States office at Aberdeen and a Pye-Barker nameplate at Rapid City; Nebraska Summit at two cities, VFP Fire Systems and Marmic at Omaha and three Pye-Barker nameplates; Kansas Marmic at three cities, National Fire Suppression at Kansas City and a Pye-Barker nameplate at Garden City; New Mexico two units at Albuquerque; Montana Western States at three cities plus a Pye-Barker nameplate. **Oklahoma carries four owners.**

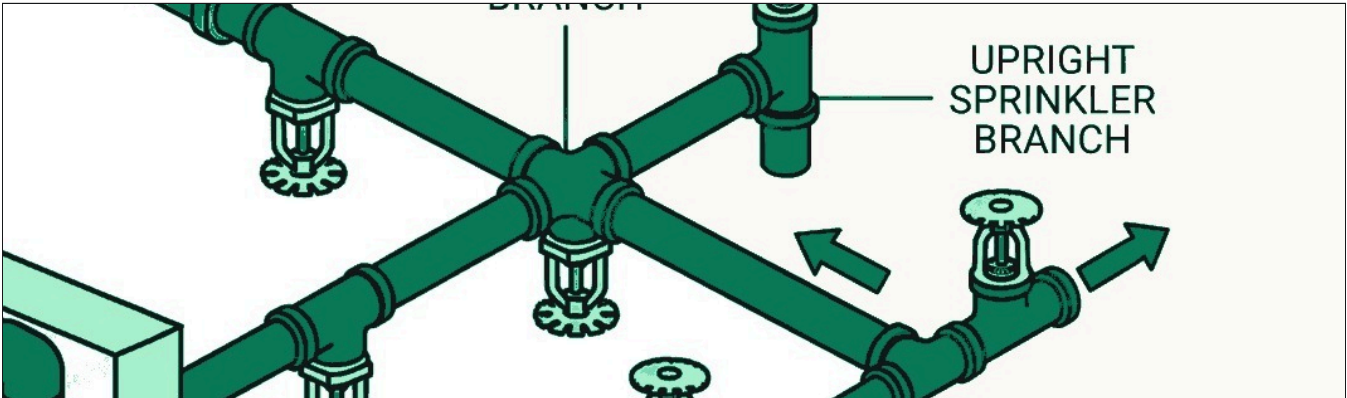
States a major platform entered for the first time recently. The most acquisitive platform in the country names "entrances into Hawaii and Arkansas" as 2025 events (PRNewswire, 2026-03-17). It had no presence in either before 2025, which makes both **the strongest primary-source whitespace indicator available** — not because those states are unoccupied now, but because the buyer with the widest funnel had not reached them until then.

Two further signals, both from sponsors' own choices. Percheron launched ASPYRE in November 2025 with a foundational partner in the **Southern United States** and a stated intent to expand nationally — that sponsor's own assessment of where unclaimed density remained as of late 2025. And ORR Protection's acquisition of Compass Fire Protection in August 2025 was framed as adding union sprinkler capability and **Pacific Northwest** presence, which identifies a capability gap rather than a geographic one.

A signal about service lines rather than metros. Summit Fire & Security runs single-service branches: **extinguishers only** at Portland OR and Seattle WA, and a dedicated **marine** branch at Fort Lauderdale FL. **A platform that opens a single-line branch in a metro is present without being dense there, and the remaining lines in that metro are open ground.** Those three cities are the only places in the verified rosters where a platform states its own coverage is partial by service line.

PART VI – VALUATION & THE DEAL RECORD

6.1 Five populations that are not comparable



Every recurring error in this market's valuation commentary is a population error . A multiple is meaningless without the population it was struck in , and the five below are reported separately throughout . They are not blended anywhere in this report , and no range in this report spans two of them .

#	POPULATION	DEFINITION APPLIED	OBSERVATIONS CARRYING A MULTIPLE
P1	Platform / carve-out	A business of roughly \$50M+ operating earnings bought by a sponsor or strategic , with its own management , brand and profit-and-loss statement	3 with a disclosed or derivable earnings multiple
P2	Bolt-on / tuck-in	A \$1-5M operating-earnings independent bought by an existing platform	0 with a per-deal disclosed multiple ; 1 programme-level disclosed threshold
P3	Recurring-monthly-revenue multiple	A multiple of <i>monthly</i> recurring revenue , the alarm and monitoring convention	2 populations : size-banded market averages , and one disclosed bulk-account transaction
P4	Public trading comparables	Listed acquirers and adjacents at a stated observation date	10 tickers , vendor data dates 2026-06-07 to 2026-07-29
P5	Product / OEM adjacency	Fire detection , suppression and gas-detection <i>manufacturers</i> , not service contractors	3 transactions ; 1 with a derivable earnings multiple

P5 exists because the three largest 2024-2026 transactions carrying a disclosed enterprise value are manufacturers . **Reading them as fire-services comparables is the most available category error in the record** , and it is available precisely because they are the only large transactions in the sector with a published price .

Four further populations appear as benchmarks and are equally never blended with the five above or with each other : **industry-agnostic size-banded private transactions** (GF Data) ; **portfolio marks** rather than transactions (Lincoln International's ≈7 , 100 US private companies valued for private funds , median \$60 . 6M of last-twelve-months adjusted operating earnings , at 11 . 7x , Q1 2026 data) ; **banker survey expectations** (Capstone's 6 . 8x "typical" and 9 . 8x "premium" for 2026 , sample size not disclosed) ; and **continuation vehicles** , which are valuation events without a competitive clearing price , priced by a lead secondary buyer against a net-asset-value reference rather than by an auction .

6.2 Public trading comparables

All rows from a market-data vendor's statistics pages retrieved 2026-07-29 , each carrying the vendor's own stated data date rather than a uniform observation date . Enterprise value compares the whole business , debt included , against its operating earnings .

TICKER	COMPANY	ENTERPRISE VALUE	EV/EBITDA	EV/REVENUE	DATA DATE	RELEVANCE
APG	APi Group	\$19.41B	21.47	2.37	2026-07-28	Pure-play life-safety services consolidator
JCI	Johnson Controls	\$94.41B	26.36	3.86	2026-07-29	Fire plus building management
FIX	Comfort Systems USA	\$55.61B	27.74	4.95	2026-07-29	Mechanical and electrical contractor including fire protection
EME	EMCOR Group	\$30.97B	15.52	1.74	2026-07-29	Mechanical and electrical contractor
ADT	ADT Inc.	\$12.94B	7.62	2.52	2026-07-29	Residential monitoring , after the commercial divestiture
CARR	Carrier Global	\$63.51B	22.59	2.87	2026-07-28	Former owner of both divested fire businesses
MSA	MSA Safety	\$7.28B	15.80	3.80	2026-07-24	Safety and detection products
CTAS	Cintas	\$89.71B	28.76	7.96	2026-07-29	Uniform and facility services with a Fire Protection segment
CNM	Core & Main	\$10.81B	11.76	1.41	2026-07-29	Waterworks and fire-protection <i>distribution</i>
HLMA.L	Halma plc (GBP)	£18.25B	30.46	7.57	2026-06-07	UK safety and detection products group

Every multiple is a data vendor's computation attributing its underlying data to S&P Global Market Intelligence , and **no issuer's own adjusted-earnings definition has been reconciled to the vendor's denominator** . The sterling row carries a data date seven-plus weeks earlier than the US names and is not currency-converted ; these are not one simultaneous observation and are not presented as one .

The panel does not resolve into a single population . EMCOR at 15.52x and Comfort Systems at 27.74x are both mechanical and electrical contractors , **12.22 turns apart** . Three independently constructed versions of roughly the same listed-contractor idea span 14.8x to 27.74x : the vendor panel above , Houlihan Lokey's Industrial Services set at 17.2x on 2025 actual and 14.8x on 2026 estimated (Q4 2025) , and Chesapeake's Construction Services set at 17.8x mean and 16.0x median as of 2026-03-31 . **That span is the honest width of what the listed comparables say** . ADT at 7.62x is the lowest and the only name that is now a pure monitoring and recurring-revenue business in a listed wrapper ; Cintas is the highest revenue multiple on the board , on a business where fire protection is a minority operating segment inside a uniform-rental company — **it prices route density , not fire protection** .

6.3 The transaction record

The record starts in 2021 : no fire and life safety transaction announced in 2019 or 2020 carries a disclosed enterprise value or multiple . Most large figures reach print through trade press citing unnamed sources ; where that is the case the outlet is named and the row carries no derived multiple .

DATE	TARGET	ACQUIRER	DISCLOSED VALUE	DENOMINATOR	MULTIPLE
closed 2022-01-03	Chubb Fire & Security (Carrier carve-out)	API Group	\$3.1B (\$2.9B cash plus ≈\$200M assumed liabilities)	2020 actual revenue ≈\$2.2B; adjusted operating margin ≈9.6%	≈ 13.3x last-twelve-months adjusted operating earnings including synergies , struck in the pre-2023 rate regime
closed 2022-07-22	STANLEY Security	Securitas AB	\$3,200M , debt- and cash-free	none	none
closed 2023-10-02	ADT Commercial (renamed Everon)	GTCR	\$1,613M in the seller's reconciliation; "\$1.6 billion" headline; net cash proceeds \$1,563M	Commercial adjusted operating earnings \$158M to 2023-06-30, less \$(14)M estimated corporate cost allocation = \$144M	≈ 11.2x on \$144M after allocation; 10.2x on the pre-allocation denominator, both printed in the same exhibit
closed 2024-06-03	Carrier Access Solutions (adjacent)	Honeywell	\$4.95B enterprise value	none	none
closed 2024-07 · 2024-12-02	Carrier Industrial Fire → Spectrum Safety Solutions · Carrier Commercial & Residential Fire → Kidde Global Solutions	Sentinel Capital Partners · Lone Star Funds	\$1.425B · \$3B enterprise value	none	none
2025-01-10	Pye-Barker, minority stakes	ADIA and GIC, with new capital from Leonard Green	"Financial terms were not disclosed."	none	none
Bloomberg 2025-02-06 · 2025-02-07	Encore Fire Protection · AI Fire	Permira · Blackstone	Reported at \$1.8B and ≈ \$1.1B including debt ; the sponsors' and advisers' releases state terms were not disclosed, and one seller's release names neither buyer nor price	none	none
closed 2025-08-21	Performance Systems Integration	Summit Fire & Security	not disclosed	none	none
closed 2025-10-01	ADT multifamily business (bulk accounts)	Everon	"approximately \$55,000,000 in cash"	≈ 200,000 units representing ≈ \$2.6M recurring monthly revenue	≈ 21.15x recurring monthly revenue; ≈\$275 per unit
closed 2026-02-02	CertaSite, LLC	API Group	\$271M total consideration (\$268M cash plus \$3M escrow)	FY2025 revenue ≈ \$90M	≈ 3.01x revenue; no earnings multiple obtainable
closed 2026-03-02	Convergent continuation vehicle	Ares, led by Leonard Green	≈ \$850M in total commitments — the size of the vehicle, not an enterprise value	none; the only performance disclosure is "approximately quadrupled Adjusted EBITDA" since 2018, with no base	none
closed 2026-06-08 · 2026-07-01	Onyx-Fire (Canada) · WTech Fire Group (Ireland)	API Group	not disclosed separately	≈ \$190M · ≈\$175M annual revenue	none

DATE	TARGET	ACQUIRER	DISCLOSED VALUE	DENOMINATOR	MULTIPLE
closed 2026-07-09	Autronica Fire and Security	MSA Safety , from Sentinel	"approximately \$555 million"	2025 sales "approximately \$160 million" at an "adjusted EBITDA margin of approximately 20%"	Derivable , but a manufacturer multiple in population P5 and not a services comparable

Two conflicts in the disclosed record are carried rather than reconciled . Carrier's press release of 2024-12-02 gives net proceeds on the Commercial & Residential Fire sale of "approximately \$2 . 2 billion" while its FY2024 10-K states "cash proceeds of \$2 . 9 billion" ; both stand and neither document reconciles them . On the commercial carve-out , the headline price is "\$1 . 6 billion" , the seller's reconciliation uses \$1 , 613M and net cash proceeds at close were \$1 , 563M ; all three stand .

That reconciliation carries the most transferable lesson in the record . The exhibit prints two multiples and the pairing matters : **10 . 2x before the corporate-cost allocation , 11 . 2x after it .** The disclosed 11 . 2x is struck on \$144M , after deducting \$14M of estimated allocated corporate costs from the \$158M of commercial adjusted operating earnings the same release reports . Building a comparable from the headline pair books the transaction roughly a full turn below what the seller disclosed . **A carve-out earnings figure quoted before corporate-cost allocation is not the earnings figure the multiple was struck on ,** and the bridge appears only in a reconciliation table beneath the headline .

Twelve further control changes across the period carry no disclosed value at all — Sciens to Carlyle , Summit to BlackRock Long Term Private Capital , Protegis to Summit Fire & Security , the partial Convergent stake to Leonard Green and Harvest , Guardian Fire Protection Services to Knox Lane , Marmic to KKR , Becklar to Graham Partners , FSS Technologies to Lightview , Guardian Fire Services to Investcorp , Security 101 to Morgan Stanley Capital Partners , Minuteman to Tenex , and VSC Fire & Security to Markel . **Each was checked individually as undisclosed rather than assumed to be .**

The bolt-on end of the record is disclosed only in aggregate . One acquirer's investor materials give a programme series — 3 bolt-ons for \$9M (2019) , 7 for \$42M (2020) , 12 for \$114M (2021) , 1 for \$5M (2022) , 7 for \$98M (2023) , 12 for \$250M (2024) — under a printed subheading stating a weighted-average adjusted operating-earnings multiple for bolt-ons below 6x in each of those years , excluding four named larger transactions and non-material customer account purchases (APi Investor Update , 2025-02-27 , p . 12) . The FY2025 10-K adds 14 businesses at \$233M of total net consideration , all individually immaterial ; the FY2024 filings resolve into 12 businesses matching the deck's count exactly , at \$244M against the deck's \$250M , a \$6M difference neither document reconciles . Cintas discloses \$232 . 9M and \$186 . 8M of acquisition cash for fiscal 2025 and 2024 across three segments , with no allocation and no deal count .

The consequence is a finding in its own right . **No US public filer discloses a per-deal fire-services tuck-in purchase price against a target's earnings .**

6.4 Recurring-monthly-revenue multiples — the second language

Recurring-monthly-revenue multiples and earnings multiples are **different languages on different denominators , and the conversion between them is not available .** An earnings multiple prices the whole enterprise : install revenue , service revenue , monitoring revenue and the overhead supporting all three . A recurring-monthly-revenue multiple prices only the contracted monthly monitoring stream , as a multiple of one month of it — a book-of-accounts price , used because alarm accounts have historically been bought and sold like receivables , independent of the business that installed them .

The one market series with a named methodology and a named presenter comes from Michael Barnes of Barnes Associates , presented in the closing keynote at the Electronic Security Expo and reported by Paul Rothman (Barnes Associates via SecurityInfoWatch , 2025-08-18): sellers under **\$50 , 000** of recurring monthly revenue averaged **36x** monthly revenue , and sellers above **\$500 , 000** averaged **46x** . The transaction year those averages describe is given as 2024 in one account of the keynote and as a 2025 average in another ; both stand , and no 2026 update exists . **These are market aggregates and are not attributable to any named transaction .**

One disclosed transaction does produce one , and it is its own population . An 8-K states a purchase price of "approximately \$55 , 000 , 000 in cash" for "approximately 200 , 000 multifamily business customer units representing approximately \$2 . 6 million of recurring monthly revenue" (ADT 8-K , 2025-09-15) , which is $\approx 21 . 15x$ at $\approx \$275$ per unit and $\approx \$13 . 00$ of monthly recurring revenue per unit . **It must not be read against the market bands .** It is a bulk account and asset purchase rather than a company purchase — no branch infrastructure , no technicians , no backlog — in residential multifamily , the lowest-recurring-revenue-per-unit segment , sold by a seller that had already sold its commercial arm to the buyer's sponsor two years earlier , with a non-compete running only through 2028-10-02 . **It is a legitimate , fully disclosed data point for bulk residential multifamily accounts and for nothing else .**

The conversion problem is arithmetic , not judgement . Dividing a monthly multiple by 12 gives a multiple of annual recurring revenue : 46x becomes 3 . 83x and 36x becomes 3 . 00x . Converting either to an earnings multiple requires an operating margin on recurring revenue , and no source supplies one . The only margin figure in the record is a monitoring and services *gross* margin of **51 . 2%** , reported down from 53 . 9% in 2017 , with recurring gross margins having declined from 54% in 2015 and stabilised on 3-4% annual price increases with minimal attrition impact (Barnes Buchanan via SDM , 2026-02-16) . Applied honestly that converts 46x into $\approx 7 . 49x$ of annualised monitoring gross profit and 36x into $\approx 5 . 86x$ — figures struck before any selling , branch , general , administrative or corporate cost . **They are not earnings multiples .**

The instruction is unambiguous . **Do not convert a recurring-monthly-revenue multiple into an earnings multiple and present the result as a valuation .** Price the recurring book at a recurring-revenue multiple , price the install and service business at an earnings multiple , and add them . A single blended multiple quoted for an alarm business with meaningful install revenue conceals which side of the business the price is on .

6.5 The platform-versus-tuck-in spread

The roll-up thesis stated as a number requires a benchmark at the small end , and **the only one that exists is industry-agnostic** . GF Data's population is North American transactions of \$10M-\$500M total enterprise value , where the buyers are private equity firms , independent sponsors , family offices and mezzanine funds — 330-plus contributors submitting blind and confidentially — with **all industries pooled** (GF Data , Q3 2025 , data through 2025-09-30) .

ENTERPRISE VALUE BAND	2023	2024	YTD 2025	ALL-PERIOD	N
\$10-25M	5.9	6.4	6.4	5.9	2,084
\$25-50M	6.9	6.8	6.8	6.7	1,671
\$50-100M	8.1	8.1	8.3	7.7	1,156
\$100-250M	9.5	8.5	10.3	8.6	654
\$250-500M	10.2	9.8	8.5	9.7	104
Total	7.2	7.2	7.3	6.9	5,669

By target earnings size, the **\$3–5M** band cleared at 6.7x in year-to-date 2025 on 1,503 all-period observations and the **over-\$10M** band at 8.3x on 1,238. The edition consulted pools all industries into eight buckets, none of them fire or specialty trade, though the publisher separately produces industry-level breakouts including one for specialty trade contractors that was not obtained; a fire ITM contractor would be classified by the contributor, most plausibly into business services, which cleared at 7.5x on 1,333 all-period observations.

Against that benchmark sits the only disclosed figure at the small end anywhere in US fire and life safety: one acquirer's weighted-average adjusted operating-earnings multiple for bolt-on acquisitions, disclosed as below 6x in each year from 2019 to 2024. **That disclosure is an investor-relations statement appearing in no SEC filing, and it is a bound on a weighted average rather than a series** — no multiple is disclosed for the first year of the programme, none for the last, and no sequence of annual figures is disclosed. Its 2025 programme averaged \$16.64M of consideration per deal across 14 businesses, placing it inside the \$10–25M band and implying a minimum average acquired earnings per target of over \$2.77M, just below the bottom of the \$3–5M earnings band.

What that comparison licenses: the acquirer is buying its bolt-ons at least 0.4 to 0.7 turns below what the average private equity buyer paid for identically sized businesses in the same period, and the small end of that statement is measured against a 2,084-observation benchmark rather than an assertion. Because the disclosure is a ceiling on a weighted average and not a point, the true gap is wider rather than narrower.

What it does not license. GF Data's buyers are sponsors while the acquirer is a listed strategic, and GF Data pools all industries while the acquirer buys fire and life safety, **so this is a cross-population comparison and must always be labelled as one**. It licenses no fire-specific size-tier range, because none exists. And it does not license the widest spreads in circulation, which are quotients of an unsourced trade-press numerator over one company's disclosed ceiling on its own programme — **a ceiling divided into an assertion produces a bound, not a measurement**.

The decisive caveat is what happens when one methodology measures both ends. Inside GF Data's single dataset, method and period, the size premium from the \$10–25M band to the \$100–250M band is 3.9 turns, a ratio of 1.609x; to the \$50–100M band it is 1.9 turns, a ratio of 1.297x; and by target earnings, from \$3–5M to over \$10M, 1.6 turns and 1.239x. **When one methodology measures both ends, the size premium is ≈1.24x to 1.61x.** The \$250–500M row inverts in year-to-date 2025 on only 104 lifetime observations and should not be leaned on. The listed-equity version of the same arithmetic is the mechanic in its starkest form: that acquirer's disclosed bolt-on ceiling against its 21.47x vendor-computed trading multiple at 2026-07-28 is a spread of more than 15.47 turns — both ends public, but bridging an entry multiple and a public equity multiple, **which is why it is a bound rather than a measurement**.

Two things qualify the thesis at its base. The first is durability: average consideration per bolt-on moved from \$3.0M in 2019 to \$9.5M in 2021 to \$20.8M in 2024 and \$16.64M in 2025 while the disclosed cap never moved, so either materially larger earnings are being acquired per deal at a constant multiple, or the mix of very low-multiple deals holding the weighted average below the cap is thinning. The second is competition: Pye-Barker reported 57 acquisitions in 2025 against that acquirer's 14, and a sector tracker counts 41 for the same company and period — both stand, and neither publication states a cut-off date or a counting rule. **Where two or more well-capitalised consolidators compete for the same sub-\$5M-earnings sellers, erosion appears at the bottom of the spread first.**

And the bottom of the spread cannot be tracked. No verifiable time series of bolt-on entry multiples exists in US fire and life safety; Pye-Barker, Summit, Marmic, AI Fire, VSC, Firetrol and Fortis disclose no deal values at all. **The durability of a number nobody can track is what the whole thesis rests on.** Compounding

it, the GF Data benchmark runs only through 2025-09-30, so movement during 2026 in the \$10-25M band — the single band the tuck-in thesis depends on — is not observable.

6.6 A figure the industry repeats that nobody published

The valuation range most often quoted for fire safety platforms has one origin, one date and no transaction behind it. **The chain is the finding, and it is reproduced here without restating the figure**, because the figure has no independent existence and a reader who carries it out of this report has taken the wrong thing from the section.

The origin. A trade magazine article published 2024-07-15 relayed a private-equity news outlet's report that the joint sponsors of one platform "could receive bids valuing the company" in a stated range on a stated earnings denominator, producing a stated potential deal value. The same article records that a company spokesperson declined to comment. **The sourcing behind the figures is unnamed.**

What it actually described. A prospective bid range for a single company, in the conditional — "could receive bids valuing" — reported before any process concluded, with an earnings denominator itself attributed to the outlet and unconfirmed by the company. The headline describes a market listing while the body describes bids from sponsors; both stand as printed. The three figures as printed are arithmetically consistent with one another, and the reported deal value corresponds to the bottom of the reported range rather than its middle — which establishes that they are **one assertion rather than three independent observations**.

No transaction occurred. Six months later, in January 2025, minority stakes went to ADIA and GIC with Leonard Green investing significant new capital and Altas Partners retaining the majority of its ownership interest, and "Financial terms were not disclosed" (Pye-Barker, 2025-01-10). There is no announced sale and no announced listing. **A predicted exit that resolved into an undisclosed-value minority recapitalisation is not evidence of a valuation.**

The restatement as a sector fact. Nine months after the original report the same outlet restated the range as a general condition of the sector — that sponsor-backed fire safety platforms had traded at those multiples over the past year (PE Hub, 2025-04-15). The visible text gives no sample size, no deal list and no denominator, and the article is paywalled beyond the lead.

Two attributions that do not hold. A 2026 valuation-aggregator page, last modified 2026-07-11, presents the range for "scaled platforms" and attributes it to two named advisory publications. **Neither publication contains the figure.** The security-sector update credited with it reports "averaging a robust EV/EBITDA multiple of 11.8x and EV/Revenue multiple of 2.2x over the five-year period" (Capstone, 2026-02-02) — several turns below the bottom of the attributed range. The fire alarm and life safety multiples note credited with it puts its highest tier, "Platform-ready (high RMR, low attrition, scalable ops)", at 7x to 10x on operating earnings (Breakwater M&A, 2026-02-01) — a ceiling well below the bottom of the attributed range.

The re-citation. An operating, sponsor-backed fire and security consolidator's own resource page, dated 2026-07-15, states that scaled platforms with strong recurring revenue transact in that range, citing the aggregator page as its authority (Zeus Fire and Security, 2026-07-15). A reader meeting the range on an operator's site would reasonably treat it as sector corroboration. **It is the same 2024 assertion arriving by a second route.**

The apparent multiplicity of sources — the 2024 report, the 2025 sector sentence, the aggregator page and the operator page — is one unsourced assertion counted four times. A separate range for project-heavy fire businesses travels the same route and has the same single ancestry.

The practical test follows from the shape of the chain rather than from any judgement about the publishers. A recurring-revenue range whose upper bound sits far above the published market bands, or an earnings range for fire services quoted without a named population, should be traced to its origin before use; **where the trail ends at a page whose methodology reference resolves back into its own domain, the figure has no independent existence.**

6.7 What no bank publishes

No investment bank or advisory house publishes fire-and-life-safety earnings multiples broken out by target size tier. Thirteen publications from eight houses establish this: GF Data (two), Capstone Partners (three), Lincoln International, Houlihan Lokey (two), Meridian Capital (two), Chesapeake Corporate Advisors, Grant Thornton UK and Deloitte, read in full for a size-banded fire multiple. **Not one contains one.**

The one house with a sector-dedicated update publishes twice a year. What it contains: 60-plus transactions from December 2024 to June 2025 with target, acquirer and business description, and 50-plus more in the following edition; a named investor universe; sponsor-backed acquirer deal counts spanning 4 to 100-plus with the acquirer names withheld behind a contact line; and public strategics named with counts of 20 to 55-plus. What it does not contain: **a value on any of the 133 transactions listed across the two editions, and zero multiples of any kind.** Its deal-tempo figure is edition-specific and the two editions differ — an average of 38 transactions per quarter since 2020 in the winter edition, against nearly 50 per quarter since the beginning of 2024 in the summer edition.

The nearest substitutes each measure something else. Capstone publishes 11.8x enterprise value to operating earnings and 2.2x to revenue as a five-year average across a Security Solutions universe whose segments include Fire & Life Safety alongside Physical Security, Uniformed Guard, Access Control, Metal Detection, Tactical Products and School Safety, **without breaking Fire & Life Safety out**, and without stating whether the average covers all deals or only those with disclosed multiples — which materially affects its meaning, since a disclosed-only average leans toward larger, better-advised transactions. Its buyer-type split for Q3 2025 — sponsors 12.0x, private strategics 9.8x, public strategics 8.6x — is US middle market across all industries. Houlihan Lokey's updates are public-company trading comparables across a 37-company set with no fire or life safety mention anywhere. Chesapeake's 31-company set mentions fire protection only inside target descriptions. Grant Thornton's UK review publishes no multiples at all and reports a different market — 184 UK deals in 2025, fire and security at 23% of them, and 70% of fire and security deals involving sponsor-backed corporates against 57% in 2024. Deloitte's 2026 engineering and construction outlook contains no transaction multiples and no fire or life safety mention.

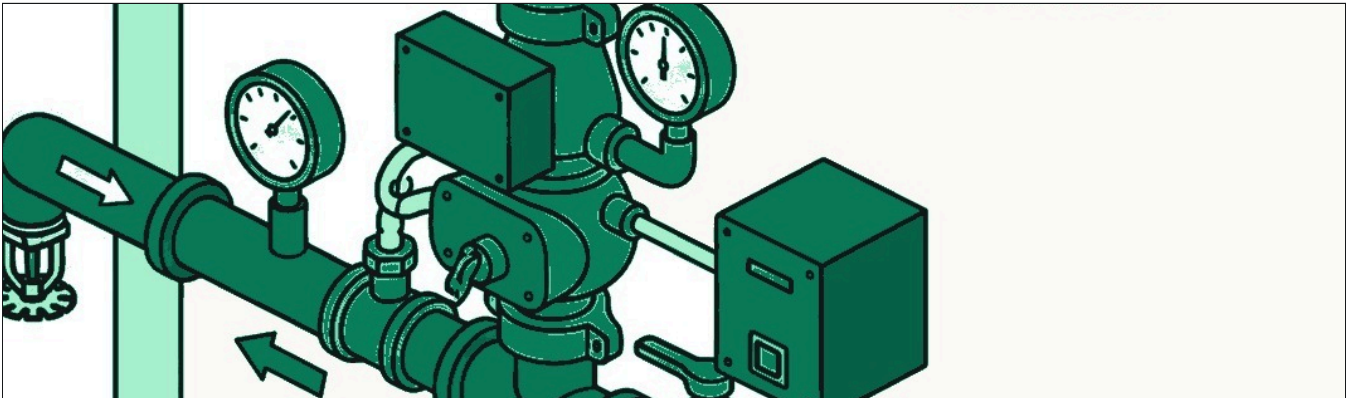
The retrieval surface compounds the gap. Across seven distinct queries for fire, life-safety and mid-market multiples, the organic result sets were dominated by unsourced valuation-aggregator pages, with a single domain returning in every query and frequently occupying four to seven of the top eight results; the genuine bank publications were reachable only by naming the house. **Any search conducted by topic rather than by publisher retrieves almost exclusively unsourced material.**

The consequence for underwriting is direct. The tuck-in end of the spread has no observed transaction anywhere in US fire and life safety. It has a benchmark that is not fire-specific, a threshold that is one company's ceiling on its own programme, and a survey of expectations rather than transactions.

Underwriting a fire-services tuck-in against a "fire multiple" means underwriting against one of those three, and the deal file should say which.

PART VII — OPERATING ECONOMICS

7.1 Margin by scale tier



Three tiers exist in the evidence , they measure different things , and **blending them is the most common error in a fire and life safety underwriting model** . They are separated here and not reconciled , because they do not reconcile .

Tier 1 — consolidated public roll-up . Whole-company figures for diversified filers , carrying centralised procurement , captive functions and no owner compensation added back . APi Group reported adjusted EBITDA of **\$1,041M** at a **13.2%** margin in FY2025 against \$893M and 12.7% in FY2024 , with adjusted free cash flow conversion of **80%** . Cintas ran a Uniform Rental operating margin of **23.49%** and a First Aid & Safety operating margin of **24.20%** .

Tier 2 — platform , segment and branch level . This is the tier that informs what a scaled fire platform earns .

SEGMENT	REVENUE	EARNINGS	MARGIN
APi Safety Services , FY2025 · FY2024	\$5,456M · \$4,797M	\$916M · \$765M segment earnings	16.79% · 15.95% ; company states 16.8% and 15.9%
APi Specialty Services , FY2025	\$2,460M	\$264M	10.7% , down 70 basis points
Cintas "All Other" (Fire Protection plus Uniform Direct Sale) , FY2025	\$1,146.0M	gross profit \$542.4M , operating income \$191.6M	gross 47.33% , operating 16.72%
Cintas "All Other" , FY2024 · FY2023	\$1,064.1M · \$967.1M	operating income \$170.0M · \$143.2M	operating 15.97% · 14.81%

Two scaled operators put a branch- or route-based fire and safety business in the mid-teens at the segment line in FY2025 . These are different measures — segment earnings against segment operating income — on very different populations : a global fire , security and elevator segment against a US route business of which fire protection is 71.33% . **Their near-identity is coincidence rather than corroboration** . What it does mean is that a buyer arguing a scaled US fire platform clears the mid-teens at the segment line has two named public reference points rather than none .

Branch-level disclosure is more useful still , and it is the only public statement of what a single operating unit earns . North American branch **median EBITDA margin ran ≈17% in 2024 against ≈13% in 2021** , with branches below a 10% margin falling from **34** to **11** ; internationally , median branch EBITDA was **11.5%** in 2024 , with loss-making branches falling from **55** in 2021 to fewer than **5** (APi Group investor day , slides 21

and 32, 2025-05-21). **Sub-scale branches exist in quantity inside a well-run platform, and they are fixable without closing them.**

Tier 3 — the small independent, which is the acquisition target population. This is the tier where the data runs out. **No survey-based or association-based EBITDA benchmark for small US fire protection contractors exists in the public record.** The trade associations covering the sprinkler, alarm and equipment-distribution trades publish none on a retrievable basis, and neither does the construction financial-management body whose benchmarking product would ordinarily carry it. **No margin figure is stated here for the small independent, because none exists that would survive contact with a diligence file.** That absence is the most decision-relevant fact on this page: **a buyer has no external benchmark against which to test a seller's margin claim**, and must build one from primary target data across several acquisitions. The one published reference point aimed at the private end of the market comes from a sell-side adviser — "Margins in excess of 20% [EBITDA] indicative of strong labor and operational efficiency" (Meridian Capital, Winter 2025). It is a threshold characterisation rather than a distribution, and **it cannot stand in for the benchmark that does not exist.**

What can be substituted is a government-sourced **cost-structure ceiling** for the container trade that fire sprinkler contracting is classified inside — plumbing, heating and air-conditioning contractors, 114,427 US employer establishments, within which sprinkler work is a small minority of receipts.

2022 ECONOMIC CENSUS, NAICS 238220, US EMPLOYER ESTABLISHMENTS	\$ THOUSAND	% OF TOTAL RECEIPTS
Total receipts	297,608,835	100.00%
Annual payroll	80,351,785	27.00%
Cost of materials, parts, supplies	93,671,679	31.47%
Payments to subcontractors	21,205,813	7.13%
Residual before all non-payroll overhead, rent, insurance, fleet running cost, bad debt, depreciation and owner distributions	102,379,558	34.40%
Value added less annual payroll	95,566,027	32.11%

Neither the 34.40% nor the 32.11% is EBITDA, and neither may be quoted as EBITDA under any circumstances. Both exclude every non-payroll operating cost a contractor bears: facilities rent, general liability and auto insurance, fuel and fleet maintenance, software, licensing and bond costs, sales and marketing, professional fees and bad debt. They are a hard upper bound, and true small-contractor operating margin sits materially below them. **The only legitimate use is falsification** — a margin claim above this band for a sprinkler contractor asserts something the cost structure of the entire containing trade cannot support.

One further Census fact bears directly on the synergy model. Payroll per head runs **\$66,225** for construction workers and **\$75,164** for other employees — **the office and supervisory layer is the more expensive layer per head.** Back-office consolidation is therefore the highest-value-per-head synergy in a roll-up, which is why the per-entity licensing rules below are economically material rather than administrative.

The mid-teens segment margin must not travel down-market. It is a segment figure inside a multi-billion-dollar filer with centralised procurement, a captive insurance function and no owner compensation added back. It is not what a single-branch sprinkler contractor earns, and **using it as an exit-margin assumption for a small independent embeds a synergy that has not been named, costed or timed.**

7.2 Inspection-and-service versus install mix

Disclosed mix , across the businesses a buyer will encounter : inspection , service and monitoring at **54%** of net revenues in 2025 from **40%** in 2021 , against a stated **60%+** objective (APi Group , Q4 2025 earnings call , 2026-02-25 , and investor day , 2025-05-21); "products and systems accounted for approximately 68% of sales from continuing operations and services accounted for 32%" (Johnson Controls FY2025 10-K); monitoring and related services at **84.9%** of revenue (ADT FY2025 10-K); and Fire Protection Services at **7.9%** of total revenue (Cintas FY2025 10-K).

Two independent constructions of the install-versus-service margin differential exist . Both are carried , because they differ by an order of magnitude and the choice between them changes what a mix shift is worth .

Construction one — a filer's own income statement . Johnson Controls splits net sales and cost of sales between products and systems and services on the face of its income statement , the cleanest disclosed differential anywhere in the fire , security and building-systems universe . Population : consolidated , global , HVAC plus fire plus security plus controls — **not a pure fire contractor .**

FISCAL YEAR	PRODUCTS AND SYSTEMS: SALES / COST / GROSS MARGIN	SERVICES: SALES / COST / GROSS MARGIN	DIFFERENTIAL
FY2025	\$16,124M / \$10,543M / 34.61%	\$7,472M / \$4,461M / 40.30%	+568 bps
FY2024	\$15,967M / \$10,677M / 33.13%	\$6,985M / \$4,198M / 39.90%	+677 bps
FY2023	\$15,789M / \$10,736M / 32.00%	\$6,542M / \$3,791M / 42.05%	+1,005 bps

Note the direction of travel : the differential compressed from 1,005 to 568 basis points in two years , because product and system gross margin rose 261 basis points while service gross margin fell 175 . **The FY2025 568 basis points is the current-cycle figure ; the 1,005 basis points is a cyclical peak reached when product margins were depressed , and it is not a structural constant .**

Construction two — fire-specific work-type bands , which imply a differential between testing and inspection at a 50%-plus floor and new construction at 25% to 35% of **15 to 25 percentage points** at the gross line — several times the products-versus-services differential above . The two are not reconcilable and should not be averaged , because "services" in a global product company's income statement is a mixed category spanning warranty , controls , maintenance and parts across HVAC and security while the work-type bands are fire-specific . **The narrow construction is the conservative one and the fire-specific construction is the relevant one ; a model that applies 568 basis points should not describe the result as a fire mix-shift benefit .**

Why install is structurally different , in the same filer's own disclosure . Typical contract period "less than 6 months" , maximum five years ; payment terms of minimum 7 days , standard 30 days , maximum 90 days ; remaining performance obligations of **\$3,605M** at 2025-12-31 of which **74%** is expected within twelve months (APi Group FY2025 10-K) . That balance equals 45.57% of a year's revenue . **It is a project backlog , not an annuity , and it should never be presented as contracted recurring revenue .**

7.3 Labour as the binding constraint

The certification ladder is the moat and the growth constraint in one object . The national certification body runs six fire protection and building systems programmes , of which the inspection certification for water-based systems is the credential the inspection annuity actually runs on . Level I requires "a minimum of 6 months of experience with ... inspection , testing , repair and maintenance activities" for "technicians who perform limited job tasks under direct supervision" ; Level II requires "a minimum of 2 years of work

experience in the inspection and periodic testing of water-based fire protection systems", at least 1 year direct, for "technicians who perform routine inspection and testing tasks under limited supervision"; and Level III requires "a minimum of 5 years", at least 3 years direct, for "technicians who can work independently to perform complex system inspection and testing jobs" (NICET candidate handbook, scope covering "applicable codes and standards, primarily NFPA 25"). The fire alarm ladder runs four levels on the same principle, reaching 10 years including at least 105 months of fire alarm experience at Level IV.

Three cross-cutting requirements convert the experience gates into a hard constraint. Recertification falls due **every three years and requires 90 continuing-professional-development points per certification**, drawn from at least two categories. Work history must be verified by a supervisor "in a position and ha[ving] the authority to directly supervise, inspect, and/or approve" the applicant's work, and verifiers "must be technically competent and cannot be peers or subordinates". Levels III and IV additionally require personal recommendations from licensed professional engineers, Level IV technicians, registered surveyors, architects, fire marshals or code officials, and **recommenders cannot be current or former verifiers**.

A Level III water-based inspection technician cannot be created in under five years, three of which must be direct inspection and testing work. That capability cannot be bought with training spend, cannot be compressed, and cannot be hired away from a competitor without the competitor noticing. **The binding constraint on how fast an inspection platform grows organically is the number of Level II technicians it started the five-year clock with.** The three-year recertification cycle runs the other way in a cost-cut scenario: a platform that stops funding continuing development watches its certified base decay on a known schedule, **which makes training spend a diligence line item rather than a discretionary one.**

Certification-holder counts are not published — nationally, by state or by discipline. The only named certified-headcount disclosure available is **42 NICET-certified and 4 NAFED-certified associates across 15 branches** at ORR Protection, or 2.80 certified individuals per branch. At a national platform servicing more than 8,000 sites a year, that is a usable order-of-magnitude prior for how thin the certified layer is even at scale.

The organised sprinkler-fitter segment has an unusual structure with direct commercial consequences. UA Local Union 669 Road Sprinkler Fitters is a single national local with jurisdiction over sprinkler fitting across the United States. Its membership is **16,631** on the 2025 Department of Labor filing, the primary instrument; the union's own statement of "over 17,000 members", of which "more than 13,000 active journeypeople" and "over 4,000 apprentices", is carried alongside it, a gap of about 2.2% that changes no conclusion, and **no midpoint is taken**. Because jurisdiction is national rather than metro-by-metro, a union sprinkler contractor's labour cost is set by a national agreement structure and manpower can move across state lines without renegotiating jurisdiction. An open-shop platform cannot access that pool. **The union and non-union choice changes cost structure and manpower mobility simultaneously, and the two effects run in opposite directions** — which is why a union-shop target and an open-shop target are not comparable on labour cost alone. The open-shop training counterpart is the American Fire Sprinkler Association, running a four-level apprentice programme. **Neither the union nor the open-shop programme publishes its length or hour requirement**, so apprenticeship duration is not a modellable input on either side. Union density in adjacent filers brackets what a target's posture might look like: approximately 18,000 of 87,000 employees covered by collective bargaining agreements or works councils at Johnson Controls, 20.69%; approximately 900 of 48,300 at Cintas, 1.86%, **which is what a pure open-shop route business looks like.**

Wage levels and inflation, Security and Fire Alarm Systems Installers (SOC 49-2098). The occupation title fuses security with fire and is not a fire-only headcount.

SURVEY VINTAGE	EMPLOYMENT	MEAN HOURLY	MEAN ANNUAL	MEDIAN ANNUAL
May 2019 · May 2021	71,600 · 77,420	\$24.14 · \$25.08	\$50,210 · \$52,170	\$48,970 · \$48,320
May 2022 · May 2023	80,720 · 83,540	\$26.10 · \$27.59	\$54,280 · \$57,400	\$50,130 · \$56,430
2025 wage data	85,900 (2024)	\$28.88	—	\$60,070

Median annual pay rose **24.32%** between May 2021 and the 2025 vintage, a compound annual rate of **5.59%**, with the sharpest single step a 12.57% move between May 2022 and May 2023 and deceleration to 6.45% across the final two years. Employment rose **16.68%** between May 2019 and May 2023 — **the occupation grew and grew more expensive at the same time.**

For sprinkler fitters, no wage series exists, and substituting the containing occupation would be wrong. Sprinkler fitters are classified inside SOC 47-2152, Plumbers, Pipefitters, and Steamfitters, which explicitly "Includes sprinkler fitters". That container reported a median of \$59,880 in May 2021, \$61,550 in May 2023 and \$63,800 in the 2025 vintage across 504,500 employed — growth of **6.55%**, a compound rate of **1.60%**. Over the identical window the alarm-installer occupation inflated at 5.59% and the pipefitter container at 1.60%, a divergence of 399 basis points a year. Either the low-voltage life-safety pool is genuinely tighter, or a 504,500-person container in which sprinkler fitters are a small minority has its aggregate wage set by residential plumbing. The second is more likely, which produces a clean and inconvenient conclusion: **there is no reliable published wage-inflation series for sprinkler fitters, and the pipefitter container must not be used as a proxy for one.** The alarm-installer series is usable directly for the alarm and detection sub-vertical, where the occupation matches the work.

7.4 Licensing as a moat, and as an integration constraint

Most states license the **firm** through a **named individual** — a responsible managing employee or qualifying agent. **That single design choice is why licensing is a genuine barrier to entry, and it is also why it becomes the most underestimated integration constraint in a multi-state roll-up.**

Florida is the clearest worked example of both halves. Under Fla. Stat. § 633.328 (2024): "At least one member or supervising employee of the business organization as designated to the State Fire Marshal by such organization shall be certified under this chapter in order for the business organization to hold a current certificate as a contractor." Two further clauses do the damage. "A certified individual who is the sole contractor on behalf of a business organization may not affiliate simultaneously with another business organization." And if the sole certified individual departs, the organisation has "a grace period of 60 days from the date of termination in which to certify another person under the provisions of this chapter, failing which the certification of the business organization shall expire without further operation of law." The experience gates behind the qualifying certificate are substantial in their own right (Fla. Stat. § 633.318, 2024), running to four years of proven or verifiable experience for Contractors I to III, a certified plumbing contractor licence plus at least 40 contact hours of NFPA 13D training for Contractor IV, and an underground utility or plumbing contractor licence for Contractor V.

Three other states show the same architecture with different mechanics. Iowa requires a contractor licence plus technician and technician-trainee licences with endorsements by system type, and the contractor must name a responsible managing employee with a current qualifying certification. Washington runs four contractor levels, and **its Level U requires NICET Level III** — a direct statutory link from a state licence to a certification level, which converts the five-year clock above into a hard cap on market entry. California requires a Fire Sprinkler Fitter Certification for C-16 qualifiers and journey-level personnel on water-based systems in commercial or multi-family dwellings.

Where this binds on a roll-up, and it is the second half that buyers underestimate.

1. **The qualifier cannot be released.** Florida's 60-day cliff hands the qualifying individual of an acquired Florida entity a licence-extinction option over that entity for two months after any termination. **A retention agreement for the qualifier is not a courtesy; it is a condition of the licence surviving the close.**
2. **Legal entities cannot always be collapsed.** Because a Florida qualifier acting as sole contractor "may not affiliate simultaneously with another business organization", an acquirer running several Florida-licensed entities needs a distinct qualified individual for each. **Entity consolidation undertaken to save overhead can require *more* certified people, not fewer.**
3. **The synergy that licensing destroys is the most valuable one.** Office and supervisory payroll runs at \$75,164 per head against \$66,225 for construction workers, so the back office is the more expensive layer per head. A regime that forces a qualified individual to remain attached to each branch or entity removes the highest-value-per-head synergy in the model — **and it does so quietly, because the licence register is usually built after the synergy model rather than before it.**
4. **Build the licence register before the synergy model.** For every acquired entity in every state of operation: which licence class, which named individual qualifies it, whether that individual is an owner and therefore leaving at close, what the statutory grace period is, and whether the state permits one individual to qualify multiple entities.

Licensing questions are legal questions. **Engage state-licensing counsel in each state of operation before signing**, and ask specifically: does the licence survive the contemplated transaction structure, what is the notification obligation and its deadline, and what is the shortest statutory grace period across the target's footprint.

7.5 Working capital, retainage, capital expenditure and systems

This is the strongest disclosed block in the sector, and **retainage and contract balances are the part a first-time buyer of a contracting business gets wrong**. Population: APi Group consolidated, \$7,911M of revenue, install-and-service mix, global (FY2025 10-K).

ITEM	2025-12-31	2024-12-31	DERIVED
Accounts receivable, net of allowances	\$1,563M	\$1,444M	Days sales outstanding on receivables alone 72.11 days
Contract assets	\$484M	\$453M	Including contract assets, 94.45 days
Contract liabilities	\$694M	\$590M	8.77% of revenue
Retentions receivable, of which beyond one year	\$187M, of which \$48M	\$160M	2.36% of revenue and 11.96% of receivables; 25.67% falling beyond a year
Net contract working capital	\$1,353M	—	17.10% of revenue

Disclosed payment terms run to a minimum of 7 days, a standard of 30 and a maximum of 90. **A fire protection contracting platform should be modelled carrying roughly 72 days of receivables and roughly 94 days once contract assets are included, with about 17% of revenue permanently tied up in contract working capital.** Retainage is the install-side tax in its purest disclosed form: \$187M at year end with a quarter of it collectible beyond twelve months. **An inspection-only book carries materially less of both, which is a second and independent reason — beyond the margin bands — that inspection mix drives value.**

Two traps sit here. First, contract liabilities exceeding contract assets means this filer is billing ahead of cost in aggregate — a favourable position a smaller install-heavy contractor without the same customer mix will not

replicate, and one that must not be assumed into a target's model. Second, a **billing-cycle-time metric is not a days-sales-outstanding metric**. The vendor benchmark showing top performers invoicing within 1.6 days, with a second view of the same report giving 1.7 days for top performers against 5.7 and 11.1 days for middle and bottom cohorts (ServiceTrade, 2024) — it measures how fast an invoice leaves the building. It says nothing about when cash arrives. **Revenue recognition on contracting balances is specialist work**: engage a construction-accounting specialist on the quality-of-earnings scope and ask for over- and under-billings by job, a retainage ageing, and a walk from contract assets to invoiced revenue for the three largest install jobs.

Capital expenditure and fleet — a low-capital, high-working-capital business. Operating cash flow of **\$759M** against capital expenditure of **\$96M** in FY2025 puts capital expenditure at **1.21%** of revenue and **\$3,310** per team member. Property, plant and equipment runs \$738M gross and \$397M net, with "autos and trucks" at **\$138M** gross cost, **1.74%** of revenue, against \$113M a year earlier, leased on 1-to-7-year terms alongside buildings at 1-12 years. Gross truck cost per team member computes to \$4,759, and **that should not be read as truck capital expenditure per technician** for three disclosed reasons: the denominator is total team members rather than technicians, and technicians are a minority of headcount in every filer that splits it; it is gross historical cost rather than replacement cost; and an unknown share of the fleet is leased and never appears in property, plant and equipment at all. **The balance-sheet burden in this sector is receivables and retainage, not trucks**.

Systems. The inspection software stack is the one input in the sector with a fully published price list, and the pricing model is more informative than the prices. One vendor publishes **\$59 Select**, **\$99 Premium** and **\$159 Enterprise**, each "per month • per technician • billed annually", with "Unlimited office users" on all tiers, a five-technician minimum on the entry tier and the certification programme included at the top. Two competitors publish no price, one pricing on "the number of field and office users on your account" and the other disclosing only a 30-technician enterprise threshold. Annualised, the published tiers run **\$708**, **\$1,188** and **\$1,908** per technician per year, and the top tier equals **0.76%** of revenue against a \$250,000 revenue-per-technician assumption, which is an assumption and is registered as one. **The finding is the charging basis — per technician, with office users free**. Software cost scales with exactly the headcount that certification and licensing constrain, and does not scale with the back office a roll-up is trying to consolidate, **so the systems line in an integration model behaves in the opposite direction from the overhead line**.

7.6 What is not measurable, and what to do about it

Four inputs a buyer wants most do not exist in the public record. For each, the useful distinction is whether the gap closes with more research or only with access to a target's own data.

Revenue per technician for fire contracting — a research gap at platform level, a diligence question at target level. No fire protection contracting platform discloses a technician count. Reported headcounts are totals only: approximately 29,000 team members, more than 9,000, approximately 48,300 employee-partners and approximately 87,000 employees at the four large filers. **Every revenue-per-employee figure computable from those is a total-headcount figure**. The single filer that splits its payroll is in the alarm and monitoring sub-vertical: "we employed approximately 12,200 people, including approximately 1,600 direct field solution advisors; 3,100 installation and service technicians; 4,000 customer care professionals; and 700 phone sales representatives" (ADT FY2025 10-K), a technician share of **25.41%** and a field-facing share of **38.52%**. The only defensible per-technician figure in the sector follows: installation, product and other revenue of \$774,520 thousand over 3,100 technicians, or **\$249,845** per technician. **It is not transferable to fire contracting**, and it is not a monitoring productivity measure either, because 84.9% of that filer's

revenue is produced by a central station and a billing system rather than by a truck . At target level this closes immediately : request the payroll register by role and the certification register , and compute it directly .

Route density in every form — a diligence question , and framing it that way is more useful than an estimate . No named , credible , fire-specific source publishes stops per technician per day , drive time as a share of the workday , minimum viable metro density , or revenue per fire inspection route . What exists is whole-company proxies , each labelled by what it measures : **12 , 100** local delivery routes at Cintas as of 2025-05-31 , up 3 . 42% year on year , at **\$808 , 678** of route-serviced revenue per route and **≈83** customers per route , company-wide across all segments and dominated by uniform rental ; **130 . 4** customer locations per technician and **23** technicians per branch at Everon , the first an upper bound because it includes monitoring-only sites needing no visit ; **84 . 7** team members per branch across a North American safety-services platform ; **533** sites per branch at a special-hazard-weighted platform ; and **36 . 0** team members per location across the largest estate . Every input carries a "more than" , "over" or "plus" qualifier , **so all are bounds rather than measurements .**

The closest thing in the record to a minimum-viable-density statistic is not a density figure at all but the branch-margin distribution above . **Route density must be measured in diligence from the target's own dispatch and work-order data . It is not obtainable from the public web , and an estimate would be worse than an acknowledged gap because it would be used .** One research route remains genuinely open : the financial performance representations inside hood-cleaning franchise disclosure documents , which four state franchise registries publish free of charge . Aggregator restatements of those figures circulate without a sample size , a filing year or an attribution to the disclosure item itself , and do not meet the evidentiary bar ; **the registry filings themselves would .**

Fully-loaded technician cost — a diligence question . No source discloses a burden multiplier or a billable-utilisation rate for fire protection technicians , and the two together are what convert a wage into a cost . **No fully-loaded cost figure is stated here , because producing one requires two assumptions that would then be mistaken for evidence .** In diligence the inputs are available directly : payroll register , burden schedule , and billed hours against paid hours by technician for a full year .

Certification-holder counts — partly a research gap , wholly answerable in diligence . The certification body publishes no count nationally , by state or by discipline , so **the size of the certified labour pool — the true constraint on how fast the sector can grow — is unmeasured .** At a single target it is measurable on day one : the certification register with levels , disciplines , expiry dates and continuing-development status , cross-referenced against the state licence register and against which individuals are selling shares .

Two further absences change what a buyer should fund . The composition of an inspection book by contract form is purely a diligence question and the answer sits in one contract file . And whether the pull-through ratio holds outside the one issuer that publishes it is a research question with no answer yet . **A model that treats \$3 to \$4 of service per inspection dollar as a sector constant is extending a single company's disclosure across a fragmented industry , and should carry that as a named assumption rather than as a fact .**

One question remains open that no available source can close : **whether a building that empties keeps getting inspected .** The nearest measure of deferral is a single city's 63% currency rate , which is a cross-section rather than a time series and cannot separate structural non-compliance from cyclical deferral . For a buyer underwriting an inspection annuity through a downturn in commercial occupancy that is a live and unresolved exposure , and **the only way to test it at a target is to trace three consecutive inspection cycles at sites whose tenancy changed .**

PART VIII — INSURANCE AND DEMAND

8.1 The insurance thesis, and why it currently cuts the other way

The standard fire-protection investment narrative runs on a single assumption: a hard property market forces building owners to upgrade fire protection, and the contractor collects. **For the current cycle that assumption is inverted.** Commercial property rates are falling, and a carrier sitting on surplus capacity has less leverage to make a sprinkler retrofit or an alarm replacement a condition of renewal.

Global commercial property rates fell **12%** in Q2 2026, following declines of **9%** in each of the two preceding quarters, while global casualty moved the other way at **+2%**. On the same index, **US commercial property rates fell 13%**, one of five regions posting a double-digit property decline (Marsh, 2026-07-22). On a separate basis, the US broker channel reports the same direction: average premium change across all lines and all account sizes was **-1.2%** in Q1 2026, which the publisher characterises as "a decisive sign of a softened market" (CIAB, 2026-05-13). The account-size split matters more than the headline for a route contractor's customer base — large accounts **-2.7%**, medium **-1.9%**, small **+1.1%**. **Small accounts are the only cohort still absorbing increases, and the large accounts with capital to fund a voluntary upgrade are the ones whose premiums are falling fastest.** The two indices are not comparable and are not combined anywhere in this report: different geography, different line mix, different respondent base.

One segment remains hard. Habitational property is priced at **\$0.20-\$0.40 per \$100** of total insured value for non-catastrophe masonry of newer construction, **\$0.60-\$1.20** for older frame, and **\$1.50-\$4.00+** for catastrophe-zone frame in Florida coastal and California wildland-urban-interface territory, with the share of new habitational placement written in excess and surplus lines now at **30%-40%** against under **15%** a decade earlier (Latent Insurance, 2026-05-22).

What this touches and what it does not is the whole of the thesis. Untouched: the code-mandated inspection annuity, created by code and, in healthcare, by federal conditions of participation. It does not move with the rate cycle, and it is the defensible half of a target's revenue mix across all three sub-verticals. **Exposed: the carrier-driven upgrade cycle.** Retrofit and upgrade demand that depends on an underwriter demanding the work as a renewal condition weakens as capacity loosens. **Install and upgrade backlog attributed to insurance pressure should be underwritten as cyclical, not structural, and separated line by line from the inspection base in quality-of-earnings work.**

8.2 What insurance actually rates on, and what it does not

The published mechanism by which fire-suppression capability enters US property rating is the Public Protection Classification, which grades **more than 40,000** fire-response jurisdictions from Class 1, superior, to Class 10 (ISO Mitigation, undated). "Virtually all U.S. insurers of homes and business property use Verisk's Public Protection Classifications in calculating premiums," and the price of fire insurance in a community with a good classification is "substantially lower than in a community with a poor PPC, assuming all other factors are equal" (Verisk, 2024-03-07).

The scope limit is the point. The classification grades the *public* fire service — department 50%, water supply 40%, emergency communications 10%, plus a community risk reduction bonus of up to 5.5% — **not the building**. It sits upstream of, and separate from, any building-level sprinkler credit. **It generates demand for municipal water and hydrant work, not for sprinkler inspection, alarm monitoring or kitchen suppression.**

Two quantified statements of the premium effect are published, they give different numbers, both are weakly attributed, and they are carried separately rather than reconciled. An ISO-branded handout, undated on its face and hosted at a path dated 2022-05, gives annual premium on a \$100,000 home of **\$894** at Class 10 and **\$373** at Class 5, with a stated saving of **\$433** a year from Class 9 to Class 5 — implying **\$806** at Class 9 and a **58.3%** reduction from Class 10 to Class 5. The same document carries the structural fact that matters commercially: "HOMEOWNER'S RATES DO NOT DECREASE BELOW A CLASS 5." **Residential credit stops at Class 5; businesses continue to benefit down to Class 1**, and that asymmetry is the commercial-property relevance of the whole mechanism. A vendor publication, undated and explicitly self-labelled illustrative, gives bands instead — up to 25% at Class 1–2, roughly 10–15% at Class 3–4, minimal effect at Class 5–6, and surcharges above that — with its own caveat that impacts vary by carrier, line of business and property characteristics. It does not carry weight here.

The finding that matters most for anyone underwriting a retrofit-driven growth story: no carrier or broker publication establishes a quantified premium differential for sprinklered versus unsprinklered commercial risk. The one quantified sprinkler discount figure in the public record is **residential**, four years old, and names no carrier: "discounts as high as 35% are offered for homes with sprinklers," attributed to a poll of property and casualty insurers with no carrier named and no methodology published, conceding on the same page that discounts vary (Home Fire Sprinkler Coalition, last modified 2022-05-18). That absence sits directly under the strongest-sounding claim in the standard fire-protection investment deck. **A model that capitalises insurance-driven retrofit demand is capitalising an unquantified premium.**

The corroborating evidence points the same way. The most on-point owner-facing insurance document available for the building classes this industry sells into — a 2026 habitational market guide — does not mention sprinklers, fire alarms, monitoring or fire protection upgrades as a coverage condition or a rating credit anywhere in its content (Latent Insurance, 2026-05-22). **Construction class is doing the pricing work:** on the stated midpoints, older frame prices at **3.0×** non-catastrophe newer masonry.

Where a buyer needs an insurance answer, buy it from someone licensed to give it. Engage a licensed commercial property broker or an insurance due-diligence specialist and ask three questions on named accounts inside the target's book: whether any submission or renewal in the file shows a quantified sprinkler or alarm credit; whether protection class, as distinct from community classification, appears in the rating; and whether kitchen-suppression standard compliance appears anywhere as a condition of coverage. **Nothing here substitutes for that.**

8.3 The loss evidence, including where it inverts

The loss data that would underpin any carrier credit is published by the standards body, not by a carrier. All figures from Ahrens, *U. S. Experience with Sprinklers* (NFPA, October 2021), data years 2015–2019:

METRIC	VALUE
Sprinklers present in reported structure fires	about 10% of all reported structure fires
Operation rate, where present and fire large enough to activate	92%
Civilian death rate reduction per 1,000 fires, sprinklered against no automatic extinguishing system	89%
Structure fires where sprinklers operated in which only one operated	77%
Average loss per fire, all structures · homes · health care	11% lower · 62% lower · 73% lower
Average loss per fire, warehouses and manufacturing	Higher in sprinklered properties

Read the fourth row precisely : it is a conditional share of the fires in which sprinklers operated , and it describes operation rather than control . Read the loss rows with their occupancy labels attached , **because the last one is not a footnote .**

The warehouse and manufacturing line reverses the property-loss case . The publisher attributes the inversion to smoke damage plus exceptional large-loss incidents . The life-safety case for sprinklers holds across every occupancy in the dataset ; **the property-loss case does not .** It fails in exactly the two occupancy classes where highly-protected-risk underwriting concentrates and where the largest industrial accounts sit . A buyer pitching a loss-reduction story into industrial and logistics accounts should know the industry's own loss statistics do not support it on a property basis there , and should expect a sophisticated risk manager to know it too . **The argument that survives is life safety , business continuity and code compliance — not average loss per fire .**

8.4 The installed base

The commercial building stock against which the inspection obligation runs is sized from the 2018 Commercial Buildings Energy Consumption Survey , the most recent completed cycle : **5,918 thousand buildings** and **96,423 million sq ft** of floorspace , at an average building size of **16,294 sq ft** .

Vintage , stated plainly . Two pages of the same publisher date the same release differently — the table pages state the data were "released September 2021 and revised September 2022 , " the programme landing page states "final results released December 2022 . " Both are carried ; the usable description is a 2018 data year released across the 2021–2022 window . **No 2024 cycle has been released or is underway** , and no timeline for the next full cycle is published . **The installed base for this industry is therefore sized off eight-year-old data , and that is a structural limitation of every model built on it , including this one .**

Age distribution is the foundation of the inspection annuity : **59.7%** of buildings and **55.0%** of floorspace predate 1990 , and **24.7%** of buildings and **28.8%** of floorspace were built in 2000 or later , with both columns of the published partition summing exactly to the totals . Renovation status is the closest available proxy for system age : **45,165 million sq ft — 46.8% —** has had some renovation since 2000 , **43,832 (45.5%)** has had none , and **7,426 (7.7%)** was constructed in 2013 or later , the three categories exhaustive and mutually exclusive .

The survey's one fire-adjacent renovation category is **"Fire , safety , or security upgrade"** , at **19,985 million sq ft** and **570 thousand buildings** (EIA CBECS 2018 , Tables B10 and B6) . **Read the label :** it fuses fire with safety and security , the same definitional problem that defeats the sizing instruments in Part II , and **it does not license a fire retrofit market size .**

No source establishes the sprinklered share of the commercial building stock — precisely the input a retrofit market size requires . The survey does not ask . The nearest proxy is sprinkler presence in reported structure fires , which runs on a different denominator and is biased downward because sprinklered buildings generate fewer reportable fires : nursing home **69%** , hospital **61%** , prison or jail **58%** , manufacturing **52%** , educational **40%** , warehouse **34%** , store or office **26%** , public assembly **25%** , residential **8%** (NFPA , October 2021 , data years 2015–2019) . **These are shares of fires and must not be relabelled as shares of buildings .**

On this evidence the retrofit headroom for sprinkler contracting sits in store , office and public assembly , where three-quarters of fires occur in unsprinklered premises — and those are also the occupancies with the weakest mandate and , in office , the weakest demand backdrop . Health care runs at 61%–69% presence , **so healthcare exposure should be underwritten as an inspection and repair annuity with install upside confined to new build .**

8.5 Occupancy and demographic drivers

Healthcare and senior housing. Two federal regulations create the hardest recurring obligation in the industry, because the consequence of non-compliance is loss of Medicare and Medicaid reimbursement rather than a fine. Long-term care facilities are held to NFPA 101, **2012 edition issued 11 August 2011**, plus four tentative interim amendments; were required to install a supervised automatic sprinkler system "in accordance with the 1999 edition of NFPA 13" by **13 August 2013**; and must "test, inspect, and maintain" it in accordance with the **1998 edition of NFPA 25** (42 CFR §483.90). Hospitals are held to NFPA 101 and NFPA 99, both 2012 editions, with the same **10-hour** impairment rule requiring evacuation of the affected area or a fire watch (42 CFR §482.41). **Note the edition freeze as a diligence item:** a contractor's healthcare book is scoped and priced against those editions, not current ones, and any target with healthcare concentration should be tested for whether its technicians, documentation and pricing are aligned to the editions the federal regulation actually incorporates.

The build side of senior housing is close to dormant. Q2 2026 occupancy was **89.9%**, up 0.4 percentage points, on **639,650** occupied units, with inventory growth of **0.4%** year on year and **fewer than 16,000** units under construction — about 2.25% of an implied inventory of roughly 711,500 units (NIC MAP, published 2026-07-09). The publisher's own framing is that "high occupancy rates and static construction mean fewer new housing options for older adults." **Ageing demographics are a utilisation story here, not a construction story**, so a fire-protection target selling into the segment is an inspection route business with negligible install exposure and should be valued on route density and contract renewal rather than on backlog.

Restaurants. Industry projections for 2026 are sales of **\$1.55 trillion**, real growth of **1.3%** and employment of **15.8 million**, with the publisher "cautiously optimistic about 2026" while noting "persistent cost pressures, such as uneven traffic and rising costs" (NRA, 2026-02-11). **The number that determines route economics does not exist in the public record.** Kitchen suppression and extinguisher routes run on locations, not sales dollars, and no public source publishes total US restaurant locations, gross closures or net unit growth. A route-density model for that sub-vertical has to be built bottom-up from a target's own customer list, permit data and site counts in its actual service territory, and **any seller-supplied market size for this segment should be treated as unsourceable until it is reconciled to that count.**

Warehouse and industrial. Q1 2026: national industrial vacancy **7.0%**, net absorption **40 msf** up 52% year on year, completions **54 msf** down 27%, and **284 msf** under construction, up 6.2% (Cushman & Wakefield, report dated 2026-04-14; the same publisher subsequently headlined vacancy back below 7% on 2026-07-17). Completions down 27% with under-construction stock up 6.2% means **the install pull flattens near-term and re-accelerates on a lag**. Absorption is strong and vacancy is tightening, so the demand signal is intact; the timing is the issue, and **a model that straight-lines warehouse install revenue off current absorption will front-load a pipeline that arrives later.**

Data centres are the largest construction-driven pull in the demand set, and they are announced rather than contracted. Alphabet raised 2026 capital expenditure to **\$195-205 bn** "as it accelerates AI data center buildout"; Meta announced **\$50 bn** for a Louisiana campus expansion to **5 GW** and a 1 GW compute campus in El Paso with BlackRock; AWS added more capacity "than any other company" in 2025, including **1.2 GW in Q4**; one utility's data-centre pipeline passed **8 GW** after deals with Oracle and Google (DatacenterDynamics, July 2026; the single-point capital expenditure figure via Construction Dive, accessed 2026-07-29). The Louisiana campus implies **\$10 bn per GW** of announced capacity, a usable scalar for sizing an announced campus. **It does not convert into contractor-addressable revenue:** the figure is total campus capital expenditure including land, power, shell, mechanical and electrical and IT, and no public source establishes fire protection as a percentage of data-centre construction value, nor the split between clean-agent and pre-action water scope that determines whether the work lands with a sprinkler contractor or a special-hazard

house . Both are gaps to close with contractor references and actual bid documents , not with a published ratio . **The counter-signal arrived in the same week :** one operator cancelled a \$30 bn project (Data Center Knowledge , accessed 2026-07-29) . **Announced capital expenditure is not contracted backlog .**

Office . Two publishers disagree on national vacancy and both are carried : **20 . 2%** for Q1 2026 (Cushman & Wakefield , 2026-04-14) against **17 . 7%** , down 170 basis points year on year , for June 2026 (CommercialCafe , 2026-07-20) — a 250-basis-point gap driven by universe definition , sublease treatment and building-class cut-off rather than by a data error . **The addressable office inspection base sits somewhere between the two , and neither may be asserted alone as the national figure .** Underneath the headline the recovery is Class A only : net absorption was $-4 . 0$ msf in Q1 2026 against four-quarter rolling absorption of $+5 . 2$ msf , with Class A four-quarter rolling absorption at $+18 . 7$ msf . New construction has effectively stopped — $29 . 6$ msf under construction as of June 2026 , about $0 . 4\%$ of stock — while office-to-multifamily conversion reached $11 . 8$ msf in 2025 , "higher than in any prior year" , which is about $0 . 16\%$ of stock . **Conversion is a record rate on a rounding-error base and will not reallocate the office inspection annuity at scale inside a hold period .** The material office risk to route density is deferred inspection in half-empty and mothballed buildings , **and no public source establishes a deferral rate .**

8.6 Third-party market sizing, and why it is not used

Two third-party estimates of the fire protection market are in circulation and quoted widely enough that a reader will have seen them : Grand View Research's *Fire Protection Systems Market* , published June 2023 and last updated May 2026 , and MarketsandMarkets' *Fire Protection System Market* , October 2025 . **Neither is used anywhere in this report , and neither figure is restated here ,** for four reasons . **Neither is US-specific** — both are global , and nothing in either isolates the United States , the only geography this practice underwrites . **Neither is decomposable into the three sub-verticals** — sprinkler is a product line inside "products , " inspection and maintenance is buried inside "maintenance , " and kitchen suppression and clean agent are not broken out at all , so neither can size the three sub-verticals separately , which is the only cut that matters for a buy-box . **One is published to a precision no stated methodology supports ,** at six significant figures on a global estimate , with no traceable methodology on either publisher's public page . **And they do not agree with each other , and one does not agree with itself :** rolling the first publisher's base year forward a single year at its own stated growth rate lands **11 . 47%** above the second publisher's figure for the same year on nominally the same scope , both stand and no midpoint is taken , and the first publisher's stated growth window and the arithmetic that reproduces its own forecast describe different periods .

Market size for this sector has to be built bottom-up — from the installed base above , the occupancy-level obligation , and a target's own route density and contract file — rather than purchased .

PART IX — AGGREGATION CHALLENGES

9.1 The central-station question



The single best diligence question in this market is whether the target owns its UL-listed central station , and if it does not , whose paper the recurring revenue sits on .

The market-level size premium quantifies what the answer is worth . Sellers above \$500 , 000 of recurring monthly revenue averaged 46x monthly revenue against 36x for sellers under \$50 , 000 — **10 turns of recurring monthly revenue , a ratio of 1 . 278x , a 27 . 8% uplift** — inside one source , one methodology and one year (Barnes Associates via SecurityInfoWatch , 2025-08-18) . The mechanism the record gives for that gap is infrastructure ownership : **a buyer that owns a central station removes the wholesale monitoring fee at close , and a buyer that does not carries it as a direct cost for as long as it holds the accounts .**

Approximately 2% of industry recurring monthly revenue changed hands in the acquisition year covered by that keynote , while about 21% of the industry has changed hands over the last four years (Barnes Buchanan via SDM , 2026-02-16) — the accounts in circulation in any one year are a small slice of a base that turns over quickly .

At least one major wholesale central station is sponsor-owned and has changed sponsor recently : Becklar went from BV Investment Partners to Graham Partners on 2024-12-10 with the seller rolling its stake , and is itself consolidating monitoring centres . National Monitoring Center sits inside The Netwatch Group after a merger with Netwatch , Onwatch Multifire and CalAtlantic . COPS Monitoring has acquired the wholesale monitoring business of Security Partners and AlarmWATCH . **Ownership of COPS Monitoring , Rapid Response Monitoring Services and Affiliated Monitoring is not established in the public record** — three top-tier wholesale central stations whose ownership bears directly on who controls the infrastructure under a target's recurring revenue .

Three exposures follow when a target resells rather than owns . The gross recurring revenue is not the margin , because the wholesale fee is a direct cost and the 51 . 2% blended monitoring and services margin in the industry data is not achievable by a pure reseller . The subscriber contracts may not be freely assignable . And the wholesale agreement carries its own change-of-control provisions , **so a transaction can trigger a renegotiation of the cost line under the very revenue being bought .** Buyers that own central stations — among them Everon , Securitas Technology , Zeus Fire and Security with two UL-listed centres , and National Fire & Safety with its own — are the population able to pay the top band .

A sub-threshold recurring share almost always resolves into something other than monitoring . Annualised recurring monthly revenue as a share of FY2025 revenue , computed from company-reported survey data

(SDM 100, 2026), runs from 98.86% at ADT and 54.47% at Kastle Systems and 52.99% at Vector Security, through 37.70% at Zeus, 35.38% at Securitas Technology, 32.13% at Everon, 30.24% at Pye-Barker and 23.65% at Pavion, down to 11.78% at Minuteman, 8.88% at ORR Protection and 6.07% at Security 101. A target in the 30-50% range is a recurring-revenue conversation. **A target under 10% is an earnings conversation, and its "recurring revenue" claim on inspection work is a different and less bankable form of recurrence with no assignable monitoring contract to value.** Special hazard sits structurally at the bottom of that column — low recurring revenue, high engineering content, project-weighted — **and should be underwritten on earnings and backlog.**

9.2 Contract assignability, and the roll-up of the roll-ups

The recurring revenue may not travel with the deal, and there are three distinct places where it can fail to. **The subscriber contract** is the first: whether monitoring agreements are freely assignable is a document-by-document question that determines whether the acquirer buys a contracted stream or an opportunity to resign a customer base, and the record establishes that the question exists and is unresolved at market level, not that any particular answer is standard. **The wholesale monitoring agreement beneath it** is the second, carrying its own change-of-control provisions, inherited as the cost side of the same revenue. **The form of recurrence itself** is the third: where the recurring claim rests on inspection and testing rather than monitoring, there is frequently no standing contract to assign at all, only a service history and a compliance obligation that keeps the customer returning.

Bulk account purchases show what does travel and on what terms. The multifamily transaction moved approximately 200,000 customer units representing approximately \$2.6 million of recurring monthly revenue with **no branch infrastructure, no technicians and no backlog**, and with a non-compete running only through 2028-10-02 (ADT 8-K, 2025-09-15). **Buying accounts is not buying a business, and the two are priced in different languages.** Alarm accounts have historically been bought and sold like receivables precisely because the contract, not the enterprise, is the asset — **and where the contract does not assign, the receivable analogy fails and the multiple built on it fails with it.**

Platforms buy platforms in this market, and platforms are sold in pieces. Both patterns are on the record with named parties. AI Fire has run through four sponsors: founded 2009 as Impact Fire, Caltius Equity Partners 2012, Audax 2017, TruArc Partners 2021 with the seller retaining a stake at exit, Blackstone 2025, with 20 add-ons under the fourth. Performance Systems Integration went Peterson Partners, then The Riverside Company, then Summit Fire & Security on 2025-08-12. Protegis Fire & Safety went Align Capital from 2017, seven add-ons taking it from 6 to 13 branches, then absorbed into Summit Fire & Security on 2022-05-02. Sciens went Huron Capital from early 2016 with ten add-ons, then Carlyle from 2021 with a minority retained. Summit Companies itself went CI Capital, then BlackRock Long Term Private Capital in 2021, then BDT & MSD Partners in 2025, on a base of 82 acquisitions since 1999. Convergent has run eight years and 40-plus acquisitions under Ares without a sale, ending in a continuation vehicle.

Summit Fire & Security has twice been the terminal buyer of another sponsor's finished platform, reaching 126 locations in 37 states after the second. APi acquired CertaSite, a Midwest inspection-first platform that had completed at least 21 acquisitions under its sponsor, with cash on hand. Everon acquired a bulk account book from the corporate seller that had sold Everon itself to Everon's sponsor two years earlier. **One sponsor has run a fire extinguisher platform, a franchised kitchen-exhaust-cleaning platform and a fire inspection platform simultaneously, exiting two of them in 2025 and 2026 — the same house appearing as buyer and seller in the same sub-vertical in the same period.**

The instructive interval is a carve-out sold in pieces. Sentinel Capital Partners acquired Carrier's industrial fire business with a closing date of 2024-07-01 in the seller's FY2024 10-K, at a disclosed enterprise value of

\$1.425B for the four-brand group. **Twenty-one months later** the Marioff water-mist division was agreed to Inflexion, and **twenty-four months** after the same closing date the Autronica unit closed to MSA Safety at a disclosed value of approximately \$555 million. Two of four brands were divested inside 24 months. **A four-brand industrial carve-out was not a hold-and-integrate; it was a separation.**

9.3 What cannot be evidenced about integration

Three things do not exist in the public record, and **each is normally the load-bearing element of a synergy narrative.**

No named post-close margin-uplift case with before-and-after figures. No acquirer in this market publishes what a named acquired business earned before it was bought and what it earned afterwards. What exists instead is growth claims without bases — "approximately quadrupled Adjusted EBITDA" since 2018 across 40-plus acquisitions at one integrator, with no base and no absolute value; a "greater than 35-fold increase in revenue and EBITDA" under a prior owner at another — and operational counts, such as one platform moving from 4 to 14 locations and 64 to 279 technicians. **None of those permit a margin bridge.**

No disclosed synergy target. The Chubb transaction was disclosed at $\approx 13.3\times$ last-twelve-months adjusted operating earnings *including synergies*, but no synergy dollar target accompanied it; the amount implied by the difference between that figure and the same company's disclosed revenue and margin inputs is inference from two disclosed numbers rather than a disclosure. The two 2026 acquisitions closed with revenue contributions disclosed and no earnings, and the incremental margins implied by the guidance raises — 15.0% and 14.1% — could bundle currency, organic revisions, purchase-accounting effects or expected synergies in unknown proportion.

Almost no platform-level organic or same-store metric. The single exception in the record is the disclosure of 19 consecutive quarters of double-digit organic inspection revenue growth and the stated ratio of service work per inspection dollar. **No sponsor-backed platform in this market publishes an organic growth figure, a same-store figure, a retention figure or an attrition figure at platform level.** Segment-level margin exists for public filers, but a segment margin is not an integration result.

Given that, a buyer should decline the synergy narrative and demand the following in its place, all documentable at target level even where the market publishes nothing:

1. **The corporate-cost bridge, shown.** Target earnings before and after allocation, with the allocation itemised. The disclosed template exists: \$158M of segment adjusted operating earnings, less \$(14)M of estimated corporate cost allocation, equals the \$144M the multiple was struck on (ADT 8-K, 2023-10-02). **A target's standalone earnings figure that has never carried its share of overhead is not the denominator the deal should be priced on.**
2. **Monitoring revenue split by owned versus wholesale central station,** with the wholesale fee shown as a line item and the wholesale agreement's change-of-control clause produced.
3. **Annualised recurring monthly revenue divided by revenue, computed from the target's own contract file** rather than from management's characterisation of what is recurring, with a statement of how much of the recurring claim is inspection work rather than monitoring.
4. **Attrition and price-increase history by cohort.** The only market figures available are 3–4% annual increases reported with minimal attrition impact and a monitoring and services margin of 51.2% against 53.9% in 2017 — **a declining-margin backdrop against which a target's own trend is the relevant fact.**
5. **Assignability and renewal terms on inspection contracts,** and the customer-level compliance driver where no contract exists.

3. The acquirer's own before-and-after margin on two named prior tuck-ins , with dates . No acquirer in this market has published this . A buyer underwriting integration is entitled to ask its own operating team for what the market does not disclose , and **an inability to produce it internally is itself a diligence finding .**

PART X — BUY-SIDE IMPLICATIONS

10.1 Where to hunt

The structure of this market points a buyer at three places, in this order. What follows reflects how these questions get decided in practice as well as what the public record supports — selected transactions, 150 acquisitions led or co-led, at a global investment bank and at a world-class private-equity-backed aggregator.

The inspection book in a jurisdiction with mandatory electronic reporting. Where a jurisdiction has mandated third-party electronic reporting, three things are true at once that are true nowhere else: the obligation is enforced rather than nominal, deficiencies are documented on a clock that forces the owner to act, and the currency of every system in the jurisdiction is a matter of record. **That is the only condition under which the repair pull-through can be underwritten from something other than the seller's assertion.** The 63% currency figure comes from exactly such a jurisdiction, which is the point: **the measured shortfall sits where enforcement is strongest, not where it is weakest.**

The extinguisher, kitchen and special-hazard sub-vertical, deliberately, and for the reason the sizing failed. The absence of a published revenue denominator for that layer is a barrier to writing a market-size slide and **an advantage in acquiring.** No aggregator has published a number for sponsors to anchor on, the obligated-site count is large and countable, and the work is route-structured with statutory frequency. The layer within it that is unsized even in this report — clean agent and industrial special hazard — is the one with the highest technical barrier and the fewest qualified contractors.

The interior West and Plains, on evidence rather than on the usual assumption. Alaska is the only state in no verified operating footprint, and states routinely described as open carry named branches from up to four distinct owners. **The correct inference is not that these markets are empty; it is that the mapping is too incomplete to support a whitespace claim,** and that any territory thesis needs a licence-registry pass before capital is committed to it.

What not to hunt on: a metro saturation ranking. Part V sets out why one cannot honestly be built from what is published, and a ranking assembled anyway would be systematically blind to several of the largest estates in the industry.

10.2 Value-creation levers to underwrite

Ranked by how well the evidence in this report supports them.

1. **Repair attach against a fixed inspection base.** The strongest lever, because the trigger is documented rather than sold: **a deficiency found on a mandated visit is a work order the owner has a code duty to close.** This is underwritable from a target's own records as the ratio of repair revenue to inspection revenue, split between electronic-reporting and paper jurisdictions, and the operating defect behind a weak ratio is a detect-and-quote discipline rather than a sales-conversion problem.
2. **Mix shift from install to inspection and service.** The margin differential is real and disclosed in two independent constructions. It is also slow: the one listed acquirer reporting the shift moved 14 points across four years.
3. **Route density in the extinguisher, kitchen and special-hazard layer.** Structurally the right lever for a statutory-frequency route business — and the one this report cannot quantify. It belongs where Part VII puts it, **as a diligence question rather than a research question.**

4. **Price** . Non-discretionary , licensed , statutorily scheduled work with a documented alternative of non-compliance is the textbook condition for pricing power , and one executed national-account schedule shows escalation of 9 . 95% and then 9 . 03% in a competitively awarded multi-site account . Nothing in the record measures realised price movement across fire inspection generally , so **underwrite it as a hypothesis to be tested against the target's own rate history , not as a market fact** .
5. **Central-station insourcing** . Where a target's recurring revenue sits on a third party's paper , bringing it onto owned infrastructure is worth roughly ten turns of recurring monthly revenue at market level . **This is a lever only for a buyer that already owns a listed station or can credibly build one** .

Not on the list : synergies . No named post-close margin-uplift case with before-and-after figures , no disclosed synergy target , and no platform-level organic or same-store metric exists anywhere in the public record for this sector . **A synergy number in a model here is an assumption wearing a fact's clothing** .

10.3 Underwriting guardrails

- **Never blend the multiple populations** . Five are defined in Part VI that are not comparable , and every error in this market's published valuation commentary is a population error . A recurring-monthly-revenue multiple and an earnings multiple are different languages on different denominators .
- **Never apply a large-platform multiple to a tuck-in , in either direction** . The widest spreads in circulation are one company's disclosed ceiling divided into an unsourced trade-press range .
- **Treat "recurring revenue" as a claim to be read , not a line to be accepted** . Ask for the contracts , in full , and sort them by form : written multi-year with an assignment right , annual purchase order , and undocumented habit . Those three behave completely differently in a change of control . A target below roughly a tenth of revenue in genuine recurring monitoring usually turns out , on inspection , to be describing inspection agreements with no assignable contract to value .
- **Establish the central-station answer before pricing anything** .
- **Do not underwrite a retrofit-driven growth story on carrier pressure in the current rate environment** , and do not underwrite one on a sprinklered-versus-unsprinklered premium differential at all , because no carrier or broker publishes one .
- **Do not size a retrofit market** . No source establishes the sprinklered share of US commercial building stock .
- **Confirm the adopted code edition , not the current one** . Scope , and therefore revenue per site , is set by the edition the Authority Having Jurisdiction has frozen , which in the largest lag states is more than a decade behind .
- **Check the licence , then check whether it travels** . The regime that protects the incumbent's margin is the same regime that can strand a book on a qualifying individual who is retiring . Engage licensing counsel in the relevant states on whether the contractor licence and the qualifying-individual registration survive the transaction structure contemplated , and what the re-qualification timeline is if they do not .
- **Retainage and contract balances are where a first-time buyer of a contracting business gets hurt** . Have a construction-experienced accountant model the working-capital unwind under the actual retainage terms rather than on a days-outstanding average .
- **A named target's value is out of scope for this report and for market data generally** . Market-level ranges are context . Anything at the level of a specific business requires a licensed appraiser , and any tax or securities question requires the relevant specialist named at the point it arises .

10.4 Thresholds that change the strategy

Each of these is observable, and each would move the conclusion rather than decorate it.

- **A jurisdiction of scale deletes an existing inspection, testing or maintenance requirement.** One state re-timing a high-rise retrofit requirement is an event; a second deleting one outright would make reversibility a trend and would require the durability of the annuity to be re-underwritten rather than assumed.
- **Commercial property rates return to increase for two consecutive quarters.** That restores the carrier leverage the upgrade-cycle story depends on, and turns the current headwind into the tailwind the industry already claims it is.
- **Any fire or life-safety business files an S-1, or a rating agency publishes an unentitled opinion on one of the named platforms.** Either would supply, for the first time, the renewal and retention disclosure that does not exist today — **and the entire annuity thesis would move from proxy to measured.**
- **The disclosed bolt-on ceiling at the fastest consolidator moves upward.** That is the single cleanest signal that competition at the sub-\$5M-earnings end has begun to erode the entry advantage the thesis rests on.
- **A second well-capitalised consolidator reaches 40-plus acquisitions in a calendar year.** Two buyers at that cadence chasing the same seller profile compresses the bottom of the spread first.
- **An electronic-reporting mandate is adopted by a top-ten metro.** It converts an unmeasured obligation into a documented one across a large installed base at once, and it is the condition under which the pull-through lever becomes underwritable at scale.

10.5 Likely acquirers versus likely sellers

Likely acquirers. The funded and demonstrably active set is unusually crowded for a market this size: the listed strategic that deployed over a billion dollars in a single quarter and holds a published inspection-mix target it has not yet reached; the private platform running the fastest add-on programme in the industry; the platforms whose sponsors entered within the last two years and are therefore early in a hold — Summit under BDT & MSD, AI Fire under Blackstone, Encore under Permira, Guardian Fire Services under Investcorp, Security 101 under Morgan Stanley Capital Partners, FSS Technologies under Lightview; and the permanent-capital and family holders, **who compete for the same assets without a clock and can therefore outlast a fund bidder on process.**

Likely sellers. This side is inference from hold period and nothing more, and it should be read as such. The longest unexited sponsor positions in the register are the natural candidates, together with the manufacturer platform already selling divisions individually rather than as a bundle. Two qualifications matter: **continued ownership could not be confirmed from a primary source for two of the platforms whose hold periods look longest**, so those are candidates on the strength of an absence of news rather than on evidence; and one sponsor in this market is simultaneously an active buyer and an active seller, which makes hold-period logic a weak predictor for its portfolio specifically.

What both sides mean for a buy-side mandate. Every likely seller is a potential source of divested brands, and every likely acquirer is a competing bidder in the metros where coverage is demonstrable. **Neither list is a target list.** The independents that make good acquisitions here are, by construction, the businesses nobody has written about — which is why Part V refuses to build a target board from platform disclosures, and why **a screen against state licence registries is the next piece of work rather than an optional refinement.**

APPENDIX — DATA CONFLICTS, CAVEATS & SOURCE NOTES

A.0 Provenance

Consolidated from twelve research workstreams, each gathered against a defined question and each holding its own source URLs: government sizing; codes and the mandate; the consolidator landscape in sprinkler, suppression and integrated life safety; the consolidator landscape in alarm, monitoring and extinguisher or kitchen roll-ups; operating brand names and domains by platform; unit economics; valuation and the deal record; regulatory, insurance and demand drivers; brand rosters as a gap-fill; sizing of the extinguisher, kitchen and special-hazard sub-vertical; multiples, bank reports and the platform-versus-tuck-in spread; and the inspection annuity quantified. A primary-source verification pass ran across every load-bearing figure and is recorded below.

A.0.1 Corrections applied 2026-07-30 — synthesis adjudication

Seven figures and attributions were carried differently by different workstreams. Each is resolved here, with the source that decided it. Retired values stay named so they are recognisable if they resurface from an older copy.

FIGURE	WAS	NOW	WHY
Summit Companies / SFP Holding sponsor	BlackRock Long Term Private Capital, carried as current	BDT & MSD Partners , majority acquired from BlackRock Long Term Private Capital	Announced 2025-08-04; the prior holder is named as the prior owner throughout
Attribution of the pull-through ratio	A research outlet's note, 2025-08-01	The issuer's own record — investor day 2025-05-21 and the Q4 2025 earnings call 2026-02-25	The outlet attribution does not hold; two issuer sources state it directly
Inspection, service and monitoring share, 40% (2021) to 54% (2025)	Press summary of an unretrievable slide deck	Verbatim from the Q4 2025 earnings call	Issuer statement supersedes a press summary of it
Distinct entities trading as "Guardian"	Fewer	Five	The higher enumeration is the complete one; all five are unrelated and one publishes on two domains
Sciens division count · Encore brand partners and footprint	A summary sentence; a higher partner count and wider state count	31 divisions · 75 partners; 13 states	Counted from the published division table, partner table and locations sitemap; the wider state figure is a sponsor-page claim, named alongside the verifiable footprint
The valuation range quoted for fire platforms	Circulated as a sector fact by four apparent sources	Retired as a valuation input ; retained in §6.6 only as a traced chain	One origin describing prospective bids on a business that did not sell (PE Hub via SDM, 2024-07-15). Two onward attributions do not survive a check of the cited houses' own published figures, which are 11.8x and a 7x-to-10x ceiling

A.0.2 Corrections applied 2026-07-30 — primary-source verification pass

Every load-bearing figure was checked against the issuing body's own instrument. Twelve findings changed the document; a further seven were wording that overstated what the source says.

FIGURE	WAS	NOW	SOURCE THAT OVERTURNED IT
The sector's only disclosed carve-out multiple	11 . 2x against commercial adjusted operating earnings of \$158M	10 . 2x on \$158M before the corporate-cost allocation , 11 . 2x on \$144M after it — both printed in the same exhibit , on an enterprise value of \$1 , 613M	ADT Inc . 8-K EX-99 . 1 , 2023-08-08
The ≈91% retention figure	Attributed to an "Everon investor deck , April 2022"	ADT Inc . , <i>Business Overview and Financial Modeling</i>, April 2022 , measuring ADT's Commercial segment as of 2021-12-31	The deck itself ; Everon did not exist until the rebrand at the GTCR close
Maryland's high-rise retrofit requirement	Described as repealed	Retained and re-timed to "within 12 years of the date of the original violation notice issued by the fire authority having jurisdiction" , with an intent-to-comply filing and mandatory signage	COMAR 29 . 06 . 01 . 07 and 29 . 06 . 01 . 08 , effective 2025-06-23
US commercial property rates , Q2 2026	Not isolated from the global figure	-13% , one of five regions with a double-digit property decline	Marsh , Q2 2026 index , 2026-07-22
Fire retrofit in the national building survey	No renovation category exists	A category exists — "Fire , safety , or security upgrade" , 19,985 million sq ft and 570 thousand buildings — but it fuses fire with safety and security , so the sprinklered share of stock remains unestablished	EIA CBECS 2018 , Tables B10 and B6
What the sprinkler revenue line measures	Revenue of establishments classified as sprinkler contractors	Value of building-sprinkler-installation work allocated across all of the construction sector . Not an establishment classification , so no contractor count can be derived from it	2022 construction questionnaire CC-23820 , Item 23
Single-sprinkler operation	Stated as fires controlled by a single sprinkler head	"In 77 percent of the structure fires where sprinklers operated , only one operated" — a conditional share , and operation rather than control	Ahrens , NFPA , October 2021
The pull-through ratio's basis · the bolt-on ceiling's provenance	A stated ratio · a disclosed multiple	Same values , correctly located : a leadership estimate for US inspection revenues excluding purely route-based service revenue , and an investor-relations disclosure appearing in no SEC filing , bounding a weighted average rather than a series	APi Group investor day , 2025-05-21 , pp . 19 and 45
GF Data's industry taxonomy	Carries no specialty-trade category	Narrowed : the edition consulted pools all industries into eight buckets , none fire or specialty trade , but the publisher separately produces a specialty trade contractor breakout that was not obtained	GF Data , <i>4th Quarter Highlights and Products</i>
Transactions in the sector-dedicated update	A merged count across editions	133 — 73 in the Winter 2025 edition and 60 in the Summer 2025 edition ; deal tempo is edition-specific	Meridian Capital , Winter and Summer 2025
CMS enforcement language	Unqualified	Object and hedge restored : no authority to allow extensions of the August 13 , 2013 deadline , and deficiencies are usually cited at scope and severity D , E or F minimum	CMS S&C-13-55-LSC , 2013-08-16
The two counts of one platform's 2025 acquisitions	Presented as reconcilable on different cut-offs	Both stand . Neither publication states a cut-off date or a counting rule , so the cause of the difference is not established	SDM , 2026-03-17 ; Capstone , 2026-02-02

What the pass confirmed rather than changed . The valuation-range chain in §6 . 6 was checked link by link and every link holds on the publishers' own words . Every GF Data figure , every Census container figure , the Cintas dollar lines to the thousand , the federal 1998 and 1999 standard-edition references , the sprinkler loss inversion in warehouses and manufacturing , and the municipal compliance figures all confirmed exactly as written . **What could not be reached , and is therefore carried as reported rather than verified :** the union

membership filing , the alarm-installer employment series , the current edition designations for five referenced standards , and the specialty-trade breakout above .

A.1 Reconciled data conflicts

Where two live sources disagree , both values are carried in the body and cited . **Nothing below is averaged , and no midpoint is invented .**

ITEM	CONFLICT	TREATMENT
Road Sprinkler Fitters Local 669 membership	"Over 17 , 000" (union) against 16 , 631 (2025 US DOL filing)	Both carried ; the filing is the primary instrument and the union figure is named alongside it
Municipal systems found compliant	The city states 90% ; its own counts give 1 , 933 ÷ 2 , 083 = 92 . 80%	Both carried . The 63% currency figure reconciles exactly and is the one the argument leans on
US office vacancy	20 . 2% (Cushman & Wakefield , Q1 2026) against 17 . 7% (CommercialCafe , June 2026)	Both carried with the methodology difference named ; a definitional gap , not a data error
APi Group FY2025 revenue	\$7 , 911M (issuer) against a lower aggregator figure	Issuer figure used ; the aggregator value is the prior year mislabelled and does not appear here
One platform's 2025 acquisition count	57 (company) against 41 (sector tracker)	Both stand ; the cause of the difference is not established and neither figure appears alone
Pye-Barker locations · AI Fire footprint	253 stated against 256 sitemap URLs · 20 states (company) against 18 states (sponsor)	Both carried in each case ; unresolved
Carve-out adjusted operating earnings	\$158M against \$144M	Both carried . The difference is corporate-cost allocation , and it is why a carve-out multiple must state which earnings figure it was struck on
Recurring-monthly-revenue band vintage	2024 in one account of the keynote , a 2025 average in another	Both carried ; the bands are market aggregates attributed to no named transaction
Building stock survey release	"Released September 2021 and revised September 2022" against "final results released December 2022"	Both carried
US restaurant unit count	701 , 875 employer establishments (2022) against "more than 1 million outlets" (2026) against "nearly 750 , 000"	All carried ; the universes differ and no single count is asserted
Global third-party market sizing	Two publishers 11 . 47% apart on the same year	Both carried in §8 . 6 and neither used anywhere
Semiannual hood-cleaning cost · sprinkler sample-test interval · fire pump no-flow frequency	Two operator price guides materially apart · two published intervals for fast-response heads · weekly against monthly on different editions	All carried , none averaged ; the binding value is named where one binds

A.2 Caveats

Primary-source verification has run on the load-bearing figures , and not on every figure . The pass recorded above opened the issuing body's own instrument for each figure carrying weight in the argument , and it changed twelve of them . Figures outside that set remain traceable rather than verified — every one appears in a named source and every computed figure appears in Derivations with its arithmetic , but **a figure faithfully carried from a source that is itself wrong survives a traceability check unchanged .** One open item could still move a conclusion : GF Data publishes a specialty-trade contractor breakout that was not obtained ,

and if it carries the size bands then the statement that no benchmark closer than all-industries exists would need revising .

Two of three sub-verticals are not sized , and this report says so rather than filling the gap . Alarm , detection and monitoring has a ceiling ; extinguisher , kitchen and special hazard has a floor that the arithmetic itself indicates is low . **No combined market total appears anywhere in this document , and one should not be constructed from its parts .**

The fragmentation distribution is a container distribution . It measures trade groupings that fuse fire with adjacent work . It supports a statement about how the containing trades are structured ; it does not license one about the size distribution of fire contractors .

Geographic coverage in Part V is incomplete by a known margin , and that part states which platforms it is blind to . No saturation index , share-of-metro figure or territory ranking should be built on it without a second source .

The consolidation map is a map of owners , not a screen . It records who owns what as of 2026-07-29 and why a name match fails in both directions . **It has not been run against a candidate board , it cannot establish that any named company is unowned , and the absence of a business from it is not evidence of independence .**

The installed base rests on a survey now several years old . That is a structural limitation of any model built on it , this one included .

Vendor-published figures are attributed to their publisher wherever they appear . Three categories recur : electronic-reporting platform statistics published by the platform's operator , contractor and franchise price guides published by contractors , and public-company trading multiples computed by data vendors rather than reconciled to any issuer's own definition of adjusted earnings .

Two figures in the body are open at the time of writing in the ordinary sense that the series refreshes : the commercial insurance rate trajectory and the listed trading panel , whose data dates are given per row .

A.3 Primary source families

Government and official statistics . US Economic Census tables and API endpoints ; the Code of Federal Regulations ; state administrative codes and fire-marshal rules ; state licence registries ; Department of Labor union filings ; the federal commercial buildings energy consumption survey ; national education , hospital and long-term-care facility counts ; occupational employment and wage statistics .

Codes and standards bodies . Model fire and building code adoption charts and edition text ; consensus standards for water-based systems , alarm and detection , portable extinguishers , commercial cooking operations , clean agents and special hazards ; municipal fire codes and adopting ordinances ; certification programme candidate handbooks .

SEC filings and issuer disclosures . Annual and quarterly reports , current reports , subsidiary exhibits across multiple vintages , registration statements , earnings-call transcripts , investor days and company newsrooms .

Market research and industry data . Middle-market transaction databases with size-banded multiples , sector M&A updates , portfolio-mark studies , trade-association research and fire-loss studies .

Trade and financial press . Sector trade outlets , national newswires and financial press , with the outlet named wherever a figure reaches print through it .

Vendor-published benchmarks , interest disclosed . Electronic-reporting platform statistics , contractor and franchise price guides , software-vendor benchmark reports , and data-vendor computations of listed multiples .

A.4 How to read the figures, and where they came from

Everything in this report is drawn from publicly available information . The sources are US government statistical releases , SEC filings and issuer disclosures , codes and consensus standards , published market-research and trade-association output , trade and financial press , and the public websites and press releases of the companies named . Each is cited where it is used and listed in the Sources section below .

No proprietary or confidential information was obtained or used in preparing this report . Nothing here derives from a confidentiality agreement , a data room , management access , or a client engagement . No company named in this document provided information for it .

Every figure in the body sits in one of three classes . The body does not label them , because a reader should not have to read a footnote to reach a sentence . The convention is :

CLASS	WHAT IT MEANS	HOW TO RECOGNISE IT
Reported	A named publisher states the figure . Government series , filings , standards bodies , research houses , trade press .	The publisher and date appear alongside it .
Verified	Checked against the primary source on the publication date — the table , the release , the filing itself .	Also carries its publisher ; the verification record is A . 0 . 2 above .
Derived	Arithmetic on reported figures , not published anywhere .	Registered in Derivations below with inputs , working and assumption .

One distinction the body does observe , because it changes what a number means . Where a transaction figure reaches print through trade press citing unnamed sources , with the parties declining to disclose terms , it is public but it is not a disclosure . The outlet is named wherever one appears , and in this sector that covers most large transaction figures .

On the multiples shown . Market-level multiples and ranges are market context , not target pricing . No multiple is applied to a named private company's earnings anywhere in this document , no enterprise value is estimated for one , and nothing here is an appraisal or should be read as a valuation of a business a reader might transact with . Five populations that are not comparable are defined in §6 . 1 and are not blended .

Where the figures are least stable . The commercial insurance rate series refreshes quarterly and has moved materially in each of the last three quarters . The listed trading panel carries per-row data dates spanning 2026-06-07 to 2026-07-29 . The size-banded transaction benchmark runs only through 2025-09-30 . Ownership of privately held platforms changes without announcement , and A . 1 and A . 2 name the positions that rest on an absence of news .

The correction record . Corrections are recorded in A . 0 . 1 and A . 0 . 2 above rather than quietly absorbed . Each entry states what the figure was , what it became , and the named source that overturned it .

Sources

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Derivations

Figures below appear in no source and are arithmetic on figures that do. Each states its inputs, its arithmetic and its assumption.

FIGURE	INPUTS	ARITHMETIC	ASSUMPTION
≈75 systems — non-compliant count, Burlington VT	686 systems tracked; 89% in full compliance, both published by the reporting platform's operator	$100\% - 89\% = 11\%$; 686×0.11	That "in full compliance" on the platform and "current on required ITM" are the same predicate. If the platform's test is narrower, the true non-current share is higher
63.03% / 92.80% — municipal currency and compliance	1,313 and 1,933 systems against 2,083	Division	None. The city states 63% and 90%; the first reconciles exactly, the second does not, and both stated values are carried
11 contractor site events a year	Code intervals for one wet-pipe sprinkler system on a riser with a backflow preventer, one monitored alarm, extinguishers and one moderate-volume kitchen hood system	$4 + 2 + 1 + 2 + 2$	The building configuration is an assumption and must be replaced with the target's site mix; the frequencies are not. Excludes 3-, 5- and 6-year events and all deficiency repairs
0.4115% / 0.9375% — sprinkler line as a share of construction	\$12,018,607 thousand against \$2,920,771,250 and \$1,281,526,572 thousand	Division	That the kind-of-business allocation is complete across the sector, as the questionnaire requires
≈16,070,500 extinguishers and the 8.57-24.11 million band	CBECS 2018 floorspace of 96,423 million sq ft against the codified maximum floor area per unit at each hazard class	Division at each class; central case between the bounds	Code-minimum spacing. Excludes manufacturing and industrial floorspace, multifamily common areas, vehicle fleets, marine and buildings under 1,000 sq ft
\$1,078.8M - \$2,599.9M — partial recurring service revenue	16,070,500 extinguishers at \$15-\$30 annual plus 6- and 12-year cycle pricing; 737,325 kitchens at a semiannual single-hood price	Multiplication and summation of two layers	A floor, not an estimate. Omits wet-chemical suppression service, clean agent and special hazard, all equipment, all installation, recharge, cabinets, signage and mounting
15.7% - 37.9% — implied share test	\$817.463M of disclosed fire protection revenue, halved, against the floor band	Division at each end	That half of the disclosed fire line falls inside this sub-vertical. A falsification device: the implied share is not credible against a highly fragmented market, which is why the floor reads as low
56.4% — extinguisher against sprinkler licences, Nevada	84 against 149	Division	Licences, not firms; one firm may hold several; one state on a list four years old

FIGURE	INPUTS	ARITHMETIC	ASSUMPTION
74.16% / 1.58% — sub-10-employee and 100-plus shares	Census employment-size bands against entire-year establishments	Summation and division	A container distribution across plumbing, HVAC and fire sprinkler together ; it licenses nothing about fire contractors specifically
10.3% — pull-through repair as a share of invoiced dollars	\$822M of repair revenue tied to recurring inspections against \$8,000M of invoices	Division	Denominator spans fire and mechanical contractors on one platform ; numerator is pull-through repair only . Not a fire-only ratio and not comparable to the service-per-inspection-dollar ratio
+9.95% / +9.03% — executed contract escalation	\$87,576, \$96,290 and \$104,979 across three years	Year-on-year change ; the three sum to the stated \$288,845 total	One executed multi-site institutional account , not a market price index
7.63 / 7.87 years — implied residential customer life	13.1% and 12.7% gross attrition	Reciprocal	Constant-hazard attrition , which real books do not exhibit . An upper-bound approximation , not a cohort life
84.0% / 98.9% — annualised recurring revenue on two denominators	\$359M end-of-period recurring monthly revenue $\times 12 = \$4,308\text{M}$, against \$5,129M and \$4,354M	Division	Annualising a point-in-time month assumes the year-end run rate held across the year
15 to 25 percentage points — work-type gross-margin spread	Testing and inspection at a 50% floor against a new-construction band of 25%-35%	Subtraction at each band endpoint	Uses the stated band endpoints and takes no midpoint of either
+568 / +677 / +1,005 bps — products against services gross margin	Segment sales and cost of sales as disclosed on the face of the income statement	Gross profit $\div$ sales at each segment , then subtraction	Consolidated global mix spanning HVAC , fire , security and controls — not a fire contractor and not a work-type differential
16.79% / 15.95% / 47.33% / 16.72% / 71.33% — segment margins and fire share	\$916M on \$5,456M ; \$765M on \$4,797M ; \$542.4M and \$191.6M on \$1,146.0M ; \$817.463M against \$1,146.0M	Division	As reported ; the route segment contains fire protection plus uniform direct sale , so fire protection is strictly smaller and not separately disclosed
72.11 / 94.45 days ; 17.10% ; 2.36% / 11.96% ; 25.67% — contract working capital	\$1,563M receivables , \$484M contract assets , \$694M contract liabilities , \$187M retentions of which \$48M beyond a year , on \$7,911M revenue	Standard days-sales and share arithmetic	Year-end balances , not average balances ; an average-balance calculation would differ
45.57% — remaining performance obligations against revenue	\$3,605M against \$7,911M	Division	A point-in-time obligation balance against a full year of revenue . A project backlog, not recurring revenue
1.21% / \$3,310 / 1.74% / \$4,759 — capital intensity and fleet	\$96M capital expenditure and \$138M gross autos and trucks on \$7,911M revenue and $\approx 29,000$ team members	Division	Denominator is total team members , not technicians ; numerator is gross historical cost ; leased vehicles are excluded from property , plant and equipment entirely
\$249,845 — revenue per installation and service technician	\$774,520 thousand of installation , product and other revenue over 3,100 technicians	Division	One alarm-and-monitoring filer . Not transferable to fire contracting , and not a monitoring productivity measure

FIGURE	INPUTS	ARITHMETIC	ASSUMPTION
5.59% / 1.60% — wage inflation, two occupations	Median annual pay, May 2021 to the 2025 vintage, for each occupation	Compound annual rate	The 2025 medians come through a different publication path than the earlier vintages. The pipefitter container is not a sprinkler-fitter wage
27.00% / 31.47% / 7.13% / 34.40% / 32.11% — cost structure	Census receipts, payroll, materials, subcontract payments and value added for the containing trade	Division against total receipts	Neither residual is an operating margin. Both exclude every non-payroll operating cost. A hard upper bound whose only use is falsification
\$66,225 / \$75,164 — payroll per head	Annual payroll for construction workers and other employees against first-quarter employment for each	Division	Divides an annual payroll numerator by a first-quarter employment denominator, which is how the Census publishes these variables. Relative cost per head, not exact annual compensation
\$708 / \$1,188 / \$1,908 and 0.76% — software cost per technician	Published monthly per-technician tiers × 12; top tier against a \$250,000 revenue-per-technician assumption	Multiplication, then division	The \$250,000 denominator is an assumption taken from the order of magnitude of the only disclosed installation-revenue-per-technician figure in the sector, and is not a fire contracting figure
3.83x / 3.00x and ≈7.49x / ≈5.86x — recurring-revenue multiple conversions	46x and 36x monthly multiples; 51.2% monitoring and services gross margin	Division by 12; then by 12 × 0.512	Applies a 2026-reported industry average margin to 2024/2025 transaction multiples. Struck before any selling, branch, general, administrative or corporate cost, and not earnings multiples
≈21.15x / ≈\$275 / ≈\$13.00 — the disclosed bulk-account transaction	≈\$55,000,000 for ≈200,000 units representing ≈\$2.6M of recurring monthly revenue	Division	All three inputs are stated as approximate and propagate their imprecision. One population only: bulk residential multifamily accounts
≈3.01x — revenue multiple on the CertaSite transaction	\$271M total consideration against ≈\$90M FY2025 revenue	Division	The numerator is total consideration transferred, not an enterprise value struck debt-free, so the true ratio is higher if debt was retired at close and this is a floor
11.201x / 10.209x — the carve-out multiple on two denominators	\$1,613M against \$144M and against \$158M	Division	Both printed in the seller's own reconciliation; the disclosed figure is struck on the post-allocation denominator
1.609x / 1.297x / 1.239x — size premium inside one methodology	6.4x against 10.3x and 8.3x by enterprise value band; 6.7x against 8.3x by target earnings	Division	The only size premium available measured inside a single dataset, method and period
over \$2.77M — implied minimum average acquired earnings per bolt-on	\$233M of consideration across 14 businesses at a weighted average strictly below 6.0x	\$233M ÷ 6.0, then ÷ 14	A ceiling divided into a total yields a floor, so both figures are minima and the gap to any benchmark is wider than shown
\$3.0M → \$16.64M — average consideration per bolt-on by year	Programme aggregate consideration ÷ deal count, per year	Division	Deal counts are exact in the disclosure; dollar totals are approximate, and the deck and the filings differ by \$6M on one year

FIGURE	INPUTS	ARITHMETIC	ASSUMPTION
15.47 turns — disclosed entry ceiling against the listed multiple	A disclosed sub-6x entry ceiling against a 21.47x vendor-computed trading multiple at 2026-07-28	Subtraction	The denominator is a ceiling , so this is a lower bound . It bridges a private entry threshold and a public equity multiple , and neither prices the other
10 turns / 1.278x / 27.8% — the recurring-revenue size premium	46x against 36x	Subtraction and division	Both sit inside one source , one method and one year , and neither is attributable to a named transaction
98.86% down to 6.07% — annualised recurring revenue as a share of revenue	Company-reported recurring monthly revenue × 12 ÷ FY2025 revenue , per company	Division	Annualising a point-in-time December figure against a full-year revenue figure overstates the ratio where recurring revenue grew during the year , which acquisition-led platforms did
59.7% / 55.0% / 24.7% / 28.8% / 16,294 sq ft / 46.8% / 45.5% / 7.7% — building stock shares and average size	Published age and renovation bands for buildings and floorspace against the totals	Summation and division ; both age columns and the three renovation categories sum exactly to the published totals	The published bands are non-overlapping , which the exact sums support
Implied unsprinklered share of fires , by occupancy	100% less the published sprinkler-presence figure per occupancy	Subtraction	The denominator is fires , not buildings , and sprinklered buildings generate fewer reportable fires , so the sprinklered share of the building stock is higher than these figures imply
≈711,500 units and ≈2.25% — senior housing inventory and construction intensity	639,650 occupied units at 89.9% occupancy ; fewer than 16,000 under construction	Division	The published occupancy rate and occupied-unit count share the same universe
≈7,400 msf and ≈0.16% — office stock and conversion share	29.6 msf under construction published as about 0.4% of stock ; 11.8 msf of conversion	Division	The 0.4% input is rounded to one significant figure , so the implied stock carries wide error bars and the conversion share is an order of magnitude
\$806 and 58.3% — implied Class 9 premium and Class 10-to-5 reduction	\$894 at Class 10 , \$373 at Class 5 , a stated \$433 saving from Class 9 to Class 5	Addition and division	Implied values from one undated handout on a \$100,000 home . Residential , and the document states rates do not decrease below Class 5
3.0x — habitational frame against masonry rate multiple	Midpoints of \$0.60-\$1.20 and \$0.20-\$0.40 per \$100 of insured value	Division	Midpoints of published indicative bands , not filed rates
\$10 bn per GW — data-centre capital intensity	\$50 bn against 5 GW of announced campus capacity	Division	Total campus capital expenditure including land , power , shell , mechanical and electrical and IT . Sizes a campus , not a contractor's revenue
11.47% — gap between two third-party global sizings	One publisher's base year rolled forward a year at its own stated growth rate , against the other publisher's figure for the same year	Division	Exists solely to quantify the disagreement . Not a market size , and used in no sizing in this report

What we don't know yet

A named gap is worth more than a confident guess, and in this market several of the gaps are more decision-relevant than the figures around them.

- **The fire share of alarm, detection and monitoring.** Both revenue instruments and the occupational series fuse fire with burglar at the definition level. The sub-vertical has a ceiling and no size, and no published source separates them — so **any alarm-side sizing a seller presents is either a vendor figure on a different scope or an unsupported allocation.**
- **The clean-agent and industrial special-hazard layer, in units and in revenue alike.** So is restaurant wet-chemical suppression service: a statutory twice-yearly obligation at 737,325 sites is missing from the extinguisher and kitchen arithmetic entirely, because no restaurant or commercial hood-suppression semiannual service price exists in the public record and the only published suppression price is an engineered detector-count price that would be a category error applied to a restaurant kitchen.
- **Any inspection-book renewal, retention or attrition rate from a fire contractor.** Not disclosed by any participant, listed or private. There is no fire or life-safety-services S-1 in EDGAR, so the document that would normally settle it does not exist, and credit-rating opinions on the named platforms are entitlement-gated rather than absent. **The single commercial proxy carried here has no published definition attached to it.**
- **The composition of an inspection book by contract form** — written multi-year with an assignment right, annual purchase order, or undocumented habit. Nobody publishes it, and it is the most commercially decisive unquantified variable in the industry. It is a diligence question rather than a research one, and **the answer sits in one contract file.**
- **Route density in any form** — stops per technician per day, drive-time share, minimum viable metro density, revenue per inspection route. The only figures in circulation are vendor marketing resting on uncited attributions, and none is carried here. One route remains genuinely open and unwalked: the financial performance representations inside hood-cleaning franchise disclosure documents, which four state registries publish free of charge.
- **Revenue per technician for fire-protection contracting, and certification-holder counts** nationally, by state or by discipline. No filer discloses a technician count against a fire contracting revenue line, and the certification body publishes no counts — so **the size of the certified labour pool, the true constraint on how fast the sector can grow, is unmeasured.**
- **Whether a mothballed office building keeps getting inspected.** No source measures deferral of inspection, testing and maintenance. That is the live question on the annuity's durability in a market where two publishers disagree on office vacancy by 250 basis points, and **it is answerable only inside a target's own book across three consecutive inspection cycles.**
- **The national share of legally inspectable systems that are current, and the sprinklered share of US commercial building stock.** Two instrumented jurisdictions are on the record and they are not a sample, so the top-down compliance-gap pitch cannot be sourced and the single-city figure carried here must not be extrapolated. The survey that sizes the stock does not ask about sprinklers, and its one fire-adjacent renovation category fuses fire with safety and security — **so any retrofit market size requires an input that does not exist.**
- **The referenced-standard editions each model-code edition freezes.** The edition-freeze mechanism is the load-bearing link in the whole regulatory case, and the specific mapping is evidenced by a single fire

district's adoption instrument and one trade-association statement rather than by the referenced-standards chapter itself . **Confirming it in a target's footprint is a legal determination , not a research task .**

- **Fire-specific transaction multiples at any size tier .** Established as absent rather than merely unfound : eight houses , thirteen publications , and the one house with a sector-dedicated update lists 133 transactions across two editions with a value on none . Alongside it , the industry-agnostic benchmark this report leans on publishes a specialty-trade contractor breakout that was not obtained , **and that breakout could narrow the gap .**
- **Where the sweeps behind this report stop .** Four items could not be reached at all and are carried as reported rather than verified : the union membership filing , the alarm-installer employment series , the current edition designations for five referenced standards , and the specialty-trade breakout above . Ownership states in Part IV are as of 2026-07-29 and privately held platforms change hands without announcement , **with two positions resting on an absence of news rather than a primary source .** The size-banded transaction benchmark runs only through 2025-09-30 . The commercial building survey is a 2018 data year . And a fire code rule hearing scheduled for 2026-07-14 in one large state sits inside the window between the underlying research and this publication , **with no outcome in the record here .**

Three routes to closing parts of this are identified and unwalked , and each is a defined piece of work rather than a dead end : a Census API key unlocks the product-line tables that would split extinguisher servicing out of its containing industry code ; four states publish franchise disclosure documents free of charge , and the financial-performance item in a hood-cleaning or extinguisher franchise disclosure is the best available route-economics evidence anywhere ; and a deduplicated pass across the fifty state licence registries would produce the fire-specific establishment count that no federal instrument publishes , and would give any territory claim the independent second source it currently lacks .

Published 10 August 2026 . First buy-side assessment of US fire and life safety for this practice ; it supersedes nothing .

Ownership of privately held platforms , brand rosters and commercial insurance pricing change monthly in this market , and adopted code editions change on each jurisdiction's own clock . Re-verify at engagement time .